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James

James 1:1

Section 1:1: James greeted his readers

In this first section, James introduced himself and greeted the people to whom he was writing.

Before you begin to translate this section, consider what is the natural way to begin a letter in your language. Consider also how closely you should follow that in your translation.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greetings from James (NLT)

Greeting (GW)

James writes to the Jewish Christians

1:1a

James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ I, James, a servant/slave of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ,
- ¶ I, James, am writing this letter. I serve God and Jesus Christ our^(incl) Lord/Master.
- ¶ I who write this am James. I serve God and Jesus. He/Jesus is the supreme/high Chief and Christ/Mes-siah.

James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ:

In an ancient Greek letter, it was normal for the writer to mention his own name first. So James began this letter with his own name. However, in some languages, starting with James' name will not make it clear that James was the writer of the letter. It may be necessary to say this explicitly. For example:

This letter is from James, a slave of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ. (NLT)

In some languages, it is not usual for a person to talk about himself in the third person. In these languages, it may be necessary to say:

I, James, am writing this letter. I am a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ.

I am James. I am writing this letter to you. I am a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ.

James: James was one of Jesus' younger brothers. He was also one of the leaders of the church in Jerusalem. He is mentioned in Matthew 13:55, Mark 6:3, and various other places in the NT. It is important to spell the name James the same way here as you did in those passages.

For more information about James, see the section called "The person who wrote the letter" in the Introduction.

a servant of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant also means "slave." This normally refers to someone who was owned by another person. He worked for his owner without receiving pay.

The phrase servant of God (or more often "servant of the Lord") is often used figuratively in the Old Testament to describe the relationship that God's people have to him, their master. It refers to someone who submits to God, serves God, and is devoted and loyal to God.

People often despised servants or slaves. But when someone called himself a servant of God, as James did here, he was not ashamed of it. If you have more than one word to describe servants or slaves, choose the one that is most appropriate to be used in this positive sense that describes a believer's relationship to God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

a slave of God (NLT)

a worker of/for God

In some languages, it will be best to translate the word servant as a verb. For example:

I serve God

belong to God

submit to God

and of the Lord Jesus Christ: James also called himself a servant of the Lord Jesus Christ.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means someone who has authority over someone or something. Here it is a title that identifies Jesus as God, the one who has supreme authority.

Some other ways to translate Lord are:

Master

Owner

supreme Chief/Leader

In some languages, it may be necessary to add a word like “our” before Lord. For example:

our Master/Chief

For further suggestions on translating Lord in James, see Lord in the Glossary.

Christ: The word Christ is sometimes used as a title and sometimes as a name. Even when it is used as a name, it has the same meaning that it has as a title. Here in James, the word Christ probably functions as a title more than as a name. This is based on the position taken in these Notes that James addressed this letter to Jewish Christians for whom the title “Christ” (or “Messiah”) would have had significant meaning. It is also based on an assumed early date for the book of James (sometime between AD 50 and AD 62), a time before “Christ” came to be established as a name. See, for example, McCartney, page 79, and the Translator’s Handbook, page 8, (which agrees that “Christ” would have been a title to early Christians of Jewish background though the Handbook takes the position that James wrote to Christians in general, Jewish and Gentile alike).

The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior.

Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

Messiah

Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer-King whom God appointed

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

the Christ, he comes from God

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the one whom God had promised to send. He would be both king and savior.

1:1b

To the twelve tribes of the Dispersion: Greetings.

- greet you^(plur) twelve tribes/clans of Israel scattered outside our^(incl) homeland.
- I greet you^(plur) Jewish believers who are living in other countries.

To the twelve tribes of the Dispersion: Greetings: In some languages, it may be natural to place the word Greetings before the phrase saying whom James was greeting. For example:

Greetings to the twelve tribes scattered all over the world. (CEV)

It may also be necessary to use a verb that means “greet” rather than the noun Greetings. For example:

I greet the twelve tribes scattered among the nations

I say “hello” to you twelve tribes scattered among the nations

To the twelve tribes of the Dispersion: Most scholars interpret the phrase the twelve tribes to refer to Christians. A small group of scholars say that James was writing to all Jews. For more information, see

the section called “The people to whom James wrote” in the Introduction. However, there are two ways to interpret which Christians this phrase refers to:

1. It refers to Jewish Christians who were scattered in other countries. The twelve tribes was a common way to refer to the Jews. Here it refers to Jews who were Christians. For example, the NLT says:

I am writing to the “twelve tribes”—Jewish believers scattered abroad.

(NLT)

1. It refers to both Jewish and Gentile Christians. Certain passages describe Christians as true or spiritual Israel. (See, for example, Galatians 3:7 and Galatians 3:29). Christians are of the Dispersion in the sense that they do not live in heaven which is their true homeland. For example, the GNT says:

to all God’s people scattered over the whole world (GNT, NCV, GW)

Most English versions translate this phrase literally and do not make it clear to whom the phrase refers. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) We are following a majority of Bible scholars, though opinion is split on this issue. and make this interpretation clear either in the text or in a footnote.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Make it explicit that the phrase the twelve tribes refers to the twelve tribes “of Israel.” For example:

to the twelve tribes/clans of Israel who are scattered among the nations

to the people of Israel who are scattered among the nations If you do this, you should include a footnote to explain that the twelve tribes refers to Jewish Christians.

- Make it explicit that the phrase the twelve tribes refers to Jewish Christians. For example:

to Jewish believers who are scattered among the nations

the twelve tribes: The phrase the twelve tribes refers to the descendants of Jacob’s twelve sons, whom God renamed as Israel. These people all spoke the same

language and all considered themselves to belong to the same ethnic group.

In some languages it is more natural to call them:

clans

sections/divisions

of the Dispersion: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Dispersion refers to certain times during the Jews’ history, when they had been forced to flee from their country. Many of them still lived in other (non-Jewish) countries. These are the people who would normally be referred to as the Dispersion.

However, James was probably writing to Jewish Christians. So he might also have meant the Jewish believers who had been forced to leave Jerusalem because they had been persecuted for their faith. See Acts 11:19 for an example.

The word Dispersion means that these people were living outside of their country or home areas. It does not mean that these people were living far apart from each other.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

dispersed throughout the world (REB)

spread outside of their homeland

living in other countries

James 1:2

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:2–4

James taught that Christians should rejoice when persons or situations test their faith. When such tests occur, Christians learn how to persevere, and they become more mature in their faith.

1:2a

Consider it pure joy, my brothers,

- ¶ Count it all joy, my brothers, (ESV)
- ¶ My brothers and sisters, be^(plur) very joyful/glad
- ¶ My fellow believers, make^(plur) it a reason/occasion to be very happy

Consider it pure joy, my brothers: Here in Greek, James switched from speaking about his readers in the third person to addressing them directly. Make sure it is clear to your readers that the expression my brothers refers to the same people as “the twelve tribes” in 1:1b.

Consider it pure joy: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Consider it pure joy is literally “Consider it all joy” (as in the NASB). This means “Regard trials as something to rejoice about” or “Think of trials as occasions for joy.” This refers to joy with no sadness mixed with it at all. James wanted his readers to think about their trials as positive events that God allowed for their good.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

be very happy (GW)

be glad (CEV)

let it be an opportunity for joy (NLT96)

my brothers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as brothers is the term commonly used in the New Testament to refer to other believers in Jesus. This term emphasizes that all believers belonged to God’s family. James used this term to identify with his audience and to show his closeness with all believers. You may have a different term of address in your language which establishes a feeling of closeness with your audience. If so, consider using it here.

Although James used a masculine form, he was not intending to exclude women. In your translation, you

should use a word or phrase that does not exclude women.

Some other ways to translate this are:

my fellow believers

My brothers and sisters (NET)

my relatives/siblings in Christ

my Christian friends

James tended to use a term of address (like my brothers) when he was introducing a new topic. Here he introduced the topic of trials. You may have another natural way in your language to introduce a new topic. If you do, you could use it here.

Notice that the BSB places the phrase my brothers in the middle of 1:2. This follows the Greek text. If it is more natural in your language to place it at the beginning or end of the sentence or verse, consider doing that here. For example:

My brothers and sisters, be very happy... (GW)

1:2b

when you encounter trials of many kinds,

- when you^(plur) encounter all kinds of tests,
- when you^(plur) have all sorts of problems/troubles that test your faith.
- when all kinds of trials/difficulties come to you.^(plur)

when you encounter trials of many kinds: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as encounter means “experience.” Some other ways to translate this clause are:

whenever you face trials of many kinds (NIV)

when you encounter various trials (NASB)

when all kinds of trials come your way (GNT)

trials of many kinds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as trials of many kinds refers to various types of difficult situations that occur in a person’s life and test his faith. These can include both external problems. The following commentators interpret *πειρασμοῖς* as referring primarily to problems and diffi-

culties: Mayor, page 32; Ropes, pages 133–134; Davids (1982), page 37; Hiebert, page 72; Laws, page 51; Moo (1985), pages 59–60; Martin, page 15. like persecution and internal temptations The following commentators interpret *πειρασμοῖς* as applying primarily to temptations or assaults of evil: Alford, page 275; Huther (but doubtfully), pages 41–42; Mitton, page 19; Adamson (1976), page 53: “trying assaults of evil.” from Satan. The Greek term for trials includes the meanings of both testing and temptation.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

when you^(plur) experience all kinds of problems that test your faith

when you are tested in different ways (GW)

when you have many kinds of troubles (NCV)

General Comment on 1:2a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 1:2. For example:

^{2a}My brothers and sisters, ^{2b}when you have many kinds of troubles, ^{2a}you should be full of joy. (NCV)

James 1:3

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:2–4

James taught that Christians should rejoice when persons or situations test their faith. When such tests occur, Christians learn how to persevere, and they become more mature in their faith.

1:3

This verse describes in more detail how Christians should think about the tests of their faith.

1:3a

because you know that

- because/for you^(plur) understand/realize that
- You know that (CEV)

because you know that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because you know introduces the basis for the command in 1:2a. James told his fellow believers to rejoice when they face trials (1:2a–b) because such trials have good effects. Trials develop perseverance in the person who is tested (1:3c).

This word also implies that James’ readers already understood that when their faith was tested, the result would be perseverance. So James was reminding them of this truth. Several commentators suggest that this phrase should be understood to mean “you should realise that”: Adamson (1976), pages 52, 54; Tasker, page 40; Hiebert, page 74. Rather similarly: Huther, page 42. R. F. Weymouth translates “Be assured that” and C.K. Williams “remember.” The German versions Luther 1964 revision, 1984 revision (but not 1975 revision), and Zürcher Bibel, and the French version Bible de la Pléiade translate with an imperative (which could be translated as “and recognize that”). Hiebert states (page 74): “The present tense participle indicates that his readers were not ignorant of the truth being set forth, but they had to continue to realize it in personal experience.” However, the following commentators support the interpretation of the BSB: Alford, page 275; Davids (1982), page 68; Martin, page 15. Laws (page 49) translates “knowing.” Many commentators do not discuss the point.

Some other ways to translate this are:

because you^(plur) realize

because you understand

because you are aware

You know that (CEV)

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis before the command (1:2a). See the General Comment on 1:2–3 at the end of 1:3c for an example.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the readers.

1:3b

the testing of your faith

- having your^(plur) faith tested
- when your^(plur) faith in Jesus is tested and proved/ found to be genuine,
- when you^(plur) have trials/difficulties to do the wrong thing and you continue to trust/believe in Jesus/ God,

the testing of your faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testing refers to the process of testing to prove that something was genuine. Here the phrase probably refers to persecution that tests whether a person was really loyal to Jesus as God's Messiah. Because of persecution, some Jewish Christians were tempted to abandon their faith in Christ and return to their Jewish religion.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

when your faith is tested (NLT)

these troubles test your faith (NCV)

when you have difficulties and you^(plur) continue to believe/trust in Jesus/God

when you are tested and you prove that you are loyal to Jesus

your faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faith refers to trusting in Jesus, relying on him, and being committed to him. It is based on the belief that Jesus is the Messiah and that he could save them from their sins.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

your^(plur) trust in Jesus

your loyalty/commitment to Jesus

If it is more natural to translate this word as a verb, do so. For example:

whether you^(plur) truly trust Jesus

that you really believe

if you are loyal to Jesus

See believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

1:3c

develops perseverance.

- causes you^(plur) to develop the ability to persevere.
- you learn to endure. (CEV)
- you^(plur) begin to be patient.

develops perseverance: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as develops perseverance means “produces the ability to continue to do something despite difficulties.” In this context, it means “produces/increases the ability to continue to believe firmly, even when difficulties arise.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

produces endurance (NET)

you learn to endure (CEV)

teaches you to continue/persist

teaches you patience

If there is an idiom in your language to express this idea, consider using it here.

General Comment on 1:2–3

In some languages, it is more natural to give the basis for the command (1:3) first, and then give the command itself (1:2). For example:

^{3a}You know that ^{3b}the testing of your faith ^{3c}develops perseverance. ^{2a}So, my brothers, consider it pure joy, ^{2b}when you encounter trials of many kinds.

James 1:4

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in

him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:2–4

James taught that Christians should rejoice when persons or situations test their faith. When such tests occur, Christians learn how to persevere, and they become more mature in their faith.

1:4a

Allow perseverance to finish its work,

- Perseverance must grow
- Learn^(plur) to endure everything.
- Become^(plur) the kind of people who are patient in/ during every trial

Allow perseverance to finish its work: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Allow perseverance to finish its work is a figure of speech called personification. Here, perseverance is told to finish its work as if it were a person. Perseverance finishes its work in the sense that our ability to persevere becomes fully developed in our lives. We develop into the kind of people who habitually persevere/endure our trials. We must develop this characteristic so that we will be mature and complete (1:4b).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

let endurance have its perfect effect (NET)

when your endurance is fully developed (NLT)

In some languages, such personification is not possible. Some other ways to translate this phrase without personification are:

you must learn to endure everything (CEV)

Learn to be patient during each trial/difficulty

Continue to believe/trust in God/Jesus during your trials

Persevere more and more until it becomes a habit

1:4b

so that you may be mature and complete,

- in order that you^(plur) may become mature and fully developed,
- Then you^(plur) will be spiritually mature and have the complete character that God wants
- so that you will be completely mature (CEV)

so that you may be mature and complete: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces a purpose clause. You should persevere (1:4a) so that you will become a mature, complete believer (1:4b).

Another way to connect 1:4a and 1:4b is:

Then you will be mature and complete (GW)

mature: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mature means to be “mature,” “complete,” or “fully-developed.” Here it refers to a person who is spiritually mature and whose character has completed its full development.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

strong in character (NLT96)

fully developed (NJB)

men of mature character (JBP)

complete: The Greek word that the BSB translates as complete has a similar meaning to the word translated mature (in the note above). This second word refers to a person whose character is entirely what God intended it to be. He is not someone who is mature in some ways but not mature in others.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

whole in all aspects/parts of his character

your character will be what God desires

In some languages, it is more natural to combine the two ideas of “mature” and “complete.” For example:

completely mature (CEV)

1:4c

not lacking anything.

- and not lack any good quality.
- and nothing good will be absent.

not lacking anything: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not lacking anything also means “not needing anything.” This means that no good quality is absent from the person’s character. It does not refer to lacking money or material possessions.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

not deficient in any way (NJB)

you will not lack anything in your character

and will demonstrate/show only good qualities/
traits

This phrase expresses the same idea as “complete” in 1:4b. James often restated the same idea in positive and negative form for emphasis. For another example see 1:6b, “believe and not doubt.”

James 1:5

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:5–8

In this paragraph, James encouraged his readers to ask God to make them wise. They needed wisdom from God to know what to do while experiencing trials that test their faith. God will answer this prayer if they fully trust God when they pray. But if they do not fully trust

him or if they have divided loyalty, God will not answer their prayers.

1:5a

Now if any of you lacks wisdom,

- ¶ If any of you^(plur) does not have wisdom,
- ¶ Anyone who is not wise

Now if any of you lacks wisdom: This clause is in the form of an “if” statement, but James was not wondering if anyone lacked wisdom. He knew that all his readers needed wisdom in order to be successful in enduring trials (1:2).

If a literal translation of if would make your readers think that James did not know if anyone needed wisdom, you could say:

Those of you who need wisdom

He who does not have wisdom

lacks: The word lacks here indicates that a person does not have wisdom or does not have enough wisdom. He also realizes that he does not have it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

do not have

need (CEV)

wisdom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wisdom refers to understanding what is right and good, and doing it. A person who has wisdom is one who chooses to behave the way God wants. He acts wisely. When he is tempted to behave in the wrong way, he resists.

In some languages, it may be necessary to translate this word as an adjective. For example:

If any of you is not wise enough

If any of you needs to become a wiser person

If any of you needs understanding to do what is right and good

1:5b

he should ask God,

- you^(plur) should ask God to give you some.

- should ask God to make him wise, and God will help/teach him.

he should ask God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as he should ask is a command addressed to the person who needs wisdom. In order to obtain wisdom, a person must ask for it.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

let him ask God (RSV)

must ask God (NJB)

he: The pronoun he refers to any person who lacks wisdom. This is the person whom James referred to in 1:5a. Depending on how you have translated 1:5a, it may be necessary to use the pronoun “you” “we^(incl)” or “they” rather than “he.” For example:

you should ask God (CEV)

they should ask God

we^(incl) should request God

1:5c

who gives generously to all without finding fault,

- God gives abundantly to everyone without blaming them.
- For God is generous. He gives what we^(incl) need to anyone asking for it. He does not criticize/reproach anyone for asking.

There are several ways to connect 1:5c to the rest of 1:5. See the General Comment on 1:5a–d at the end of 1:5d for some examples.

who gives generously to all without finding fault:

This clauseThe NIV and other English versions translate this Greek participial phrase as a descriptive (or non-restrictive) relative clause. describes the character of God. He generously gives good gifts to people, and he does not criticize them for asking. James said this to encourage people to ask for wisdom.

In some languages, it will be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

For God gives generously to all without finding fault.

It may be natural to begin a new sentence here because:

1. 1:5a–d is a long sentence in both the Greek and the BSB, and it may be natural in your language to divide it into several shorter sentences.
2. a clause beginning with the word “who” might imply that one God gives generously and another God does not give generously.

gives generously: The Greek word that the BSB translates as generously means that God gives “without hesitation,” “freely,” and “unconditionally.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

gives without reserve

gives bountifully

If your language needs to say what God gives, you can say:

generously gives good things

abundantly gives what we need

to all: The word all here refers to all people.

without finding fault: The phrase that the BSB translates as without finding fault means “does not criticize, reproach, or blame.” God does not criticize those who ask him for wisdom, because he is pleased that they have come to him for help.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

without scolding (NJB)

He will not resent your asking. (NLT96)

won’t correct you for asking (CEV)

He will not reprimand/criticize you when you ask

1:5d

and it will be given to him.

- So if you^(plur) ask for wisdom, it will be given to you.
- (1:5d was placed above at the end of the second meaning line in 1:5b)

it will be given to him: The word it refers to wisdom. The verb will be given is passive. God is the one who

gives wisdom. So there are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

wisdom will be given/granted him

- Use an active verb. For example:

he will give you wisdom (NCV)

God will cause him to become wise.

In some languages, “wisdom” is not something that “is given.” Some other ways to translate the word given are:

God will teach him to be wise

God will help him to be wise

General Comment on 1:5a–d

One of the challenges in translating 1:5 is to decide how to connect the “who” clause in 1:5c to the rest of the verse. Some possibilities are:

- Follow the Greek order, but begin a new sentence. For example:

^{5a}Now if any of you lacks wisdom, ^{5b}he should ask God for it. ^{5c}God gives generously to all without finding fault. ^{5d}So if he asks for wisdom it will be given to him.

- Put 1:5c first. For example:

^{5c}God gives generously to all without finding fault. ^{5a}So, if you lack wisdom, ^{5b}you should ask God for some, ^{5d}and he will give it to you.

- Put 1:5c last. For example:

^{5a}If any of you need wisdom, ^{5b}you should ask God, ^{5d}and it will be given to you. ^{5c}God is generous and won't correct you for asking. (CEV)

James 1:6

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going

through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:5–8

In this paragraph, James encouraged his readers to ask God to make them wise. They needed wisdom from God to know what to do while experiencing trials that test their faith. God will answer this prayer if they fully trust God when they pray. But if they do not fully trust him or if they have divided loyalty, God will not answer their prayers.

1:6a

But he must ask

- However, when someone asks for wisdom,
- When you^(plur) ask God to make you wise,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces an additional requirement for a person to receive wisdom. The person who wants to be wise must:

1. ask God (1:5b)
2. believe and not doubt (1:6b)

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

And

In addition

This conjunction does not indicate a contrast with 1:5.

he must ask: The words he must ask refer back to “he should ask” in 1:5b. In 1:6a James went on to tell his readers how they should ask for wisdom.

he: The pronoun he refers to the same person as in 1:5a. Consider whether it would be more natural here to use “he,” “they,” “we” or “you.” Refer back to your translation of 1:5 and be consistent.

1:6b**in faith, without doubting,**

- he must believe/trust in God/Jesus and not waver in that trust.
- you^(plur) must be firm/constant in your faith/trust and committed to God/Jesus.
- you^(plur) must truly/firmly trust in God/Jesus.

in faith, without doubting: There are two ways to interpret the clause in faith, without doubting:

1. The person must believe/trust in God and Christ with his whole heart. He must be firmly committed to God and to Jesus as the Messiah. He must not trust anyone else or anything else, and he must not waver in his commitment. For example, the NLT says:

be sure that your faith is in God alone (NLT)

1. The person must believe that God will answer his prayer for wisdom. He must not be uncertain whether God will give him wisdom or not. For example, the NLT96 says:

be sure that you really expect him to answer (NLT96)

Most English versions are ambiguous, and there is good support among the commentators for both interpretations. Interpretation (1) is supported by Mayor, page 39 (he compares 4:4 and Matthew 6:24); Ropes, page 140; Hiebert, page 84; Davids (1982), page 73; Moo (1985), page 64; Mitton, page 31; Tasker, page 42. Interpretation (2) is supported by Alford, page 277; Huther, page 50; Adamson (1976), pages 57–58; Laws, page 57. So if you can leave your translation ambiguous here, you should do so. However, if you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretation (1) fits well with the idea of “the testing of your faith” in 1:3b. It also fits well with the description of the person as “double-minded and unstable in all his ways” in 1:8a–b.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he must firmly trust in God/Jesus and not doubt/
waver

he must trust in God/Jesus without any hesitation

See also the note on “your faith” at 1:3b and see believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

Notice that in faith, without doubting is another positive statement followed by its negative restatement (See the note on “not lacking anything” at 1:4c). Together they emphasize that complete faith is necessary.

Another way to translate this expression is:

truly believe/trust

without doubting: The Greek word that the BSB translates as doubting can also be translated as “waver.” It means “continue to change one’s mind or commitment.” Though most English versions translate with the word “doubt,” many commentators explain the meaning as having to do with a wavering allegiance to God or Jesus. See, for example, Davids (1982), page 73; Lenski, page 530–531; Moo (2000), page, 60–61; McCartney, page 90–91; and Ropes, page 140–141. McCartney in particular says: “James does not mean that a believer may never have a measure of uncertainty regarding whether something is God’s will; rather, he is condemning a lack of commitment, a divided loyalty, or an indecision or hesitancy that questions the integrity of God.” (91). David DeGraaf argues that the Greek word *διακρίνω* never refers to intellectual uncertainty in his article “Some Doubts about Doubt: The New Testament Use of *Διακρίνω*.” (Journal of the Evangelical Theological Society 48:733–755) This refers to not being firm and constant in one’s commitment to trust Jesus as God’s Messiah.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

nothing wavering (KJV)

not waver in his trust/commitment

not continually changing his mind about trusting Jesus

not have two minds/hearts about this

1:6c**because he who doubts is like a wave of the sea, blown and tossed by the wind.**

- For anyone who wavers is like an ocean wave that the wind blows and tosses around.
- He who continues to change his mind about this is as unstable/unreliable as the rough water of the sea/lake that the wind blows back and forth.

because: The conjunction because introduces the basis for James' command in 1:6b. A person who asks God for something must believe and not doubt/waver (1:6a–b), because he who doubts/wavers is like a wave (1:6c).

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary to introduce the basis for James' command. For example:

^{6a}But when you ask for something, ^{6b}you must have faith and not doubt. ^{6c}Anyone who doubts is like... (CEV)

he who doubts is like a wave of the sea, blown and tossed by the wind: The phrase is like a wave of the sea, blown and tossed by the wind is a simile. In this simile, a person who doubts/wavers is compared to a wave. They are similar in that neither one is stable. A wave is never stable or still because the wind blows it around in different directions. A person who wavers is not stable because he keeps changing his mind about what he believes.

One way to translate this simile is to make explicit how a person who doubts/wavers is similar to a wave. For example:

a person with divided loyalty is as unsettled as a wave of the sea that is blown and tossed by the wind. (NLT)

the person who wavers is always changing what he believes. He is like a wave that always changes as it is blown and tossed by the wind

a wave of the sea: The phrase a wave of the sea refers to the action of the water in a sea moving up and down, and back and forth in relation to the surface.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

- Describe waves. For example:

the moving of the water on the sea/lake

the constantly changing water of the sea

the swells of water in a sea

- In areas where waves and the sea are well-known, the word wave may include the idea of sea. It may not be necessary to add the phrase of the sea. For example:

wave

- In areas where there are no large bodies of water, it may be possible to translate this phrase simply as:

water

blown and tossed by the wind: The Greek words that the BSB translates as blown and tossed are passive. There are at least two ways to translate them:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

blown and tossed around by the wind (NET)

- Use active verbs. For example:

that the wind blows and throws around

In some languages, it will be more natural to use one expression for the two verbs in the phrase blown and tossed by the wind. For example:

that the wind blows in every direction

The wind causes the waves of the sea to go in every direction

tossed around in a storm (CEV)

blown: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blown refers to the way the wind can move and lift the surface of the water in many different directions.

tossed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tossed is similar in meaning to the word translated as blown. The picture is of the water being thrown into the air by the wind.

James 1:7

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:5–8

In this paragraph, James encouraged his readers to ask God to make them wise. They needed wisdom from God to know what to do while experiencing trials that test their faith. God will answer this prayer if they fully trust God when they pray. But if they do not fully trust him or if they have divided loyalty, God will not answer their prayers.

1:7–8

Some English versions (RSV, GNT, CEV, and NCV) combine 1:7–8. Other English versions follow the Greek more closely and separate the two verses. Compare the two models below.

^{7a}That man should not think ^{7b}he will receive anything from the Lord; ^{8a}he is a double-minded man, ^{8b}unstable in all he does. (NIV)

⁷⁻⁸Such doubters are thinking two different things at the same time, and they cannot decide about anything they do. They should not think they will receive anything from the Lord. (NCV)

You should follow the model that is most natural in your language.

1:7

In Greek, 1:7 begins with a conjunction that the RSV translates as “For.” The BSB has left this conjunction implicit. This word introduces a further basis for James’ command in 1:6b that a person should ask in faith without wavering. In other words, when someone asks God for something, he must believe and not waver (1:6c):

1. because he who wavers is like a wave of the sea (1:6c)
2. and because that man (who wavers) should not think that he will receive anything from the Lord (1:7a–b).

You should begin this verse in a way that your language uses naturally to introduce an additional basis for a command.

1:7a

That man should not expect

- Such a person should not think
- A person who wavers should not expect

That man: The phrase That man refers to a person who doubts. It does not refer to any specific person. The word man refers to a person of either gender, male or female. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

that person (NET)

a person like that

should not expect: The Greek word that the BSB translates as expect means “regard something as probably true,” or “think, assume, presume.” So the phrase should not think means that a person “should not assume” that something is true.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

must not expect (NJB)

must not suppose (RSV)

1:7b

to receive anything from the Lord.

- that he will receive/get anything from the Lord God.
- that the Highest Lord/Master God will give him anything.

to receive anything from the Lord: In some languages, it will be more natural to translate this clause by making the Lord the subject. For example:

the Lord will give him anything

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “a master,” or “one who is in authority.” Here, the Lord refers to God the Father, since God is mentioned in 1:5b. Also, Jesus generally taught that prayers should be addressed to the Father in his name (John 15:16; also Matthew 6:8, Matthew 7:11, 18:19). An exception is found in John 14:13–14 where Jesus says he will do whatever his disciples ask in his name. In some translations, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

he will receive anything from the Lord God

he will receive anything from God

See also the note on Lord at 1:1a and Lord in the Glossary for more translation advice on translating this word.

James 1:8

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:5–8

In this paragraph, James encouraged his readers to ask God to make them wise. They needed wisdom from God to know what to do while experiencing trials that test their faith. God will answer this prayer if they fully trust God when they pray. But if they do not fully trust him or if they have divided loyalty, God will not answer their prayers.

1:8a

He is a double-minded man,

- He has two hearts/minds,
- He keeps changing his mind,

In 1:8a, James continued to describe “the one who doubts/wavers” whom he first mentioned in 1:6b.

He is a double-minded man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as double-minded is literally “double-souled.” This word describes someone who wants to go in two directions at once. He wants to please God, yet at the same time he wants to please the world.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he has two hearts/minds

thinking two different things at the same time (NCV)

loyalty is divided between God and the world (NLT)

a person who cannot decide who to obey/follow

he is not able to make up his mind

If your language has an idiom for this way of thinking, consider if it would be appropriate here.

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man here normally refers to a male. However, it is not intended to exclude women. In this context, it may be translated as “person.” For example:

person (GW)

they (NCV)

1:8b

unstable in all his ways.

- and he is not dependable.
- and people cannot depend/rely on him.

unstable in all his ways: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unstable in all his ways means “is not reliable in any of his ways” or “is uncertain in making decisions.” Someone who is unstable in his behavior is someone who starts to do a certain thing but does not continue steadily with the same course of action. As soon as he encounters a difficulty, he changes and does something else. Therefore, people cannot depend on him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

inconsistent in every activity (NJB)

a person cannot depend on him in anything he does

vacillates in everything he does

James 1:9

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These

trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God’s wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:9–11

Even if a Christian has a low position in society, he can rejoice. He can rejoice because, in God’s opinion, he is in a high position. Similarly, a Christian who is rich should have God’s opinion about himself. Although rich people are generally given high status because of their riches, rich Christians should rather value a low position and humble attitude. They should remember that our lives on earth are short and that riches will not last.

The theme of section 1:2–11 is that Christians should continue to trust God/Jesus when they have various kinds of tests/trials. Poverty is a kind of trial. It is also the result of the trial of being persecuted. Riches too may be a kind of test of faith. They test whether the Christian will trust God or his money. And for rich Christians who had lost wealth and status because of their faith in Christ, they should think of this in a positive way.

1:9a

The brother in humble circumstances

- ¶ A believer who is lowly/unimportant
- ¶ Believers who are poor (NLT)

The brother: The word brother refers to any believer, whether male or female. Notice that although James used a singular noun, he was not referring to one person in particular. He was referring to poor believers in general. Consider whether it is more natural to use a singular or plural term here in your language.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the believer (NET)

fellow believers

Any of God’s people (CEV)

The plural form of this same word occurs in 1:2a.

in humble circumstances: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in humble circumstances literally means “lowly” (as in the RSV). It refers to someone who is in a low position in society and whom others consider to be unimportant. It includes the idea of such a person being poor. So the person in humble circumstances is contrasted to “the one who is rich” in 1:10a.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

who are poor (GNT)

who is unimportant

who has a low status

1:9b

should exult in his high position.

- should be glad/joyful that he is raised/honored by God.
- should rejoice because/that they are important to God.

should exult: The Greek word that the BSB translates as should exult usually means “boast.” In other words, it usually refers to talking about something that you are proud of. It can have either a positive or negative meaning.

Here it is clearly positive, and it refers to a way of thinking. Lowly, poor believers should “think very well of” or “highly value” their high position. This is because God thinks of them very highly and will reward them in the future.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

be glad (GNT)

think well/highly of

highly value

rejoice (KJV)

in his high position: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in his high position refers to his spiritual status as a Christian. Although other people may not

consider a poor believer important, he is still important to God. This is what should give him pride and pleasure.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

that he is important to God

in his high status as a Christian

for God has honored them (NLT)

James 1:10

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:9–11

Even if a Christian has a low position in society, he can rejoice. He can rejoice because, in God's opinion, he is in a high position. Similarly, a Christian who is rich should have God's opinion about himself. Although rich people are generally given high status because of their riches, rich Christians should rather value a low position and humble attitude. They should remember that our lives on earth are short and that riches will not last.

The theme of section 1:2–11 is that Christians should continue to trust God/Jesus when they have various kinds of tests/trials. Poverty is a kind of trial. It is also the result of the trial of being persecuted. Riches too may be a kind of test of faith. They test whether the Christian will trust God or his money. And for rich Christians who had lost wealth and status because

of their faith in Christ, they should think of this in a positive way.

1:10a

But the one who is rich should exult in his low position,

- But a rich believer should be glad that he is lowered/humbled by God,
- But rich believers should rejoice when God humbles them,

But the one who is rich: The clause But the one who is rich contrasts with 1:9. However, there are two ways to interpret the clause the one who is rich:

1. It refers to believers who are rich, in contrast to the ones who are poor (1:9). James was warning rich believers not to put their confidence in or highly value riches. For example, the GNT says:

the rich Christians (GNT, REB, GW, CEV and probably BSB, NIV, NLT, NCV) Mayor, pages 43–44; Ropes, pages 145–146; Mitton, pages 36–37; Adamson (1976), page 61; Hiebert, pages 91–92; Moo (1985), page 68; Lenski, page 534; Tasker, page 43.

1. It refers to unbelievers. James was speaking about rich people who were generally evil and not believers in Jesus, like the ones described in James 2:6–7 and 5:1–6. He said that they will be condemned. For example, the NASB says:

the rich man (NASB, NET) Alford, page 278; Huther, pages 55–56; Laws, pages 62–64; Davids (1982), pages 76–77; Martin, pages 25–26; Dibelius, pages 84–85; Stulac, pages 190–201.

Some English translations can be understood either way (ESV, RSV, NJB, KJV, JBP). The choice between interpretation (1) and (2) is very difficult. Some translators may prefer to translate in a way that can be understood as either (1) or (2). For example:

the rich (ESV)

rich people

If you must choose one interpretation, or if you prefer to choose one interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions and many commentators follow that interpretation.

Some ways to make it clear that the one who is rich is also a brother are:

the rich brother

Rich believers (GW)

the rich Christians (GNT)

the one: Like “the brother” in 1:9a, the one here refers to rich believers in general. Consider whether it is more natural to use a singular or plural term here in your language.

should exult: The phrase should exult does not occur in Greek. However, it is clear from the parallel structure in 1:9b that readers should understand the same phrase here. So the BSB has supplied these words.

As noted in 1:9b, the Greek word that the BSB translates as should exult often means “boast.” But the Bible teaches that we should “boast” or “highly value” things that people generally have a low opinion of. Some of these things are weakness (2 Corinthians 12:5), knowing God (Jeremiah 9:24), and sufferings (Romans 5:3). Here James says that rich believers should “think well of” or “highly value” their low position.

Some other ways to translate this are:

be glad (GNT)

think well/highly of

highly value

rejoice

If possible, use the same word for both the lowly brother (1:9b) and for the rich brother.

in his low position: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in his low position refers to:

1. a humble attitude. God causes rich men to become humble so they understand that they need him to save them. Rich believers also become humble as they realize that their wealth does not make them important. They learn to highly value things that most people think of as lowly like serving others and being mistreated for the sake of Jesus.
2. losing their wealth and high status when they were persecuted for being believers in Jesus.

If possible, translate this in a general way that could include both (a) and (b).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in being brought low (NRSV)

when God makes them humble (CEV)

God has humbled them (NLT)

1:10b

because he will pass away like a flower of the field.

- because he will soon die like a wild flower does.
- because they, and their riches with them, will soon end/finish just like blossoms do/finish.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the basis for the command in 1:10a. The rich believer should take pride in his low position, not in his riches (1:10a), because he, and his riches with him, will not last long (1:10b). In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis for the command (in 1:10b) before the command (in 1:10a). See the General Comment on 1:10a–b below for an example.

he will pass away like a flower of the field: This clause is a simile. In this simile, the rich person is compared to a wild flower. Some ways that they are similar are:

1. They are not permanent. Both will soon die.
2. It is only for a short period of time that people regard a rich person and a wild flower as important.

It is implied that the rich person’s wealth is also not permanent. You may want to make this explicit in your translation. For example:

he, and his riches too, will pass away like a wild flower

he will pass away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as he will pass away here means that the rich believer, like all people, “will die.” His life on this earth will end. For example:

The rich will die (NCV)

Many languages use idiomatic expressions for dying. In English, one such expression is what the BSB has used: pass away. If you have an idiom or an expression that would fit both a flower that withers and dies as well as a person who dies, you may want to use that here. For example:

he will no longer be alive

he will cease to live/be

he will no longer be present

like a flower of the field: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as flower of the field refers to flowers that grow on their own. No one plants them. In Israel, the land where James lived, brightly colored wild flowers grow in great numbers when rain comes. But it is not long before the hot sun dries them up, and they die.

In some languages there is no general word for a flower. In such cases, it may be necessary to:

General Comment on 1:10a–b

- Use a word for a specific well-known flower that only lives for a short while and dies in the heat.
- Use a word for a specific part of a plant such as:

a blossom

a bloom

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 1:10 and put the basis (1:10b) before the command (1:10a). For example:

^{10a}But the one who is rich ^{10b}will pass away like a flower of the field. ^{10a}So, he should exult in his low position, not in his riches.

James 1:11

Section 1:2–11: James encouraged believers to continue to trust God during times of testing

The theme of this section is that it is important for Christians to continue to trust God when going through various kinds of trials or difficulties. These trials are a test of their faith (1:2–4). They need God's wisdom in order to remain faithful to him, and so they should pray for wisdom (1:5). When they come to God in prayer, they should have an attitude of firm trust in him (1:6–8). Both poverty and wealth test a Christian. They should trust God whether rich or poor and learn to think about poverty and wealth as God does (1:9–11).

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Have faith and wisdom

When you have trials/tests, you must trust God

Be joyful when your faith is tested

Paragraph 1:9–11

Even if a Christian has a low position in society, he can rejoice. He can rejoice because, in God's opinion, he is in a high position. Similarly, a Christian who is rich should have God's opinion about himself. Although rich people are generally given high status because of their riches, rich Christians should rather value a low position and humble attitude. They should remember that our lives on earth are short and that riches will not last.

The theme of section 1:2–11 is that Christians should continue to trust God/Jesus when they have various kinds of tests/trials. Poverty is a kind of trial. It is also the result of the trial of being persecuted. Riches too may be a kind of test of faith. They test whether the Christian will trust God or his money. And for rich Christians who had lost wealth and status because of their faith in Christ, they should think of this in a positive way.

1:11a

For the sun rises with scorching heat

- The sun rises with its terrible/great heat
- As the sun rises and becomes very hot,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces a more detailed explanation of what was said in 1:10b. Do not translate this verse as if it were the reason for 1:10b. It further explains 1:10b, but it is not a reason. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

the sun rises with scorching heat: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as scorching heat refers to heat that is so great that it causes plants to die.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The sun rises with burning heat (NCV)

the sun becomes high and scorches

the sun becomes hot and burns

1:11b

and withers the plant;

- and dries up the plant.
- it wilts/shrivels the plants and kills them.

and withers: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as withers means “dries up.” In Israel, the rainy period ends early in the year. After that, there are no more

clouds, and the sun is so hot that flowers dry up and die quickly.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

causes to dry up

causes to die

kills

the plant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as plant may refer to any plant with flowers on it.

1:11c

its flower falls

- The blossom/flower falls to the ground,
- Then their flowers fall/drop off,

its flower: The word flower refers to the flower of the plant.

falls: The Greek word that the BSB translates as falls refers to when a flower “drops” or “falls off” its stem to the ground. For example:

The flowers drop off (GW)

the plants lose their blossoms

1:11d

and its beauty is lost.

- and its beauty is gone.
- and they are no longer beautiful.

its beauty is lost: The phrase its beauty is lost means that “the plant’s beauty is gone.”

In some languages, it is not possible to talk about something abstract like beauty being lost. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use an adjective form and say:

It is no longer beautiful at all.

what was lovely to look at is lost for ever (REB)

is lost: This is a passive verb. It is the heat of the sun that destroys the beauty of the flowers. So there are at least two ways to translate this:

General Comment on 1:10b–11d

- Use a passive verb. For example:

is destroyed (NASB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the heat destroys its beauty

the sun causes it to lose its beauty

- Use an intransitive verb. For example:

its beauty is gone (NCV)

its beauty fades away (NLT)

James was talking about wild flowers in general, not one specific blossom or plant. So in some languages, it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

^{10b–11b}Rich people will disappear like wild flowers scorched by the burning heat of the sun. ^{11c}The flowers lose their blossoms, ^{11d}and their beauty is destroyed. (CEV)

1:11e

So too, the rich man will fade away

- In the same way, a rich brother/believer will also come to the end of his life
- The same thing will happen to rich people. They will die

So too: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So too introduces an explanation of how rich people will fade away like flowers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

So also (NET)

The same thing will happen to (GW)

the rich man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates here as the rich man is the same as the phrase translated “the one who is rich” in 1:10a. There it referred to the rich brother/believer. James was probably still thinking of the rich brother/believer, but what he says is true of all rich people. You can translate this either as “rich brother/believer” or as “rich man/person.”

This phrase does not refer to one specific rich man. It refers to all rich people. To make this clear, it may be best to translate this with a plural. For example:

rich people (GW)

will fade away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will fade away refers to a plant withering and dying. James used this verb to show how rich people will fade away like wild flowers. They will die and lose all the things that made people admire them, just as a flower loses its beauty when it dies. After that, people do not pay attention to them any longer.

If it is not natural in your language to talk about a person “fading,” you can say:

will die (NCV)

will end up being nothing

1:11f in the midst of his pursuits.

- while he is busy working.
- as they are earning money.

in the midst of his pursuits: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the midst of his pursuits here means, “while he is doing his normal activities.” James was probably thinking of the rich man’s daily business activities such as trading.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

while they are still taking care of business (NCV)

while he is busy working

while he is earning money

General Comment on 1:11e–f

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{11e}It will be the same with the rich person also.

^{11f}While he is busy at his work, ^{11e}he will die.

James 1:12

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repe-

tition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:12

In this paragraph, James reminded his readers that it is important to persevere when difficult situations test their faith.

1:12a

Blessed is the man who perseveres under trial,

- ¶ How blessed is that person who endures when he is tried/tested.
- ¶ Those who do not abandon their faith during trials/troubles are favored/fortunate,

Blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed means “in a good position” or “in an enviable/desirable situation.” In the Bible, the good situation results when God favors a person and does good to him. The person who perseveres when he is tried and tempted is in a good position.

This word does not primarily refer to a feeling. However, a person in this good situation will frequently have good feelings such as happiness and joy. Do not use a word that only refers to material prosperity or physical health.

Some other ways to translate this are:

Joyful/desirable/happy is the situation of the man

How good it is for the man

The person is favored/fortunate

See bless, meaning 1, in the Glossary. Refer also to your translation of Matthew 5:3–11, where this word is used in a similar way.

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man generally refers to a male. However, in this context, the word introduces a general statement that is true of everyone. In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this statement with a general word like “people” or with a pronoun like “you” or “they.” For example:

Blessed are people

Blessed are those

Blessed is anyone (NRSV)

God will bless you (CEV)

perseveres: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as perseveres means “continued effort to fulfill some purpose.” Someone who perseveres has the ability to face all kinds of troubles, difficulties, and sufferings with courage and faithfulness. He continues to work towards his goal. He does not run away or give up.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

endures (NET)

persists

don’t give up (CEV)

This verb corresponds to the noun in 1:3c that the BSB translates as “perseverance”. See the note there.

under trial: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trial refers to difficult situations that occur in a person’s life and test his faith. These can include both external problems like persecution and internal temptations from Satan.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

during troubles/difficulties

hardships/problems

when they are tested (GW)

when your faith is being tested (CEV)

This same word occurs in 1:2b.

1:12b

because when he has stood the test,

- For when he has successfully completed/passed the test,
- because when they have proved that their faith is real/genuine,

because: The conjunction because introduces the reason that the person who endures trials in 1:12a is blessed. He is blessed (1:12a) because he will receive the crown of life (1:12c). In some languages, it will be more natural to put the reason before 1:12a. See the General Comment on 1:12a–d at the end of 1:12d for an example.

when he has stood the test: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as when he has stood the test means “when he has passed the test.” When this person is persecuted because he believes in Jesus, he perseveres. He does not abandon his faith. In this way he passes the test. He shows that his faith is genuine.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

When they pass the test (GW)

when he has proven to be genuine (NET)

After they have proved their faith (NCV)

The word “test” here in 1:12b and the word “testing” in 1:3b come from related Greek words.

1:12c

he will receive the crown of life

- he will receive a reward that is eternal life
- God will give them their reward/prize. The reward is that God will cause them to live forever.

he will receive the crown of life: The word crown literally refers to a wreath of leaves that both the Greek and Roman cultures put on a person’s head in order to honor him.

Here the word crown is a metaphor. James was using this metaphor to refer to a “reward” or “prize” for passing a test. He was not saying that believers will receive an actual object on their heads such as a crown.

So the phrase the crown of life refers to the reward or prize. A person will receive this reward or prize if he perseveres in his faith when he is persecuted. That reward/prize is eternal life.

There are two ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

he will receive the crown of eternal life

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor without keeping the figure of speech. For example:

he will receive in reward the life which God has promised (REB)

God will reward them with life forever (NCV)

God will give him a reward/prize. That reward is eternal life

life: The Greek word that the BSB translates as life here refers to eternal life with God. For example:

life forever (NCV)

life with God that never ends

1:12d

that God has promised to those who love Him.

- that God promised to give to all those who love him.
- He will do this just as he said that he would do to all of us^(incl) who love him.

God: Most of the earliest Greek manuscripts simply have the pronoun “he” here. Other Greek manuscripts have “God” or “Lord.” The meaning is the same. “He” refers to God. Most English versions supply the word “God” to make it clear who is meant. You may want to do this also.

has promised: The verb promised means “affirm that he would do something.” God said with certainty that he would give the crown of life to those who passed the test.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

vowed/guaranteed that he would do

said that he would certainly do

to those who love Him: The phrase those who love Him refers to all believers. James was including himself and his readers among those who love Him. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this

clear by using the word “us.” Some other ways to translate this are:

to all those/people who love him

to all of us^(incl) who love him

to everyone who loves him

General Comment on 1:12a–d

In some languages, it is more natural to put the reason (1:12b–d) before the result (1:12a). For example:

^{12b}When someone has stood the test, ^{12c}he will receive the crown of life ^{12d}that God has promised to those who love him. ^{12a}That is why the man who perseveres under trial is blessed.

James 1:13

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:13–15

In this paragraph, James taught that God does not tempt people. Our own sinful desires in our hearts and minds tempt us.

1:13a

When tempted,

- ¶ When someone is tempted,
- ¶ When/If temptation happens to someone,

- ¶ If something causes you^(plur) to want/desire to do evil,

When tempted: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tempted refers to being “encouraged/enticed to do something wrong.” Some ways to translate this word are:

caused to desire to do what is wrong

persuaded to do evil

encouraged/urged to sin

Notice that there is a difference between being tempted to do something wrong and actually doing it.

Here the word tempted is a passive verb. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

When people are tempted (NCV)

- Use another type of verb. For example:

When you experience/undergo temptation

When you desire to do evil

This Greek word is related to the word translated as “trial” in 1:2b and 1:12a. It has a wide range of meanings in Greek. It can mean:

1. “tested” to cause a person to trust God more.
2. “tempted” to do evil. This is its meaning in 1:13.

The context indicates which meaning is intended.

In some languages, it is necessary to use a different word here than in 1:2b and 1:12a. This is true in English. In other languages, there may be one term which fits both testing/trials and temptations. This is true in Greek. In such a case, it may be necessary to add a phrase that indicates the purpose of the testing/trial. For example:

When we are tested to make us do evil

When we experience trials/difficulties which might cause us to sin

1:13b
no one should say,

- he should not say,
- that person should not say that
- do^(plur) not say that

1:13c

“God is tempting me.”

- “It is God who is tempting me.”
- God is the one tempting/enticing him to do wrong/evil.
- God is causing you^(plur) to want/desire to do evil.

“God is tempting me.”: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as God is tempting me is literally “I am being tempted from God.” The verb is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

General Comment on 1:13c

- Use a passive verb. For example:

I am tempted by God (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God is tempting me (NLT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

No one should say that God is tempting him.

1:13d

For God cannot be tempted by evil,

- For God is never tempted to do wrong,
- Because evil can never tempt God,
- God never wants/desires to do anything wrong/sinful,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the basis for James’ command in 1:13a–b. No one should say, “God is tempting me” (1:13a–b), because God cannot be tempted by evil... (1:13d–1:15). The basis for the command continues to the end of 1:15.

God cannot be tempted by evil: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as cannot be tempted by evil means that God never feels the desire to do anything wrong. He never wants to sin. So though someone might try to tempt him, he will never do what is wrong.

There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

God is never tempted to do wrong (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Evil cannot tempt God (NCV)

God never wants to do anything wrong

by evil: The word evil in this context refers to moral evil. It refers to acts and thoughts that are morally harmful and damage a person's spiritual life. God will never desire to do anything that is wrong, sinful, or against his holy character and nature.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

wrong

sinful

1:13e

nor does He tempt anyone.

- nor does God tempt anyone.
- and God does not tempt/entice anyone to do wrong.
- and he never causes anyone to want/desire to do evil.

nor does He tempt anyone: The clause nor does He tempt anyone means that God does not encourage anyone to do something wrong. He never urges anyone to sin.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and he doesn't use evil to tempt others (CEV)

and he does not try to make people want to do wrong

General Comment on 1:13a–e

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of 1:13d and 1:13e. For example:

^{13a}When tempted, ^{13b}no one should say, ^{13c}“God is tempting me.” ^{13e}For God does not tempt anyone, ^{13d}nor can he be tempted by evil.

James 1:14

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney,

page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:13–15

In this paragraph, James taught that God does not tempt people. Our own sinful desires in our hearts and minds tempt us.

1:14a–b

each one is tempted when by his own evil desires:

This clause states a general principle. In some languages, it may be more natural to state a general principle using plural phrases or using pronouns like “we” or “you.” For example:

people are tempted...by their own evil desires

we are tempted...by our own evil desires

you are tempted...by your own evil desires

This clause is also passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Everyone is tempted by his own desires (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

A person's own evil desire tempts him

Temptation comes from our own desires (NLT)

1:14a

But each one is tempted

- But, each person is tempted

- Rather, temptation happens/occurs
- People want to do wrong

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the false idea that God tempts people to sin (1:13) and the true idea about temptation (1:14).

Some other ways to indicate this contrast are:

Rather

Instead

1:14b

when by his own evil desires

- when his own evil desires
- when a person himself desires to sin.
- because of their own evil desires.

his own evil desires: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as evil desires generally refers to any wish or desire. However, in this context, it is clearly a sinful desire. For example:

wrong desire (NJB)

In some languages, it is more natural to translate this noun as a verb. For example:

he himself desires/wants to do evil

Notice that the word desires here is personified. In other words, desires are said to do things just like a person does. In some languages, it is not natural to say that “evil desires something.” In other words, in these languages, we cannot say that our own “desires” urge or entice us to do something. If your language is like that, you may want to avoid the personification. One way to do this is:

When he himself desires to do evil

1:14c

he is lured away and enticed.

- attract/lure him and try to persuade him to sin.
- It is like when an animal is attracted and lured to a trap.
- It is as if someone/something is pulling/dragging them to do evil.

lured away and enticed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lured away literally means “pulled/

lured out.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as enticed literally means “attracted with a bait.” In this context, it means “attracted.”

These two Greek words are related metaphors. In this metaphor, the way that a person’s evil desires tempt him to sin is compared to the way a hunter catches a wild animal. One way that they are similar is that both the person and the wild animal are attracted to do something that is not good for them to do.

There are at least three ways to translate these metaphors:

- Keep the metaphors. For example:

he is lured and enticed (ESV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

like when they use bait to attract an animal and lure it to a trap

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

attract him and try to persuade him to sin

These two Greek words are also a doublet. This means that the two words mean basically the same thing. The reason for saying the same thing in two different ways is to intensify the meaning. If it is not natural to use doublets in your language, you may use one expression and intensify it. For example:

which can be enormously attractive (JBP)

he is increasingly attracted to do evil

he is enticed more and more to sin

General Comment on 1:14a–c

These verse parts contain three passive verbs (tempted, dragged, enticed). There are at least two ways to translate them:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

But each one is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desires. (NET)

- Use active verbs. For example:

Temptation comes from our own desires, which entice us and drag us away. (NLT)

A person's own evil desires tempt him and entice him and drag him away.

James 1:15

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:13–15

In this paragraph, James taught that God does not tempt people. Our own sinful desires in our hearts and minds tempt us.

1:15a–d

Verse 1:15 is an extended metaphor. The stages of sin are compared to the stages of a woman having a child. Each stage is described below.

Verse 1:15 is also a personification. This means that “desire” and “sin” are both described as doing things that people normally do.

1:15a

Then after desire has conceived,

- Then, it is like his desire becomes pregnant.
- Next, after he conceives a plan to sin,
- As a result, they decide to do the evil that they desire,

Then: The word Then introduces the result and next logical step after a person is enticed to do wrong. When translating this word, consider how your language speaks of events that normally happen in a set

order. Consider how to properly introduce an event that is the result of the one before it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

As a result

Next

And then

desire has conceived: The clause desire has conceived is both a metaphor and personification. After a person is lured to sin (1:14c), the next step is that he actually decides to sin. This step is compared to conceiving a child.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Then desire becomes pregnant (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Then, it is like the person's desire becomes pregnant,

- Keep the metaphor but not the personification. For example:

Then, he conceives/develops a plan to do what he desires

- Translate the meaning. For example:

Then he decides/plans to actually do the evil that he desires

has conceived: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has conceived refers to the beginning of a woman's pregnancy. For example:

becomes pregnant (GW)

Use a word or phrase that is appropriate for reading aloud in church and will not offend or embarrass anyone.

1:15b

it gives birth to sin;

- Then, it is like the desire gives birth to sin.

- sin is born/produced.
- then they commit/do the evil/sin.

it gives birth to sin: This clause continues the metaphor and personification. The word it refers to “desire” in 1:15a. In this metaphor, sin is committed. This is compared to giving birth to a child.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

and gives birth to sin (GW)

the child born to desire is sin

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

and it is like a woman who gives birth to sin

- Keep the metaphor but not the personification. For example:

sin is born

it produces sin

- Translate the meaning. For example:

Next he commits/does the sin

sin: The noun sin refers to any offense against God or another person. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English versions translate as sin is also a term that was used in archery to mean “miss the target.” When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

It is helpful to translate “sin” with a general term that can include any wrong act that a person does against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes such as murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses such as gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Some ways to translate sin are:

a wrong act

an offense against God

an evil deed

In some languages, it is more natural to express “sin” as a verb. For example:

it causes the person to sin

1:15c

and sin, when it is full-grown,

- Then, when the sin also grows/matures,
- Then, when he grows up doing the sin,
- Then they continue to sin until it becomes habitual and fully developed.

sin, when it is full-grown: This continues the metaphor and personification. When a person continues to sin, it develops or grows into a habit. This is compared to a child becoming mature or fully grown.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

When sin grows up (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

then it is as if sin grows up

- Keep the metaphor but not the personification. For example:

he grows up doing the sin

- Translate the meaning. For example:

when he continues to habitually sin

1:15d

gives birth to death.

- it is like sin gives birth to death.
- he has/gets eternal punishment.
- Finally, they die forever.

gives birth to death: This continues the metaphor and personification. When a person continues to sin until it controls him, it will eventually lead to eternal death. This is compared to the grown-up child becoming pregnant and giving birth to a baby of her own. It is the opposite of the life with God mentioned in 1:12c.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

it gives birth to death. (GW)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

and it is like sin gives birth to death.

- Keep the metaphor but not the personification. For example:

and has/gets eternal punishment

- Translate the meaning. For example:

and he eventually dies eternally.

and the result is eternal death.

James 1:16

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:16–18

This paragraph gives more reasons that show why it is not God who tries to make people do evil. Everything good comes from God, and he never changes. So it is unthinkable that any bad thing could come from him. God wants to give us new life.

1:16

Do not be deceived, my beloved brothers.

- ¶ My dear brothers and sisters, do^(plur) not be deceived/fooled.
- ¶ My beloved fellow believers, do^(plur) not have wrong/false ideas and think that God tempts us^(incl).

Do not be deceived: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Do not be deceived means “do not go astray” or “do not have false ideas.” We should not deceive ourselves into thinking that God is the one who tempts us to do evil.

This phrase is passive. Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

don’t be misled (NLT)

do not be fooled (NCV)

do not be deceived into thinking that God tempts us

- Use an expression that is not passive. For example:

do not deceive yourselves

do not have false/wrong ideas

This expression is used elsewhere in the New Testament to warn Christians against ideas that are dangerously wrong (1 Corinthians 6:9, 15:33; Galatians 6:7). See also Luke 21:8; 1 John 3:7. See also Davids (1982), page 86; Martin, page 37, and see the note on the word “wander” in 5:19a.

my beloved brothers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my beloved brothers refers to believers in Christ to whom James was writing. It refers to both men and women. The similar phrase “my brothers” occurs in 1:2a.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

my dear fellow believers

my dear brothers and sisters (NET)

my beloved relatives/siblings in Christ

my beloved Christian friends

James used the term of address my beloved brothers to soften his command “Don’t be deceived.” You may have another way in your language to soften a command. If you do, you may be able to use it instead of the phrase my beloved brothers.

Notice that the BSB places the phrase my beloved brothers at the end of 1:16. This follows the Greek text. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning of 1:16 before the command or after 1:17. For example:

My dear brothers and sisters, do not be fooled about this. (NCV)

beloved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beloved is used because James was telling his fellow believers that he cared about them.

James 1:17

Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example). Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (*πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν*), testing (*δοκίμιον/δόκιμος*), and endurance (*ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει*). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:16–18

This paragraph gives more reasons that show why it is not God who tries to make people do evil. Everything good comes from God, and he never changes. So it is unthinkable that any bad thing could come from him. God wants to give us new life.

1:17a

Every good and perfect gift is from above,

- Every good and perfect/complete gift comes from God above.
- It is God in heaven above who gives us^(incl) everything that is good and perfect/faultless.

Every good and perfect gift: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Every good and perfect gift contains two words for gift. For example:

Every good gift and every perfect gift (ESV)

The two words for “gift” are almost the same in meaning. James was probably quoting a piece of poetry or a proverb that repeated the phrase for emphasis.

There are two ways to translate this phrase:

- Use two different words. For example:

All generous giving and every perfect gift (NET)

every good gift and every perfect present

- Use one word. For example:

Every good and perfect gift (CEV)

everything that is good and perfect

perfect gift: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfect refers to something that is complete and full. It does not lack anything. (See the notes on 1:4b and 1:4c.) So a perfect gift is a gift that has no faults in it.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

faultless gift

everything that is perfect

is from above: The phrase is from above means that every good gift comes from God in heaven. In some languages, it may be necessary to say explicitly that God is the one who gives everything that is good and perfect. For example:

is from God (NCV)

comes from God above

is given by God

1:17b**coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights,**

- He created all that shines in the heavens/sky.
- He made the sun, moon, and stars that shine in the sky.

the Father of the heavenly lights: The phrase the heavenly lights refers to the lights that are in the heavens: the sun, moon, and stars. God is called the Father of the heavenly lights because he created the heavenly lights. He is also called the Father of the heavenly lights because he has the nature of light, which is a symbol of goodness.

In some languages, Father may be totally unclear here. If that is the case in your language, you could translate it as “Creator.” For example:

God, the Creator of the heavenly lights. (GNT)

the heavenly lights: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heavenly lights here refers to the sun, moon (see Genesis 1:16), and stars. In other words, this word refers to the things in the sky that give light.

Many languages do not have a general word that includes the sun, moon, and stars. If that is the case in your language, you could:

- Mention all three words separately. For example:

the sun, moon, and stars

- Use a phrase. For example:

the things which are in the sky and shine/give light

1:17c**with whom there is no change or shifting shadow.**

- He does not vary or change like shadows.
- They move and make shadows that change, but God does not change at all.

with whom there is no change or shifting shadow:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as change or shifting shadow is a metaphor. James was contrasting the lights in the sky with God. The sun, moon, and stars change their position in the sky and cause shadows that also move. In contrast to this, God never changes. Use a word for shadow that does not only refer to the shadow of people. The Greek word, *ἀποσκίασμα*, that is translated as “shadow” is a rare word and not the

typical word for shadow. There are quite a variety of suggestions put forward by commentators for its meaning including: shadows cast by heavenly bodies, the “shadow” of night, the phases of the moon, and shadows caused by an eclipse. Elsewhere in Greek literature the word can describe the changing shadows of the moon and the moving shadow of a sundial (see McCartney, page 112). Also, be careful not to use a word for shadow that refers to the spirit of a person.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Keep the metaphor and make the meaning clear. For example:

who does not vary like the sun, moon, and stars
or change like their shadows change

The Father doesn’t change like the shifting shadows produced by the sun and the moon. (GW)

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

God’s nature/ways never change.

no change or shifting shadow: The Greek words that the BSB translates as change and shifting are similar in meaning. Both words were commonly used to describe the changing appearance and movement of the sun, moon, and stars. There is a textual variant here. In place of “with whom there is not change or shadow of turning” some Greek manuscripts read “with whom there is not change which is of a turning/ changing shadow.” The variant reading is followed by the REB. Some other versions (GW, NCV, NIV, NJB) may also be following this reading. However, they may just be combining the two references to change in one expression. The general meaning of 1:17c is similar whichever reading is followed.

If possible, use a word that you would naturally use to describe the “changes” of the sun, moon, and stars. To make it clear that James is contrasting God to the sun, moon, and stars, you could say:

who, unlike the sun, moon, and stars, does not change or move like shadows.

James 1:18**Section 1:12–18: God does not tempt people to do evil**

This section has an opening verse (1:12) Some commentators connect 1:12 to 1:2–11 (Hiebert, for example).

Others see 1:12 as a kind of “hinge” that connects 1:2–11 to 1:12–18 (Moo (2000), pages 71–72; McCartney, page 100). They recognize that 1:2–3 and 1:12 form an inclusio, or verbal bracket to 1:2–12 through the repetition in both of three key words: trials (πειρασμοῖς/πειρασμόν), testing (δοκίμιον/δόκιμος), and endurance (ὑπομονήν/ὑπομένει). and two main paragraphs (1:13–15 and 1:16–18). In 1:12 James recalled 1:2–3 and that it was important to persevere in times of trial and temptation. The next paragraph, 1:13–15, points out that it is not God who tempts us but our own sinful desires, which eventually lead to death. Paragraph 1:16–18 reinforces this by saying that God gives only good gifts.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Christians should endure testing and temptations

Trials and temptations

Paragraph 1:16–18

This paragraph gives more reasons that show why it is not God who tries to make people do evil. Everything good comes from God, and he never changes. So it is unthinkable that any bad thing could come from him. God wants to give us new life.

1:18

In 1:18, James wrote about the particular gift that was foremost in his mind when he said, “Every good gift... comes from above” (1:17). This good gift is that God “chose to give us birth through the word of truth.”

1:18a

He chose to give us birth through the word of truth,

- He chose to give us^(incl) new life by means of the true message,
- He decided to give us^(incl) eternal life when we believed in the gospel.
- He chose/decided to send his true message and make us^(incl) his children.

He chose to give us birth: This phrase indicates that God planned and decided to give us birth. He did not choose and desire to cause people to sin (see 1:13).

give us birth: There are two ways to interpret the phrase give...birth:

1. It refers to the new birth that happens when people become followers of Christ. Huther, page 74; Alford, page 283; Mayor, page 59; Ropes, page 166; Mitton, pages 56–57; Hiebert, pages 116–117; Adamson (1976), pages 76–77; Davids (1982), pages 89–90; Moo (1985), pages 76–77; Martin, pages 39–41. For example, the CEV says:

give us new birth (NLT96, CEV, JBP)

1. It refers to the creation of mankind. In particular, see F. J. A. Hort. For example, the GNT says:

he brought us into being (GNT)

Childbirth is used in the NT as a metaphor for new birth in Christ (1 Peter 1:23; 1 John 3:9), but never for creation. Also the phrase “word of truth” normally refers to the gospel (see the following note on “through the word of truth”). For these reasons, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

In some languages, the metaphor of childbirth (“he gave birth to us”) may be misunderstood. If this is the case in your language, it may be better to say:

he gave us new life

us: James was probably referring to all Christians. See the note on “firstfruits” at the end of this verse.

through the word of truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through the word of truth here means “through the true message.” In the NT this phrase commonly refers to the gospel concerning Jesus Christ. Belief in the gospel is the way that God chose to give us new birth.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by means of the word of truth

when we believed the true message

because we believed that his word is true

See the General Comment on 1:18a below for other ways to translate this phrase.

word: The Greek word that the BSB translates as word means “a message.” It is what someone has said.

General Comment on 1:18a

In some languages, it is more natural to put “through the word of truth” before “He chose to give us birth.” For example:

The word of truth is the way that he chose to give us birth.

He used/took the word of truth and chose to give us new birth.

We believe the word of truth saying, “He chose to give us birth.”

1:18b

that we would be a kind of firstfruits of His creation.

- so that we^(incl) might be the most important part of everything he created just like the first part/grains of the harvest are the most important part.
- He did this in order that we^(incl) believers might be the most important part of everything he created.

that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that introduces God’s purpose in giving people new birth. God gave us new birth (1:18a) so that we might be a kind of firstfruits (1:18b).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

in order that

for the purpose of

In some languages, it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He did this so that...

we would be a kind of firstfruits: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a kind of firstfruits is a simile. In this simile, Christians are compared to firstfruits. The word firstfruits refers to the first grains and fruits of the harvest. It also refers to the first-born child and animal. God had asked his people to give their firstfruits to him.

Some ways that Christians and firstfruits are similar are:

- Both are first in time, in contrast to others that will come later. For example:

that we might be...the first specimens of his new creation (JBP)

- Both are offered to God and so belong to him. As a result, both are more important than other parts of God’s creation. For example:

so that we should have first place among all his creatures (GNT)

to make us his most important creatures (GW)

Some ways to translate this simile are:

- Make explicit the way that Christians and firstfruits are similar. For example:

that we believers should be the first to come to him just like the firstfruits of the harvest

that we believers should be the most important of all his creation just like the firstfruits of the harvest

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

to be his own special people (CEV)

- Translate the simile literally. For example:

so that we would be like the first fruit/grains of the harvest If you translate the simile literally, you may want to add a footnote. In the footnote you can explain more fully what firstfruits were and what was being compared in this simile. For example:

The word “firstfruits” refers to the first grains/fruits of the crops that ripen or the firstborn child or animal. God asked the Israelites to give these things to him. Here James compares us Christians to the firstfruits. We are similar in that we are the most important part. We are also the first.

of His creation: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as of His creation is literally “of his creatures” (as in the RSV). This phrase refers to everything that God created. It does not refer just to living things.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

of all the things that he created

from among everything he made

James 1:19

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God's message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:19–21

Believers should get rid of sin and obey the word of God.

1:19a

My beloved brothers, understand this:

- ¶ My dear brothers and sisters, listen^(plur) to this:
- ¶ Remember^(plur), my fellow believers whom I love, that

My beloved brothers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My beloved brothers refers to believers in Christ. It refers to both men and women. James loved these believers. This phrase also occurs in 1:16. See the note there for translation advice.

James used this phrase to introduce the subject of controlling one's speech. He also used this phrase to soften his command ("understand this") and to make it more polite. You may have another way in your language to introduce a change of subject or to soften a command. If you do, you may be able to use it instead of the phrase My beloved brothers.

understand this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as understand this is literally "know" (as in the RSV). Instead of the verb "know," some Greek manuscripts have the conjunction that the KJV translates as "wherefore." The reading "know" is strongly supported by a variety of manuscripts and the majority of English versions. James was telling his readers to be attentive to what he was about to write.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

take note of this (NIV)

remember this (GW)

do not forget

In some languages, it is not necessary to translate this word. For example the CEV says:

^aMy dear friends, ^byou should be quick to listen...

1:19b

Everyone should be quick to listen,

- Everyone should be ready to listen,
- you^(plur) should be eager to listen to other people,

Everyone should be quick to listen: The phrase quick to listen means:

ready to listen

eager to listen

In some languages, it may be more natural to use the second person plural "you" in giving a command like this. For example:

you should be quick to listen

always be willing to listen (NCV)

James was mainly referring to listening to "the word of truth" (1:18). But he stated his command in a general way. So if you need to provide an object for the verb listen in your language, use a general word like "talk" or "words." For example:

Everyone should listen to others' words/talk

Everyone should eagerly listen to what is said

1:19c

slow to speak,

- everyone should think before speaking,
- you^(plur) should not be too eager to speak,

slow to speak: The phrase slow to speak means "take time to think carefully before speaking."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Everyone should think before he speaks

you should not be quick to speak

This phrase does not refer to speaking slowly rather than quickly.

1:19d and slow to anger,

- and not become angry quickly.
- and you^(plur) should not become angry easily,

slow to anger: The phrase slow to anger means “do not quickly/easily become angry.”

Some languages have an idiom to describe anger. An example of an idiom in English is:

No one should be hot-tempered

you should not be quick-tempered

James 1:20

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God’s message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:19–21

Believers should get rid of sin and obey the word of God.

1:20

for man’s anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires.

- I say this because when a person is angry, he cannot live in the righteous way that pleases God.
- because anger will not help you live the right kind of life God wants. (NCV)

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason that people should not get angry quickly. People should be slow to become angry (1:19d), for/because man’s anger does not bring about the righteous life that God desires (1:20). Another way to show this connection is:

I say this because

See also the General Comment on 1:19–20 at the end of 1:20 for an example of another way to begin this verse.

man’s anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the righteousness that God desires is literally “the righteousness of God” (as in the RSV). There are at least two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the righteous behavior/action that God desires from his people. For example, the GW says:

An angry person doesn’t do what God approves of. (BSB, NIV, NCV, GW, NLT, JBP)

1. It refers to God’s own righteous purposes and justice. Human anger does not achieve the right things that God himself intends to do in his people and in the world. For example, the REB says:

For human anger does not promote God’s justice. (GNT, NJB, NLT96, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the great majority of commentators follow this interpretation.

The phrase man’s anger does not bring about... indicates that man’s anger seriously hinders the righteousness of God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

anger will not help you live the right kind of life God wants (NCV)

Anger makes it very hard for you to live the righteous life that God approves.

an angry person does not do what is right in God’s eyes

human anger does not help someone do the good/right things that God wants him to do

See also righteous, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

man’s: The word man here refers to any human being. It refers to both men and women. It means a human being in contrast to God. Another way to translate this word is:

human

anger: In some languages, it may be necessary to express anger as a verb or verb phrase. For example:

when people are angry....

if you become angry....

being angry....

General Comment on 1:19–20

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of 1:19–20 and put the reason in 1:20 before the result in 1:19b–d. For example:

^{19a}My beloved brothers, understand this: ²⁰man's anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires. ^{19b}That is why everyone should be quick to listen, ^{19c}slow to speak ^{19d}and slow to anger.

James 1:21

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God's message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:19–21

Believers should get rid of sin and obey the word of God.

1:21a

Therefore, get rid of all moral filth

- Therefore, remove^(plur) everything that is immoral
- So, stop^(plur) doing every evil thing

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces a command. Based on the principle that he had just mentioned (1:20), James commanded his hearers to do two things:

1. renounce their wickedness, and
2. accept the word of God.

Another way to translate this word is:

So (NLT)

get rid of all moral filth: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as get rid of here means “remove” or “separate yourself from.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

put away all filth (NET)

remove everything that causes you to be morally dirty

You must stop doing anything immoral (CEV)

all moral filth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as moral filth refers to dirtiness or pollution. Here it is used figuratively to refer to moral uncleanness or wickedness.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

every evil thing (NCV)

everything that is bad

1:21b

and every expression of evil,

- and the extreme amount of evil that you^(plur) do,
- and stop the wicked things that you^(plur) do so frequently.

every expression of evil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as expression of evil is literally “wickedness” (as in the RSV). Among the meanings of the Greek word, *κακία*, (translated “evil” here by the BSB) are a) a general meaning, “moral evil/wickedness,” or b) the more specific meaning, “malice.” Both meanings could make good sense in this context. The vast majority of English versions translate the word in the general sense. Commentary opinion is quite evenly split. These Notes follow the English versions. However, other language versions such as French versions favor a meaning closer to “malice.” Some commentaries that support this meaning include Laws, page 81 and Davids (1982), page 94. This is a second thing that James wanted his readers to get rid of. It means approximately the same as “moral filth” in 1:21a. For a suggestion on how to combine 1:21a–b, see the General Comment on 1:21a–b following this note.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as every expression means “abundance,” “enormous quantity,” or “extreme amount” (of evil).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the enormous amount of wicked things that you do

the evil things that you do so frequently

all the wicked things you do (GW)

General Comment on 1:21a–b

Verse 1:21a and 1:21b say the same thing with different words. In some languages, it will be more natural to combine the two parts. For example:

So stop doing all kinds of evil things that remain in your lives.

1:21c

and humbly accept the word planted in you,

- and humble yourselves and accept the word/message that was planted in you.^(plur)
- You^(plur) should be humble and accept/obey the good news that God put in your hearts.
- Instead, humbly obey/receive the message that God caused you^(plur) to know.

In some languages, it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Instead, be humble and accept the message (CEV)

humbly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as humbly refers to being submissive and willing to learn. It is the opposite of being proud and angry.

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this word as a verb or verb phrase. For example:

be humble (CEV)

humble yourselves

accept: The Greek word that the BSB translates as accept means “welcome” or “receive.” In this context it refers to paying attention to the gospel and obeying it. Some ways to translate this word are:

receive

honor

obey

the word planted in you: The phrase the word planted in you is a metaphor. In this metaphor, preaching the word of God is compared to planting seed in the soil. One way that they are similar is that both activities put/insert something (word – seed) into something else (our hearts – soil). When the word/gospel was preached, it was planted or “put” in our hearts.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

the word that he plants in your hearts (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without using the metaphor. For example:

the word that God has placed in you (GW)

the message that God has caused you to know

the gospel that you heard and know

the word: The phrase the word refers to the gospel.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the message (CEV)

the good news

This phrase also occurs in 1:18a.

planted: The verb planted is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the message that is planted in you (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the word God has planted in your hearts (NLT)

the word that God has placed in you (GW)

1:21d

which can save your souls.

- This word can save you. (GW)
- This good news is able to save/rescue you^(plur) from being punished for sin.

which can save your souls: The word which refers back to the word/message in 1:21c. This message is able to save us in the sense that it tells us about Jesus who can save us.

In some languages, it would be better to translate this as a clause beginning with “and” rather than which. For example:

the Word which has been planted in you and can save your souls (NJB)

save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save means “to rescue from danger or trouble.” In this context, it refers to rescuing someone from the spiritual dangers of sin and from death. Spiritual death is the punishment that results from sinning.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit what the person was saved from. For example:

which can save you from the results of sin.

which can rescue you from punishment for sin.

See save, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

your souls: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as your souls refers to the whole person. That is why many versions translate it simply as you.

James 1:22

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God’s message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:22–25

Believers must not forget the word of God that they had heard. They must do/obey it.

1:22

In 1:22, there are three clauses in Greek. The BSB follows the Greek order but some other English versions change the Greek order of these clauses. Compare the order of the clauses in the BSB and NIV below.

^{22a}Be doers of the word, ^{22b}and not hearers only, ^{22c}...deceiving yourselves. (BSB)

^{22b}Do not merely listen to the word, ^{22c}and so deceive yourselves. ^{22a}Do what it says. (NIV)

You should arrange the clauses in 1:22 in a way that is natural in your language. See the General Comment at the end of 1:22c for more discussion on reordering these clauses.

In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that means “But” in some contexts. Some English versions have translated it as “But” here. However, in this context, it is not indicating a contrast. It simply introduces the next point about the “word.” So, in many languages, no conjunction is necessary here.

1:22a

Be doers of the word,

- Be^(plur) doers of the word.
- Do^(plur) what the word says/commands.
- You^(plur) must also follow/obey it.

Be doers of the word: The clause Be doers of the word refers to those who always do what God’s word tells them to do. Such people put the word’s teaching into practice and regularly obey its commands.

Translate this clause in such a way that the action is habitual, repeated action.

Some other ways to translate this are:

Do what it says (NIV)

put it into practice (GNT)

obey God’s message (CEV)

the word: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the word refers to the gospel.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

God’s word (NLT)

God’s message

The same word occurs in 1:18a and 1:21c.

1:22b

and not hearers only.

- ¶ Do not only be^(plur) hearers of the word,

- ¶ Do not only hear^(plur) the word of God
- ¶ Do not just listen^(plur) to the good news

and not hearers only: The clause and not hearers only indicates that it is not enough to just listen to someone preaching or reading from the word of God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Do not only be hearers of the word

don't just listen to God's word (NLT)

You must do more than just hear God's word/
message

Do not limit yourselves to just hearing the gospel

Be careful not to translate this in a way that implies that it is not good to listen to the word.

not hearers only: The phrase hearers only refers to those who only hear the gospel teaching. They never do what it tells them to do.

In many languages, the usual word for “hear” includes the idea of obeying. If this is so in your language, be careful here to use an expression that describes hearing without obeying.

1:22c

Otherwise, you are deceiving yourselves.

- and deceive yourselves and think that just hearing is sufficient.
- or you will fool yourselves. (GW)

Otherwise, you are deceiving yourselves: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as deceiving yourselves can also be translated as “fool yourselves.” It refers to wrong thinking that leads a person astray. Anyone who just listens to the message of the gospel but does not obey its commands is mistaken if he thinks that God is pleased.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

or you will fool yourselves (GW)

and lie to yourselves

General Comment on 1:22a–c

In Greek and the BSB, a clause with a positive command (“Be doers of the word”) comes first. This is followed by a clause with a negative command (“do

not only be hearers”). The NIV reverses the order of the positive and negative commands. Use the order that is most natural in your language.

Another possible way to translate the verse is:

He who hears the word and does not do what it says is deceiving himself. Therefore you should be people who both hear and do, not people who only hear.

James 1:23

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God's message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:22–25

Believers must not forget the word of God that they had heard. They must do/obey it.

1:23a–24b

This is a type of comparison called a simile. In this simile, a man who listens to the word (in 1:23a–b) is compared to a man who looks at his face in a mirror (in 1:23c–24b). Some ways that they are similar are that:

1. they both realize something about themselves that they ought to act on
2. they carelessly neglect to do anything about it

Part of what is similar is implied but not stated in this comparison. If what is similar is not clear, then it may be necessary to include some of the implied information in your translation. For example:

^{23a}For anyone who hears the word ^{23b}but does not carry it out ^{23c}is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror ^{24a}and after observing something he should do, ^{24b}goes away and immediately forgets/neglects to do anything about it.

1:23a

For anyone who hears the word

- If anyone is a hearer of the word
- Whoever hears the word of God

- I give this command because if you^(plur) listen to the good news

1:23b**but does not carry it out**

- and not a doer,
- but does not obey what it commands,
- and do not follow it,

1:23a–b

In Greek and the BSB, this verse begins with a conjunction that means “for” or “because.” This conjunction introduces the basis for James’ command in 1:22. Most English versions do not translate this conjunction. Consider whether you need a conjunction or phrase in your language to make the relationship between 1:22 and 1:23 clear.

For anyone who hears the word but does not carry it out: In Greek, this clause is literally, “For if anyone is a hearer of the word and not a doer.” Translate “hearer” and “doer” in the same way in which you translated them in 1:22.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

If someone listens to God’s word but doesn’t do what it says (GW)

If you hear the message and don’t obey it (CEV)

1:23c**is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror,**

- he is like someone who carefully looks at his face in a mirror,
- you^(plur) are like someone who looks at a reflection of his own face.

is like: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *is like* means “to be similar to.” The person in 1:23a–b is compared to the person in 1:23c–24b.

a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *a man* here means “someone.” It normally refers to a male, but in this context the word introduces a general statement that is true of either a man or a woman (as in 1:12a).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

someone (NET)

a person (GW)

who looks at his face in a mirror: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *looks at* means “to look at something so as to notice what it is like.” The person does not just give a quick glance at his image in the mirror. He looks carefully enough to observe what his face is like. See the discussion in Adamson (1989), page 407.

Some other ways to translate this are:

carefully looks at himself in a mirror

observes his reflection

his face: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *his face* is literally “the face of his existence/origin.” It apparently means his physical face, his face in its natural state. Commentators are divided on whether they understand *γενέσεως* to mean here “birth” or “existence.” It can hardly mean “birth,” since a person looking in a mirror sees a rather different face from the one he had at birth. Hort, page 39, cites a late Greek writer Eustathius who uses almost the same phrase to indicate the original face, or ordinary face of a person, in contrast to the face when it is loaded with cosmetics. For example:

his natural face (RSV)

This perhaps indicates that his face was dirty or he needed to trim his beard, or the woman needed to adjust her make-up. The person saw that he needed to correct something about his appearance but was foolish and did nothing about it (1:24a–b).

James 1:24**Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it**

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God’s message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:22–25

Believers must not forget the word of God that they had heard. They must do/obey it.

1:24a and after observing himself

- and when he is finished looking at himself,
- Then

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces more details about 1:23c. The person not only looks at himself, he goes away and forgets what he looks like.

Some English versions translate this word as “for.” But do not translate this verse as if it were the reason for 1:23. It further explains 1:23, but it is not a reason.

after observing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as after observing is from the same Greek word as the word translated “looks at” in 1:23c. In some languages, it may be unnatural or unnecessary to repeat the word here. In these languages, it may be sufficient to translate this as:

after that

having done that

then

1:24b goes away and immediately forgets what he looks like.

- he goes/walks away and soon/quickly forgets what he looks like.
- he leaves, and it is not long before he no longer remembers what he saw.

goes away: Some other ways to translate goes away are:

leaves

walks away

immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immediately can also be translated as:

quickly (NCV)

soon

it is not long before

forgets what he looks like: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forgets in this context means “neglects to do something about” what he has seen and quickly forgets it. He has an attitude of carelessness. He does not consider it important for him to do anything about what he has observed. See the note about the simile in 1:23a–24b. Barclay-Newman and Louw & Nida both suggest “neglect” as a possible meaning of ἐπιλανθάνομαι. The SSA (page 54) on James says, “One sense of the verb ἐπιλανθάνομαι ‘forget’ is ‘neglect to do,’ which is more than just a lapse of memory. It is deliberately not responding to what has been seen.” Martin (page 50), agrees: “What is seen in a mirror is meant to lead to action, usually regarded as remedial. The face is seen to be dirty ... or blemished and needing attention. Instead the thoughtless person ‘goes off and forgets’ [in the sense of “neglects to do”] ... what he has seen.” Similarly, the New Bible Commentary for this passage (page 1226) says, “The word is compared to a mirror, for it shows a man to himself as he is and the sight is not pleasing... But the mere hearer gives himself a glance and hurries off; and away from the mirror he at once forgets what he saw—though his face was dirty. He does not receive the Word and act on it.” While many commentaries understand “forget” in this passage in the sense of “to not have the remembrance of something,” the two senses are not necessarily unconnected. Thompson in the Wesleyan Bible Commentary (page 212) notes: “If we do not move fairly quickly in doing what we see, the danger of forgetfulness is soon upon us.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

forgets what he saw

does nothing to fix the problem he saw and soon forgets about it

James 1:25

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God’s message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:22–25

Believers must not forget the word of God that they had heard. They must do/obey it.

1:25

In Greek and the BSB, 1:25 is one long sentence. This sentence has many clauses, and some clauses repeat information. In some languages, it will not be natural to follow the BSB order and structure. For some ways to reorder this verse, see the General Comment on 1:25a–e at the end of 1:25e.

1:25a

But the one who looks intently into the perfect law of freedom,

- But the person who carefully studies God's perfect law that sets people free
- But as regards the person who listens carefully to God's commandments that are perfect and that free us^(incl) from sin,
- But some people carefully examine/read the law. This law is completely good and it liberates us^(incl) from sin.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the person who only hears the word (1:23–24) and the person who hears the word and does it (1:25).

the one who: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the one who is in a general statement that applies to anyone. In some languages, it may be more natural to use a pronoun or a plural in such a statement. For example:

the person who (GW)

the one who (NET)

those who (NCV)

if you (GNT)

looks intently: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as looks intently literally means “look/peer into.” Here it is used figuratively and means “investigate carefully.” Some authorities (including F. Field, page 236, and F. J. A. Hort) think the component of carefulness is not present in the meaning of the verb. It seems, however, that examples can be quoted on both sides. In other words, the context shows whether carefulness is implied or not. It refers to determining what God's word says by listening to someone else read it, asking questions, or reading it oneself.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

thoroughly examines

carefully study (NCV)

carefully thinks about

listens very well

the perfect law: The phrase the perfect law refers to all the commandments in God's word. It refers to the set of instructions and commands that God gave his people to live by. They are perfect. It does not just refer to the Ten Commandments or other laws in the Old Testament. It also includes Jesus' teachings.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

God's perfect law (NCV)

God's perfect teachings (GW)

God's perfect rules

perfect: The word perfect means that God's law is completely good. It has no unrighteous commands.

This same word occurs in 1:17a with similar meaning.

of freedom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as of freedom describes what the perfect law does for people who obey it. It frees them from sin. This interpretation is explicitly supported by the NIV, GNT, REB, and Huther, page 89. However, since the Greek literally just says, “the law of liberty,” some commentators interpret the phrase as “the law that a person obeys freely.” See Mayor, page 70; Mitton, pages 72–73. But the interpretation that the law sets a person free fits well with the teaching of the Psalms (see Psalm 119:32, “I will run in the path of your commands, for you have set my heart free,” and 119:45 “I will walk about in freedom, for I have sought out your precepts”) and other Jewish literature (for example, “you find no free man except him who occupies himself with the study of Torah,” Aboth 6:2b, cited in Martin, page 51). In some languages it may be necessary to translate freedom as a verb. For example:

that makes us free (REB)

that sets you free (CEV)

In other languages, it may be necessary to provide an object. For example:

that frees people from sin

that frees people to do what God wants them to do

1:25b
and continues to do so—

- and continues to study it
- if/when he hears and thinks about them constantly,
- Those who continue to examine/read this law

and continues to do so: The Greek word that the BSB translates as continues to do so indicates that the person continues to carefully investigate the law of God.

In some languages, it may be possible to translate this word as part of 1:25a. For example:

But the man who continues to look intently into the perfect law

But if you keep looking steadily into God's perfect law (NLT96)

1:25c-d
not being a forgetful hearer, but an effective doer:
In Greek, this is literally "being not a forgetful hearer but a doer of the work." For example:

being no hearer that forgets but a doer that acts (RSV)

The words "hearer" and "doer" are the same words as in 1:22a and 1:22c. See the notes on 1:22a, 1:22c, and try to use the same expressions here that you did there.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and do not simply listen and then forget it, but put it into practice (GNT)

They do not forget what they heard, but they obey what God's teaching says (NCV)

not neglecting to do what they heard that they should do but doing it

If it is more natural in your language to first say what a person does and then say what he does not do, then you may want to reverse the order of these clauses. For example the NLT says:

and if you do what it says and don't forget what you heard

1:25c
not being a forgetful hearer,

- and does not just hear it and forget,
- and does not neglect and forget what he heard,
- and do not neglect to do what they have learned,

not being a forgetful hearer: If you used a verb in 1:25a that means "look," "read" or "study," then it may not be natural to use the verb "heard" here. In such a case, you can say:

not forgetting what he read/studied

not forgetting what he saw in the law

not neglecting to do what he has learned

not forgetting what it says

Another way to translate this is to translate it without the negative. For example:

Remembering what he has heard

1:25d
but an effective doer—

- but does/obeys what it teaches,
- but follows/keeps them,
- but instead they obey it,

but an effective doer: The clause effective doer refers to doing what the perfect law teaches. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

but doing what the law says/teaches

but keeping/obeying the law

1:25e
he will be blessed in what he does.

- he will be blessed for doing/keeping it.

- God will bless him because he follows/keeps the commandments.
- they will be favored/fortunate.

he will be blessed in what he does: The clause that the BSB translates as he will be blessed in what he does is literally “that one will be blessed in the doing of him/it.” The Greek pronoun can be translated as either “him” or “it.” As a result, there are two different ways to interpret the words “the doing of him/it”:

1. The pronoun should be interpreted as “it” and refers to the law. So the words “the doing of it” refer to doing/keeping the law. According to this interpretation, God will bless a person because he keeps the law. For example, the NLT says:

But if you look carefully into the perfect law that sets you free, and if you do what it says..., then God will bless you for doing it. (RSV, ESV, REB, JBP, NLT, NCV)NIV, NASB, KJV, and NET (which all say something similar to “will be blessed in what he does”) are somewhat ambiguous but the intended meaning may be “in what he does to keep/do the law.”

1. The pronoun should be interpreted as “him” and refers to the man in 1:25a. So the words “the doing of him” refer to the activities that the man does. According to this interpretation, God will bless the man in everything he does. For example, the NJB says:

But anyone who looks steadily at the perfect law of freedom and keeps to it...will be blessed in every undertaking. (NJB, GNT)The GNT’s “you will be blessed by God in what you do” will probably be interpreted by most readers to mean “in whatever you do.” It is also possible to understand “in what you do” to refer to what was just said about putting the law into practice., (CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because this is the most natural meaning of the phrase “the doing of it” in this context. These words refer to the same action as the words “doing it” in 1:25d. In other words, it means doing what the law says.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he will be blessed because he does/keeps the law

he will be blessed through/by doing it

Those who do this will be made happy (NCV)

In some languages, it may not be natural to translate the clause in what he does because it repeats information in 1:25d. If that is true in your language, you may leave this clause implicit. For example:

he will be blessed

will be blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed means that the person is in a good position or situation. In other words, because he is doing what the law commands, all will be well with him. He will be blessed in the sense that God will think well of him.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

God will bless him

how good it will be for that kind of person

a person like that will be favored/fortunate

This does not mean that he will necessarily be comfortable or successful from a human point of view.

This same word occurs in 1:12. See bless, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 1:25a–e

In Greek and the BSB, 1:25 is one, long sentence. In some languages, it may be natural to divide this long sentence into several sentences. For example:

^{25a}But the truly happy people are those who carefully study God’s perfect law that makes people free, ^{25b}and they continue to study it. ^{25c}They do not forget what they heard, ^{25d}but they obey what God’s teaching says. ^{25e}Those who do this will be made happy. (NCV)

It may also be natural to change the order of some of the clauses. For example:

^{25a–b}But if you keep looking steadily into God’s perfect law—the law that sets you free—^{25d}and if you do what it says ^{25c}and don’t forget what you heard, ^{25e}then God will bless you for doing it. (NLT96)

The law is complete and frees us^(incl) from sin. So if we study it carefully, and remember to always obey it, God will bless us.

James 1:26

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God's message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:26–27

In order to please God, a person must control his tongue, help others, and avoid sin.

1:26a

If anyone considers himself religious

- ¶ If anyone thinks that he is a religious person
- ¶ Whoever believes that they do God's laws/work,

If anyone: Some Greek manuscripts also have the phrase “among you” in 1:26. For example, the KJV says, “If any man among you.” The majority of English versions do not include this phrase. The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as If anyone can also be translated as “Anyone who.” The form of this Greek “if” clause indicates that James was referring to everyone who was like this. He was not uncertain whether there was anyone like this. So in some languages, it may be more natural to use a plural here. For example:

Those who

People who (NCV)

If you^(plur)

considers himself religious: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as considers himself religious implies that the person falsely thinks that he is religious. He believes that he does things that please God, but he is wrong.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

thinks that he is religious

says that he is a religious person

religious: The Greek word that the BSB translates as religious describes a person who seriously follows the rites and teachings of a religion. This might include prayer, worship with other people, and fasting.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

devoted to God

on God's path

walks well with God

does God's work/laws

1:26b

and yet does not bridle his tongue,

- but he does not bridle his tongue,
- but he does not control his tongue/mouth,
- and yet they cannot restrain themselves from saying words that they should not say,

does not bridle his tongue: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as does not bridle his tongue refers to the way a person who rides a horse controls his horse with ropes or leather straps around the head. The ropes are called a bridle. (See the illustration below.) The act of controlling a horse by means of those ropes or straps is also called “bridle.” (For example, “He bridles his horse.”)

Here this word is a metaphor. James compared someone who is able to control his tongue to a horse that is bridled. They are similar in that both can be controlled. Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

does not bridle his tongue (ESV)

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

can't control your tongue (CEV)

say things they should not say (NCV)

his tongue: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as his tongue is also a figure of speech. It refers to “the words that a person says” with his tongue.

Some other ways to translate this figure are:

his mouth

his words

what he says

1:26c he deceives his heart

- he is deceiving himself,
- they are lying to themselves.

he deceives his heart: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heart is frequently used in Greek to refer to a person’s thoughts. Some modern English versions translate this word as “himself.”

Another way to translate this phrase is:

he is fooling himself (GW)

he is lying to himself

what he thinks about himself is wrong

A person deceives himself if he thinks that he is religious when, at the same time, he cannot control his tongue.

1:26d and his religion is worthless.

- then his religious practices are worth nothing.
- Their worship of God is of no value/use.

and his religion is worthless: In Greek, 1:26a–c is part of a complex clause that begins with “if.” This is followed by the consequence in 1:26d. The RSV follows this grammatical structure: Condition ^{26a}If any one thinks he is religious^{26b}and does not bridle his tongue^{26c}but deceives himself,Consequence^{26d}this man’s religion is vain.The NIV and many other modern versions have transferred 1:26c (but deceives himself) to the consequence. One way to emphasize the consequence in 1:26d is to make it a separate sentence. For example, the GW says:^{26a}If a person thinks that he is religious^{26b}but can’t control his tongue,^{26c}he is fooling himself.^{26d}That person’s religion is worthless.

The clause his religion is worthless indicates that all that he does to show that he is devoted to God is useless in God’s eyes. Another way to translate this is:

this person’s religious acts/practices are worth nothing

his religion is of no worth/use

his worship has no value

religion: The Greek word that the BSB translates as religion refers to the worship of God or gods. It refers primarily to outward, external acts of piety or devotion.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

ceremonies to God

worship of God

piety toward God

This word also occurs in Acts 26:5.

James 1:27

Section 1:19–27: Believers should accept the word of God and obey it

In this section, James emphasized the importance of obeying the word of God. There are three paragraphs: 1:19–21, 1:22–25, and 1:26–27.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Hearing and Doing the Word (ESV)

Christians must listen to God’s message and obey it (UBS)

Paragraph 1:26–27

In order to please God, a person must control his tongue, help others, and avoid sin.

1:27

Verse 1:26 is about the sort of behavior that is a wrong way of showing devotion to God. In 1:27, James explained how to do what really pleases God.

See the General Comment on 1:27a–c at the end of 1:27c for ways to reorder this verse.

1:27a**Pure and undefiled religion before our God and Father is this:**

- The religious practices that God our^(incl) Father considers pure and faultless are
- The worship of God that is pure and without fault in God our^(incl) Father's eyes is this:
- Pious acts that God our^(incl) Father considers completely pure/genuine are:

Pure and undefiled religion before our God and Father is this: This clause is literally "Religion pure and undefiled before God is this."

Pure and undefiled: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as Pure and undefiled have the same general meaning: "without any fault." In some languages, it may be more natural to find one word to translate both terms. If your language is like that, you should try and intensify that word to convey James' emphasis here. For example:

completely pure

Pure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Pure means "clean." Here it is used in a figurative sense to mean "having no sin." It has a very positive sense.

undefiled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as undefiled means "unpolluted" or "faultless." It conveys a positive sense by saying "not anything is bad" about it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

without fault (NCV)

genuine (GNT)

spotless (CEV)

without sin

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Religion that is pure and undefiled before God and the Father is this: (RSV)

What God the Father considers to be pure and genuine religion is this: (GNT)

Pure and genuine religion in the sight of God the Father means (NLT)

Religion that pleases God the Father must be pure and spotless. (CEV)

our God and Father: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as our God and Father is literally "the God and father." The BSB has supplied the word our. Another way to translate this phrase is:

God the Father (GNT)

1:27b**to care for orphans and widows in their distress,**

- to take care of orphans and widows who are suffering,
- helping children who have no father and widows when they have problems/difficulties,

to care for orphans and widows: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to look after literally means "to visit" (as in the RSV). In this context, it means "to take care of," "to care for," or "to help" orphans and widows. For example:

to take care of orphans and widows (GW)

we must care for orphans and widows (NLT96)

You must help...orphans and widows (CEV)

Use an expression that is natural in your language for caring for widows and orphans.

orphans: The Greek word that the BSB translates as orphans refers to children whose father had died. It also refers to children whose father and mother have died. If the word "orphan" in your language refers only to those who have lost both a mother and a father, then you may want to translate this word as:

the fatherless

in their distress: The phrase in their distress refers to both orphans and widows. It does not just refer to widows.

The word distress also means "affliction," "suffering," or "troubles."

In Jewish society, orphans and widows were the people who needed help most frequently. James did not

mean that all orphans and widows always suffer. So it may be natural to translate this phrase as:

when they suffer (GW)

who are suffering

1:27c

and to keep oneself from being polluted by the world.

- and to keep oneself uncontaminated by the world.
- and not let this world make you evil. (CEV)
- and not letting ourselves^(incl) be influenced by behavior that is opposed to God.

and to keep oneself from being polluted by the world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as from being polluted is literally “unstained” (as in the RSV). This word also means “spotless” or “without blemish.” Here it is used in a spiritual sense. Just as we try to keep dirt from staining our clothing, so we should keep the world from having a negative effect on our lives.

Some other ways to translate this are:

and to keep oneself from being corrupted by the world (GNT)

and keeping oneself uncontaminated by the world (NJB)

and refusing to let the world corrupt you. (NLT)

and not let this world make you evil (CEV)

by the world: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the world here refers to every person in the world who is opposed to God and who tempts God’s people to sin against him. God’s people become polluted by the world when they begin to act and think like the ungodly people of the world.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

those who are against God

behavior that is opposed to God

by the evil which is being done by God’s enemies

General Comment on 1:27a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{27b}When you take care of widows and orphans in their distress, ^{27c}and you keep yourself from being polluted by the world, ^{27a}this is the type of religion that God considers to be pure and undefiled.

^{27a}A person whose worship of God is completely genuine ^{27c}avoids the evil behavior that people here on the earth do. ^{27b}He takes good care of orphans and widows who are in difficulty. ^{27a}This is the way which our Father God likes for us to worship him.

James 2:1

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:1–4

In this paragraph, James taught that believers must not favor rich people over poor people.

2:1a–b

My brothers, as you hold out your faith in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ, do not show favoritism:

James commanded God’s people to treat everyone equally. They must not show favoritism. The basis for his command was that they are believers in Jesus. They must live in a way that is fitting and right for those who are believers.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

since/because you believe..., do not show favoritism.

if you believe..., then do not show favoritism.

now that you believe..., do not show favoritism.

you believe.... So, do not show favoritism.

2:1a

My brothers, as you hold out your faith in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ My brothers, since/because you^(plur) believe in our^(incl) wonderful/great Lord Jesus Christ,
- ¶ My brothers and sisters, as people who believe in our^(incl) wonderful/great Lord/Master, Jesus Christ,
- ¶ My fellow believers, you^(plur) trust in Jesus, our^(incl) supreme/high Chief and Christ/Messiah. He is worthy of praise/honor.

My brothers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My brothers refers to other believers in Christ to whom James was writing. It refers to both men and women.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

My fellow believers

My brothers and sisters (NET)

My relatives/siblings in Christ

My Christian friends

This same phrase occurs in 1:2a.

James used the term of address My brothers here to introduce the topic of proper treatment toward poor believers and to soften his command “don’t show favoritism.” (2:1b) You may have another way in your language to introduce a change of topic or to soften a command. If so, consider using it here.

as you hold out your faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as you hold out your faith is literally “have the faith.” This phrase refers to those who trust in, rely on, or are committed to Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

as those who trust in

since you rely/depend upon

as people who are committed to

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning.

See believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

our glorious Lord Jesus Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as our glorious Lord Jesus Christ indicates that glory in some way belongs to or describes the Lord Jesus Christ.

The word glorious means that our Lord Jesus Christ is majestic and worthy of praise and honor. He is wonderful and great.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

our majestic Lord Jesus Christ

our wonderful Lord Jesus Christ

our Lord Jesus Christ. He is worthy of praise.

Lord Jesus Christ: The phrase Lord Jesus Christ also occurs in 1:1a. See the note on 1:1a for help in translating this phrase.

2:1b

do not show favoritism.

- you^(plur) must not favor certain people.
- So do not show more honor/respect to some people than you^(plur) do to others.

do not show favoritism: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as show favoritism refers to treating some people better than others. This is done because they have much wealth or because they have a high position in society.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

do not favor rich people more than poor people

do not honor/respect some people more than others

The way you treat people should not be determined by their wealth or status in society

The Greek word is plural. This implies “many acts of favoritism.” James was thinking of a habitual way of behaving. For example:

You should not make a habit of treating some people better because they are wealthier

you must always be impartial (REB)

Some languages have an idiom for referring to the practice of giving special treatment to rich or powerful people.

James 2:2

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:1–4

In this paragraph, James taught that believers must not favor rich people over poor people.

2:2–4

Verses 2:2–4 contain a specific example of showing favoritism. James gave this example to reinforce the command he gave in 2:1.

2:2a

Suppose a man comes into your meeting wearing a gold ring and fine clothes,

- Suppose that a man enters your^(plur) assembly wearing gold rings and wearing fine/splendid clothes.
- For example, a certain man visits your^(plur) congregation. He is well-dressed and wears expensive gold rings on his fingers.

Suppose: The word Suppose introduces an example of showing favoritism. Consider how your language naturally introduces an example.

Some other ways to begin this example are:

For example (GW)

For instance (REB)

Let us say

your meeting: The phrase your meeting refers to a gathering of Christians to worship the Lord. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

your assembly (RSV)

your church meeting (NCV)

your worship service

wearing a gold ring: The Greek adjective that the BSB translates as wearing a gold ring is literally “gold-fingered.” Notice that the word ring is not actually in the Greek. But many versions add the word ring to make the sense clear. This word indicates that the man was rich.

The Greek does not specify whether the man was wearing one ring or many rings. However, at the time when James wrote, it was customary for very rich people to wear many rings on their fingers. See Hiebert, pages 151–152 for more information on this point; also Martin, page 61. So it is good to use “rings.” For example:

wearing gold rings (GW)

If rings do not signify wealth in your culture, use another phrase to show that the man was rich. For example:

wearing gold

wearing expensive gold rings

expensive jewelry (NLT)

wearing things that rich people wear

fine clothes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fine literally means “bright, shining.” This word was especially used for clothes that were pure white (as in Acts 10:30). Wealthy men in James’ day often wore white clothes. So this word also shows that the man in this example was rich.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

well-dressed (REB)

glamorous/splendid clothes

expensive clothes

elegantly bright clothes

2:2b

and a poor man in shabby clothes also comes in.

- And also a poor man who is wearing dirty clothes enters.
- A poor man also visits your^(plur) service. He is wearing worn-out clothing.

shabby clothes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as shabby means “dirty.” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

grimy clothes (REB)

filthy clothes (NET)

worn-out clothes (CEV)

James 2:3

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:1–4

In this paragraph, James taught that believers must not favor rich people over poor people.

2:3a

If you lavish attention on the man in fine clothes

- If you^(plur) show more respect to the man who wears fine clothes
- Then you^(plur) show more consideration/respect to the well-dressed man than to the poor man.

If you lavish attention on the man in fine clothes:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as lavish attention on means “look at someone in a way that shows that you care about them and are interested in their needs.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

If you show more respect to the well-dressed man (GNT)

You honor the rich man

and if you take notice of the one wearing the fine clothes (NRSV)

2:3b

and say, “Here is a seat of honor,”

- and you^(plur) say, “Come sit^(sing) here in this good seat,”
- You^(plur) say to him, “Sir, please come^(sing) have a seat here at the front.”
- You^(plur) invite him to sit in a nice seat.

Here is a seat of honor: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Here is a good seat of honor is literally “You sit here well.” There are two ways to interpret the word “well” in this context:

1. It refers to a good seat, either because the seat is more comfortable than others or because it is a seat of honor. Alford, page 291; Huther, page 102; Mayor, page 81; Hiebert, page 153; Adamson (1976), page 106; Laws, page 99; Davids (1982), page 109; Martin, page 62. For example, the NET says:

You sit here in a good place. (BSB, NIV, NJB, GNT, NASB, KJV, NET, NLT, CEV, ESV)

1. It indicates a polite request, “please” Ropes, page 190; Adamson (1989), page 279 note 43; Dibelius, page 131; Lenski, page 565. For example, the REB says:

Please take this seat. (RSV, REB, GW)

In many cultures, it is important to speak politely to important people. So, even though interpretation (1) is the preferred interpretation, your translation may combine interpretations (1) and (2). For example:

Sir, here is a good seat for you

Please, sir, sit here in this nice seat

2:3c

but say to the poor man, “You must stand”

- but you^(plur) say to the poor man, “Go stand^(sing) over there,”
- However, you^(plur) tell the poor man to go stand at the side,

2:3c–d

“You must stand” or “Sit at my feet,”: In the earliest Greek manuscripts, there were no punctuation marks. There are two ways to punctuate this sentence:

1. There should be two separate quotations. According to this interpretation, these two clauses are two possible commands. Adamson (1976), page 101; Dibelius, page 132; Lenski, page 565. For example, the NET says:

“You stand over there,” or “Sit on the floor.” (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NET, GW, NCV, ESV)

1. There should be only one quotation. According to this interpretation, the poor man was given two choices: sit on the ground or stand. Alford, page 291; Huther, page 102; Mitton, page 83; Hiebert, page 153; Moo (1985), page 89; Martin, page 62. For example, the REB says:

‘You stand over there, or sit here on the floor by my footstool,’ (KJV, REB, NASB, GNT, NLT, JBP)

It seems unlikely that people would give the poor man a choice between sitting or standing. It seems more likely that James mentioned two commands that people might give to a poor man. Therefore, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Another way to translate this is:

but to the poor man you either say, “Stand over there,” or you say, “Sit on the ground/floor.”

2:3d

or “Sit at my feet,”

- or you^(plur) say, “You^(sing) sit there on the ground at my feet,”
- or perhaps you^(plur) tell him to go^(sing) sit on the ground.

“Sit at my feet,”: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sit at my feet is literally “sit below my footstool.” At the time when James lived, important people used to sit on a fine chair with a low stool in

front of it. They would rest their feet on this stool. This was called a footstool. Poor people would sit on the floor below the level of the rich person’s feet on the footstool.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

sit here on the floor by my footstool (REB)

sit on the floor next to my chair

sit down next to my feet

What is important here is not the footstool itself but the fact that “below the footstool” represents the most inferior place. Use an expression that shows that the speaker is showing contempt for the poor man. For example:

sit on the ground

go sit over there

General Comment on 2:3a–d

When translating the words spoken to the two men who might come into the worship place, it is more natural in some languages to use indirect speech. For example:

You must not give the best seat to the one in fancy clothes and tell the one who is poor to stand at the side or sit on the floor. (CEV)

James 2:4

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:1–4

In this paragraph, James taught that believers must not favor rich people over poor people.

2:4a–b

have you not discriminated among yourselves and become judges with evil thoughts?: This is a rhetorical question. James was not asking for information but making an emphatic statement: “You certainly have discriminated.” He was also implying that they had done some things wrong, and he was rebuking them for it.

Some ways to translate this emphasis and rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you not see that you are discriminating among your members and judging by wrong standards? (REB)

You have discriminated among yourselves. You have become judges with evil thoughts. Why have you done that?

- As a statement. For example:

You have certainly done wrong by discriminating among yourselves and becoming judges with evil thoughts.

That is the same as saying that some people are better than others, and you would be acting like a crooked judge. (CEV)

Translate this emphasis and rebuke in the way that is natural in your language for making a strong statement.

2:4a**have you not discriminated among yourselves**

- you^(plur) have discriminated among yourselves.
- If you^(plur) act like that, you show that you think that some people are better than others.
- When you^(plur) do that, you certainly show by your actions that you think that the rich people in your congregation are more important than the poor people.

have you not discriminated among yourselves: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you...discriminated among yourselves means “you think that some people are better than others, and so you treat them better.” By treating the rich and the poor differently, they were creating distinctions within the fellowship

of God’s people. The meaning is essentially the same as “show favoritism” in 2:1.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

have you not made distinctions among yourselves (RSV)

You are making some people more important than others (NCV)

You are treating some members of your congregation as if they were better than others

That is the same as saying that some people are better than others (CEV)

2:4b**and become judges with evil thoughts?**

- You^(plur) have become like judges with evil thoughts/motives. Why have you done that?
- You^(plur) are acting like corrupt judges.
- You^(plur) have judged/decided that one person is better than another. That is evil.

and become judges with evil thoughts: This is a metaphor. When people in the Christian community discriminated and favored the rich over the poor, they were acting like evil judges. There is also a word play in Greek that strengthens the comparison. When Christians judge in the sense that they discriminate (*διακρίνω*), they are like evil judges (*κριτής*). Both words are built off the Greek root (*κρίνω*) that means “to judge.” Some ways that these Christian people and judges with evil thoughts are similar are:

1. both make decisions about who is good/right and who is evil/wrong.
2. both prefer the rich. They unjustly make decisions that favor the rich.

When Christians act this way, they become like judges who have evil thoughts.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

and you would be acting like a crooked judge (CEV)

you have become like evil judges who mistreat good people

- Keep the metaphor as in the BSB. In some languages, it may be necessary to translate the noun “judge” as a verb. For example:

you have become people who have evil thoughts and who judge the rich man better than the poor man

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

You think that you can decide who is worthy of honor. That is a wrong way of thinking.

you favor the rich because of what you hope to receive from them. That is an evil way of thinking.

This phrase does not mean that these Christians had become judges who sit in a court.

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

with evil thoughts: The phrase with evil thoughts means evil in their way of thinking. It includes the idea that these people judge with an evil standard. This means that they make decisions based on someone’s wealth and social status. It also means that they decide with evil motives. Some commentators (Moo (2000), page 105; Martin, page 64; McCartney, pages 140 and 144) point out that in a legal context, it is also possible to interpret this as “evil verdicts.” They make decisions based on what they can get, such as a bribe.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

with evil motives (NASB)

using a corrupt standard (GW)

evil/corrupt judges

James 2:5

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:5–7

In this paragraph, James wrote about two further reasons why Christians should not favor a rich person above a poor one. The reasons are:

1. that God honors poor people, and
2. that the enemies of Christ and the church are more likely to be rich people.

2:5a

Listen, my beloved brothers:

- ¶ My dear brothers and sisters, listen^(plur)!
- ¶ Be^(plur) attentive, my beloved fellow believers!

Listen: James used the word Listen so that his readers would pay special attention to what he wrote next. Some other ways to translate Listen are:

Be attentive to what I am about to say

Please think about this

In your translation, use whatever a speaker of your language would say in order to encourage his listeners to focus their thoughts on the next words.

my beloved brothers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as my beloved brothers refers to believers in Christ to whom James was writing. It refers to both men and women.

For suggestions on translating this phrase, see the note in 1:16 where this same phrase occurs.

The BSB places the phrase my beloved brothers at the beginning of 2:5, right after the word “listen.” This follows the Greek text. In some languages, it may be more natural to place it before the word “listen.”

2:5b–e

Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him?: This is a rhetorical question.

James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that God had certainly chosen the people whom society regards as being poor. He chose them to be rich in faith.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. In some languages, it will be more natural to divide this long question into two questions. For example:

Do you not know that God has chosen those who are poor to be rich in faith? Do you not know that he has chosen them to obtain the kingdom that he promised to those who love him?

God has chosen those who are poor to be rich in faith, right? God has chosen them to inherit the kingdom he promised those who love him, right?

- As a statement. For example:

God has certainly chosen those who are poor in the eyes of the world to be rich in faith. He has certainly chosen them to inherit the kingdom that he has promised to those who love him.

God chose the poor people of this world to be rich in faith and to possess the kingdom which he promised to those who love him. (GNT)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

2:5b

Has not God chosen the poor of this world

- Did not God choose people who are poor in the things of this world
- God often chooses people whom others regard as being poor
- God has certainly chosen poor people

Has not God chosen the poor: The clause Has not God chosen the poor refers to the fact that most of the people whom God has chosen are poor. It does not mean that all poor people are rich in faith. In some languages, it is more natural to make that clear. For example:

God has often chosen those who are poor

It is those people who are poor...whom God has often chosen

God has certainly chosen more poor people than rich people

the poor of this world: The phrase that the BSB translates as poor of this world is literally “poor in

the world” or possibly “poor to the world.” The grammatical dative *τῷ κόσμῳ* can be understood in various ways including as: a) a locative identifying the place where they are poor, b) an ethical dative (also called dative of interest), poor in the opinion of the world, or c) a dative of respect, poor in regard to the things of the world. This means that they had little of the things that the people (especially unbelievers) considered valuable. They had little land, money, and other possessions. There are differences of interpretation represented in the versions and discussed in commentaries. It could mean poor with reference to worldly things (McCartney, page 141) or poor in the eyes of the world (the majority of commentators). We felt the difference is subtle and both are true: these poor were in reality poor in terms of material possessions and they were considered poor.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

poor in things and money

poor according to the way people think

In some languages, it may be possible to translate “poor in/to the world” simply as “poor.” Readers will understand that the poor have very little or no money, land, or possessions. They are poor according to the way that people think.

2:5c

to be rich in faith

- to be rich in believing
- to be rich in faith, right?
- to trust/believe in Christ. When they trust, it may be said that they have real riches.

to be rich in faith: The phrase rich in faith contrasts with “poor of this world” (2:5b). These people were actually rich because they had placed their faith in Christ and had the benefits of such faith. This is something of great value.

This phrase does not necessarily indicate that they had a lot of faith. It simply means that they had faith.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Translate it literally using the word rich. For example:

to be rich in faith/believing

to rather be rich because they have faith

- Show that the word rich is used in a spiritual sense. For example:

to believe in Christ. When they believe, it may be said that they are rich.

- Use a word other than rich that fits better with faith. For example:

to instead have faith, which is truly valuable

in faith: The word faith refers here to faith in Jesus. If it is necessary to include an object for the verb “believe,” use “our Lord Jesus Christ” as in 2:1, or simply “Jesus Christ.” “Faith in Jesus” means to trust, to rely on, and to be committed to him.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

trust in our Lord Jesus Christ

reliance/dependence upon Jesus Christ

confidence in Jesus Christ

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun faith with a verb. Some ways to do this are:

relying/depending on Jesus

trusting in Jesus

believing in Jesus

trusting in and committing to Jesus

having confidence in Jesus

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning.

See believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

2:5d

and to inherit the kingdom

- and to obtain his kingdom
- He has chosen poor people to possess the kingdom
- He has also chosen them to receive the benefits of his ruling them.

to inherit the kingdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to inherit the kingdom is literally “to

be heirs of the kingdom” (as in the RSV). The “heirs” are God’s children, so they will receive all the blessings that God has promised to give to his people.

The phrase the kingdom refers to the kingdom of God. The kingdom of God refers to God ruling and caring for his people as their king. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to have a share/part in his kingdom

to be citizens/subjects of his kingdom

to receive the eternal blessings of his kingdom

to have the benefits of being a citizen of his kingdom

to be blessed by having him as their/our king

2:5e

He promised those who love Him?

- that he promised to all those who love him?
- that he promised to the people who love him, right?
- God promised that he would give these benefits/blessings to all of us^(incl) who love him.

He promised those who love Him: This clause describes the kingdom. In some languages, it will be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

God has promised this kingdom to those who love him.

promised: The Greek word that the BSB translates as promised means “said or announced with certainty that he will do something.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

said he would do

vowed

assured

those who love Him: The phrase those who love him refers to all believers. James is saying that poor believers are included in this group. Some other ways to translate this are:

to all those who love him

to everyone who loves him

to all of us who love him

The same words occur in 1:12d.

James 2:6

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:5–7

In this paragraph, James wrote about two further reasons why Christians should not favor a rich person above a poor one. The reasons are:

1. that God honors poor people, and
2. that the enemies of Christ and the church are more likely to be rich people.

2:6a

But you have dishonored the poor.

- But you,^(plur) you have dishonored that poor man!
- But as for you,^(plur) you have shown no respect to the poor man! Why do you do that?

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what God had done (chosen the poor) in 2:5, and what James' readers had done (dishonored the poor) in 2:6.

you have dishonored: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dishonored refers to being rude to someone by what you do or say. The believers whom James

was addressing should have realized that the poor person was important to God. Instead they treated him as someone who deserved no respect.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

you have insulted (NIV)

you have humiliated

you have treated shamefully

you have shown no respect

you: The pronoun you is emphatic in Greek. One way to translate this is:

as for you, you

the poor: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the poor is singular. So James was probably referring again to his example, and the poor is the poor man of 2:2–3. For example:

the poor man (NLT96)

2:6b–7b

The rhetorical questions in 2:6b–7b all imply that it was foolish to honor the rich, because they were the very ones who were being cruel to Christian believers. You may be able to show this by making some of this information explicit in 2:6. For example:

^{2:6a}But you have dishonored the poor and honored the rich. Why?. ^{2:6b}Is it not the rich who are exploiting you?

^{2:6a}But you have insulted the poor. ^{2:6b}You are foolish! Is it not the rich who oppress you?

2:6b–c

In Greek and the BSB, 2:6b–c forms one rhetorical question. Some translations, however, translate 2:6b–c as two rhetorical questions. For example:

Is it not the rich who are exploiting you? Are they not the ones who are dragging you into court? (NIV)

Do whatever is clearest and easiest to understand in your language.

2:6b**Is it not the rich who oppress you**

- Is it not the rich people who are oppressing you^(plur)
- It is rich people who are causing you^(plur) trouble, right?
- You certainly know that it is rich people who cause you^(plur) to suffer!

Is it not the rich who oppress you: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that it was the rich people who were exploiting the believers. He implied that his readers knew this very well. For that reason, their custom of treating the rich better than the poor did not make much sense.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

are not the rich your oppressors? (REB)

It is the rich people who are oppressing you, right?

- As a statement. For example:

The rich are always trying to control your lives.
(NCV)

You know that it's the rich people who oppress you.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

the rich: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the rich is plural. James was referring to rich people in general. For example:

rich people (GW)

oppress: The Greek word that the BSB translates as oppress means “oppressing, dominating, causing severe hardship.” James meant that rich people were using their power against the poor and making them suffer while helping themselves to become richer.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

taking advantage of you

mistreating you

control your lives (NCV)

causing you to suffer

2:6c**and drag you into court?**

- and forcing you^(plur) to go to court?
- It is rich people who are taking you^(plur) to court, right?
- You^(plur) know that they are the ones who force you to appear before judges.

and drag you into court?: This is a rhetorical question. James again emphasized that it was the rich people who were mistreating believers.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it not they who drag you into court? (NRSV)

It is the rich people who drag you into court, right?

- As a statement. For example:

It is the rich people who are forcing you to appear before the law court.

They are the ones who take you to court. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

drag you into court: The Greek word that the BSB translates as drag means “forcing to go.” Rich people were taking poor people to court, making false accusations against them, and treating them unjustly.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

take you to court (NCV)

force you to go before the judges

James 2:7**Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism**

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:5–7

In this paragraph, James wrote about two further reasons why Christians should not favor a rich person above a poor one. The reasons are:

1. that God honors poor people, and
2. that the enemies of Christ and the church are more likely to be rich people.

2:7a–b

Are they not the ones who blaspheme the noble name by which you have been called?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that it was the rich people, not the poor, who were speaking against Christ.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do they not blaspheme the good name of the one you belong to? (NET)

They are the ones who are slandering the noble name of him to whom you belong, right?

- As a statement. For example:

They are the ones who speak evil of that good name which has been given to you. (GNT)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

2:7a

Are they not the ones who blaspheme

- Is it not those people who are slandering/blaspheming
- It is rich people who are insulting
- And they are the ones who insult/disgrace

blaspheme: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blaspheme means “speaking evil of someone” or “insulting and saying bad things about someone.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

insulting

profaning

speaking evil against

disgracing

This same Greek word is also translated as “slandering” (as in the NIV).

2:7b

the noble name by which you have been called?

- the honorable name of him whose people you^(plur) are?
- the good name of him/Jesus who is your^(plur) master/ chief, right?
- the excellent name of Jesus Christ. He is the one to whom we^(incl) belong.

the noble name by which you have been called:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the noble name by which you have been called is literally “the noble name that has been called upon/over you.” This “name that has been called over you” is the name that Jesus has given to you. Jesus gave his name to you to show that you belong to him. In other words, you/ we are now in special relation to Jesus and part of his family.

The phrase the noble name refers to the name of Jesus Christ. His name is noble in the sense that it is a good, excellent, or honorable name. He is the one to whom James’ readers belong.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the honorable/good name of Jesus, the one to whom you belong

the praiseworthy name of Jesus Christ. He is the one to whom you belong

the holy name of the one who is our master, Jesus Christ

the excellent name of Jesus Christ, whose people you became when you trusted in him

General Comment on 2:7a–b

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of 2:7a and 2:7b. For example:

^{7b}You belong to him who has a noble name. ^{7a}Are they not slandering his name?

James 2:8

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:8–11

This paragraph indicates that showing favor to rich people is breaking God's law. God told us to love everyone as we love ourselves. If we do not treat poor people as well as we treat rich people, we are not loving poor people. So we are not loving everyone as we love ourselves. As a result, we break God's law.

2:8a

If you really fulfill the royal law

- ¶ If you^(plur) obey the law of God the king
- ¶ If you^(plur) follow the commands of God our^(incl) king,

If you really fulfill the royal law: There are at least three ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as really:

1. It indicates a contrast with 2:9. It means “^{2:8}if, on the one hand, you keep the royal law.... ^{2:9}But if, on the other hand, you show favoritism....” This understands *μεντοι ... δε* to function in a similar way to *μεν ... δε*. Some versions show this contrast only at the beginning of 2:9. For example, the GNT says:

^{8d}You will be doing the right thing ^{8a}if you obey the law of the Kingdom,...^{9a}But if you... (KJV, GNT, CEV, JBP, NCV) It is not certain that these versions are following this interpretation. But since *μεν* is often left untranslated in a *μεν ... δε* construction, it is possible that these versions are interpreting (and translating) *μεντοι ... δε* in a similar way to *μεν ... δε*.)

1. It indicates that something is true, and it indicates it with emphasis. It can be translated as “really,” “truly,” or “in fact.” (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, NLT)
2. It indicates a contrast with what comes before. In this context, it contrasts with showing partiality against poor people as described in 2:1–7 and explicitly noted in 2:6a, “you have insulted the poor.” It can be translated as “but” or “however.” For example, the NASB says:

If, however, you are fulfilling the royal law...
(NASB, REB, NET)

In the case of interpretations (2) and (3), some scholars also think that this conjunction indicates some irony. In other words, James implies that people are not really keeping the royal law. See, for example: Davids (1982), page 114; McCartney, pages 147–148; Tasker, page 60.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is certain that the conjunction shows contrast with 2:9. It may also show contrast with what goes before or emphasize the truth of the statement (or show irony), but this is less certain. And these should be clear from the context with or without a conjunction.

In most languages, it will be enough to mark the contrast at the beginning of 2:9. So it may not be necessary to translate the conjunction here. Or you may have a way to show that a pair of things are being contrasted. For example:

on the one hand,...on the other hand

fulfill: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfill means “obey.” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

If you obey the royal law

If you do what God said in the royal law

the royal law: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the royal law is literally “kingly law.” This law comes from a king and is the law of the kingdom. Here the king is God.

This phrase refers to the whole of God's law, and it consists of many commands. It does not refer specifically to the command that follows (“Love your neighbor as yourself”) though that is one very important command within God's law.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the law of the Kingdom (GNT)

the law of God the/our King

law from the highest authority (GW)

2:8b

stated in Scripture,

- that is written in Scripture:
- in particular the one in his written word that says

stated in Scripture: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as stated in Scripture is literally “according to the Scripture” (as in the RSV). The royal law is written in the Scripture.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the Scripture

written in Scripture

as God said in the Scripture

by keeping in particular God’s command which says

Scripture: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Scripture is used in a special way in the New Testament. It refers to words that God directed someone to write. Such writings had authority because God guided a person to write them. In the New Testament the word Scripture almost always refers to something that was written in the Old Testament. Here it refers to the verse which follows, quoted from Leviticus 19:18.

Some other ways to translate Scripture are:

God’s written words

this word of God that someone/Moses wrote

God’s written command

2:8c

“Love your neighbor as yourself,”

- “Love your^(sing) neighbor as you love yourself,”

- that people should love their fellow human beings as well as they love themselves,

Love your neighbor as yourself: In Greek, the word Love is singular. The word neighbor is also singular. However, this command was intended for everyone. It was also intended to command us to love all our neighbors, not just one. In many languages, it will be more natural to use plurals here. For example:

Love^(sing) your neighbors as yourself

Love^(plur) your neighbors as you^(plur) love yourselves

People should love their neighbors as they love themselves

This command also occurs in Matthew 19:19; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27; and Romans 13:9. You should translate it here as you did in these other passages.

Love: In this context, Love refers to seeking the well-being of others. It does not refer to having warm feelings towards them. It also does not refer to romantic love.

Some other ways to translate this are:

Do what is best for

Act lovingly toward

Do good things that show you care for

neighbor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as neighbor literally refers to someone who lives nearby. It also refers to someone of the same social group or someone who speaks the same language. It can also refer to anyone you interact with.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

person who is near you

fellow human being

people you interact with

General Comment on 2:8a–d

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of 2:8a–d. For example:

^{8b}In Scripture, ^{8a}the royal law is/says, ^{8c}“Love your neighbor as yourself.” ^{8a}If you really keep this law, ^{8d}you do well.

^{8b}The Scripture says, ^{8c}“Love your neighbor as yourself.” ^{8a}This is the royal law. If you keep this law, ^{8d}you do well.

2:8d you are doing well.

- you^(plur) do well.
- you^(plur) are doing what you should do.

James 2:9

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:8–11

This paragraph indicates that showing favor to rich people is breaking God’s law. God told us to love everyone as we love ourselves. If we do not treat poor people as well as we treat rich people, we are not loving poor people. So we are not loving everyone as we love ourselves. As a result, we break God’s law.

2:9a

But if you show favoritism,

- But if you^(plur) favor certain people,
- But if you^(plur) show more honor/respect to some people than to others,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. The contrast is between loving your neighbor and thus keeping the law (in 2:8) and showing favoritism and thus breaking the law (in 2:9).

if you show favoritism: The Greek word that the BSB translates as show favoritism refers to treating some

people better than others because of their wealth or position in society.

The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as you show favoritism implies the person is habitually showing favoritism. This verb is from the same root as the noun that the BSB translates as favoritism in 2:1b. See the notes there for translation advice.

2:9b

you sin and are convicted by the law as transgressors.

- you^(plur) are sinning, and God’s law convicts/condemns you as people who break the law.
- you^(plur) are doing evil/wrong. You are guilty of disobeying God’s law.

you sin: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you sin is literally “you do a sin.” In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this using the verb sin (as the BSB does).

Here James wrote that when a person shows favoritism, he disobeys God and God’s law. That is a sin.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

you do what is wrong/evil

you offend/disobey God

you are doing things against God

See also the note on “sin” at 1:15b.

are convicted by the law: The Greek word that the BSB translates as convicted means “shown or proven to be guilty.” This is a passive verb. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

are convicted by the law (NET)

are shown to be guilty by the law

- Use an active verb. For example:

the Law condemns you (GNT)

the Scriptures teach that you have sinned (CEV)

the law: The phrase the law refers to the same law that was called “the royal law” in 2:8a. Notice that

in this verse the law is personified. This means that James said that the law did something as if it were a person. It “convicts” somebody just as a judge or prosecutor proves that somebody disobeyed a law of the government.

In some languages, it may be more natural not to personify the word law. If this is the case in your language, you could say something like:

You are guilty of breaking the law (NLT)

you deserve punishment for disobeying God’s commands

as transgressors: The Greek word that the BSB translates as transgressors means “people who do things contrary to what God commanded in the law.” It refers to people who deliberately disobey the law. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this noun as a phrase. For example:

people who disobey God’s laws

a person who does not do what God told people to do

those who violate God’s laws

In some languages, it may be possible to translate the phrase “are convicted by the law” and the phrase “as lawbreakers” as one phrase. For example:

You are guilty of not obeying the law.

James 2:10

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:8–11

This paragraph indicates that showing favor to rich people is breaking God’s law. God told us to love everyone as we love ourselves. If we do not treat poor people as well as we treat rich people, we are not loving poor people. So we are not loving everyone as we love ourselves. As a result, we break God’s law.

2:10–11

Verses 2:10–11 explain how someone who favors rich people is a lawbreaker. When someone shows favoritism, he is not keeping the part of the law that tells him to love his neighbor as himself. He has broken this one commandment in the law, so he has broken all the law.

In some languages, James’ explanation will be clearer if some clauses in 2:10–11 are reordered. See the General Comment on 2:10–11 at the end of 2:11e for an example.

2:10a

Whoever keeps the whole law

- Because he who keeps the entire law,
- The reason I said this is, if you^(plur) obey all of God’s laws,

In Greek, 2:10 begins with a conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.” The Greek word introduces an explanation of 2:9. The BSB has left this conjunction implicit. Consider whether you need a conjunction or phrase in your language to make the relationship between 2:9 and 2:10–11 clear.

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

Because

The reason I said this is

the whole law: The phrase the whole law refers to all the commands and instructions that are part of God’s law. See the note at 2:8a where God’s law is called “the royal law.”

2:10b

but stumbles at just one point

- but fails to keep just one law,
- except that you^(plur) go wrong in one matter,

stumbles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stumbles is used figuratively. Here in the context of following God’s laws and rules, it means “does not

obey every one of God's commands" or "does something wrong."

Some other ways to translate this word are:

fails to obey (NCV)

does not keep

does not do what God has said

just one point: The phrase that the BSB translates as just one point refers to any one commandment of the law. The way in which this person has gone wrong is that he has broken only one out of all the commandments.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

only one commandment/law

only one part

in one single matter

2:10c

is guilty of breaking all of it.

- is guilty of breaking the whole law.
- you^(plur) are responsible for having disobeyed all the laws.

is guilty: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is guilty is literally "has become guilty" (as in the RSV). The verb "has become" emphasizes the person's situation. It can also be translated as "is" (as in the BSB).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

is responsible

has become accountable (ESV)

of breaking all of it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all of it is literally "all." It refers to breaking/disobeying the law as a whole or as a unit (even though the law as a whole is made up of individual commands).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

of disobeying the whole law

of failing to keep the entire law of God

of breaking God's laws/commands

James 2:11

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:8–11

This paragraph indicates that showing favor to rich people is breaking God's law. God told us to love everyone as we love ourselves. If we do not treat poor people as well as we treat rich people, we are not loving poor people. So we are not loving everyone as we love ourselves. As a result, we break God's law.

2:11a–b

"Do not commit adultery," also said, "Do not murder.": The Greek phrases that the BSB translates as Do not commit adultery and Do not murder are commands. Here these commands are singular just as they are in the Old Testament in Hebrew. God gave these commands to each Israelite.

In some languages, people do not use a singular form to give a general command like this. Use whatever form is natural in your language for giving this type of general command. For example:

You^(plur) must not commit adultery. You^(plur) must not murder.

People must not commit adultery. People must not murder.

Also, in some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

The same God who told us to be faithful in marriage also told us not to murder. (CEV)

2:11a

For He who said, “Do not commit adultery,”

- For he who said, “You^(sing) must not commit adultery”
- God commanded us^(incl) not to behave immorally with someone who is not our spouse.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces an example of the statement that James made in 2:10. That statement is, “If you break one law, you are guilty of breaking all the law.”

In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary here.

He who said: The word He refers to God. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

For the same God who said (NLT)

Because God said both

“Do not commit adultery,”: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commit adultery refers to a man or woman having sexual relations with someone who is married to someone else. It also refers to a married person having sexual relations with anyone other than their spouse.

Many languages have hidden ways of saying adultery that are understood but do not embarrass people when it is read in public. For example:

do not behave immorally with one not your spouse

be faithful in marriage (CEV)

Do not have sexual relations with anyone who is not your spouse

The same word occurs in Matthew 5:27; Luke 18:20; and Romans 13:9.

2:11b

also said, “Do not murder.”

- also said, “You^(sing) must not murder people.”
- He also commanded us^(incl) not to kill people.

“Do not murder.”: The Greek word that the BSB translates as murder means “kill someone deliberately.” Some ways to translate this phrase are:

Do not kill

Do not purposefully cause someone to die

Do not intentionally slay someone

2:11c

If you do not commit adultery,

- Therefore, if you^(sing) do not commit adultery,
- So for example, someone who does not behave immorally,

2:11d

but do commit murder,

- but you^(sing) murder a person,
- but who has killed someone,

2:11c-e

If you do not commit adultery, but do commit murder, you have become a lawbreaker: James used an “if” clause to begin a specific example of his principle in 2:10. (The principle is that someone who breaks one point of the law breaks the entire law.) In some languages, it may be more natural to begin a specific example without using an “if” clause. For example:

^{11c}Someone who does not commit adultery, ^{11d}but commits murder, ^{11e}is still a lawbreaker.

2:11e

you have become a lawbreaker.

- you^(sing) have broken God’s law.
- has disobeyed God’s commands. So when you^(plur) show favoritism, you are not keeping the law to love your neighbor as yourself. Therefore, you have disobeyed God’s commands.

you have become a lawbreaker: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you have become could also be translated as “you are.” It emphasizes the person’s situation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you are a breaker of the law (REB)

you are guilty of breaking God’s law

you are a person who does not obey God’s laws

you are a person who does not do what God says to do

General Comment on 2:11c–e

In some languages, it may be natural to reorder these verse parts as the REB has done:

^{11c}If you commit murder ^{11e}you are a breaker of the law, ^{11d}even if you do not commit adultery as well.

General Comment on 2:10–11

In some languages, James' explanation will be clearer if some clauses in 2:10 and 2:11 are reordered. His explanation may also be clearer if some information is made explicit. For example:

^{10b}Anyone who stumbles at just one point of the law ^{10c}is guilty of breaking all of it ^{10a}even if he keeps the rest of the law. ^{11d}For example, if someone commits murder ^{11c}but never commits adultery, ^{11e}he is a lawbreaker ^{11b}because God told us both not to murder and ^{11a}not to commit adultery. So that is why, when you show favoritism, you are breaking the law. You are not following God's command to love your neighbor as yourself.

James 2:12

Section 2:1–13: Believers must avoid favoritism

The theme of this section is that Christians should not treat rich people better than poor people. They should treat everyone with kindness. This is one of the marks of a truly godly person.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Show mercy and honor to poor people and thereby fulfill the royal law of love

Obey the law of love by treating poor people with mercy and honor

Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:12–13

In this paragraph, James warned his readers that God will judge all people based on how they act toward others. He requires his people to be merciful to others. This is a conclusion to 2:1–11.

In some languages, it will be natural to begin this paragraph with a conjunction indicating that it is a conclusion. For example:

So (NLT)

Therefore

2:12a

Speak and act as those who are going to be judged

- ¶! Speak and act like people who will be judged (CEV)
- ¶! So, whatever you^(plur) say or whatever you do, remember that one day God will decide if you are innocent/righteous or guilty.
- ¶! Therefore, speak^(plur) and behave carefully/mercifully, because God will examine people's lives

Speak and act: The verbs Speak and act refer to normal, everyday conversation and behavior. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Talk and behave

So whatever you say or whatever you do (NLT)

In everything you say and do (NCV)

as those who are going to be judged: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as as those who are going to be judged indicates that people will be judged. A future judgment is certain to happen. The word as does not mean that people should just behave "as if" judgment were going to happen.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

like people who will be judged (CEV)

remember that you will be judged (NCV)

because you are going to be judged

those who are going to be judged: This is a passive verb phrase. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

people who will be judged (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

people whom God will judge

be judged: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be judged is a legal word. It describes the work of a judge in court. A judge:

1. examines and considers the evidence

2. pronounces the person innocent or guilty
3. decides the punishment (if the person is guilty)

In this verse, God is the judge, and the focus is probably on (a) and (b) above. God will evaluate whether each person has kept his law. On that basis, he will decide whether the person is innocent or guilty. Many commentators (see, for example, Lenski, pages 574–575; McCartney, page 150; Mitton, pages 95–96; Moo (2000), pages 116 and 118) in looking at the wider context of Scripture take the position that this judgment does not lead directly to a verdict of guilt or innocence before God based on the law. Rather obedience to the law is evidence that someone has been shown grace. Their actions and particularly their actions of grace and mercy to all people demonstrate that they are truly saved. Those who have obeyed his law, in particular the law which says to love your neighbor (2:8), will be judged to be righteous. Those who have not obeyed his law will be judged to be guilty.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

be examined/evaluated

God will consider the evidence and decide whether they are innocent or guilty

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

2:12b

by the law that gives freedom.

- according to the law that frees us^(incl),
- He will decide using the commands that free us^(incl) from our sins.
- to see if they have obeyed his commands/rules. These commands/rules free us^(incl) from our sins.

by the law: The phrase by the law indicates that the law is the standard by which, or according to which, God will judge us.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

according to the law

using the law

As in 1:25, the word law refers to the complete set of instructions and commands from God. It does not refer to just one law. So in some languages, it is more natural to use the plural “laws” here. For example:

by laws (GW)

that gives freedom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that gives freedom describes what the law does for people who obey it. It sets them free from sin.

Some other ways to translate the expression the law that gives freedom are:

the law that sets us/you free

the law that makes people free (NCV)

the law that frees people from sin

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this phrase as a separate sentence. For example:

^{12a}Speak and act as those who are going to be judged ^{12b}by the law. This law gives freedom to do what God wants us to do.

See the note “of freedom” in 1:25a, where the same Greek expression occurs.

General Comment on 2:12a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{12a}You are going to be judged ^{12b}according to the law that gives freedom. ^{12a}So be careful to speak and act appropriately.

^{12b}God will use the law that gives freedom ^{12a}to decide whether we are innocent or guilty. Therefore, speak and act well.

James 2:13

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Do not discriminate against poor people

Paragraph 2:12–13

In this paragraph, James warned his readers that God will judge all people based on how they act toward others. He requires his people to be merciful to others. This is a conclusion to 2:1–11.

In some languages, it will be natural to begin this paragraph with a conjunction indicating that it is a conclusion. For example:

So (NLT)

Therefore

2:13a

For judgment without mercy will be shown to anyone who has not been merciful.

- because God will judge without mercy/kindness the person who has not shown/had mercy towards others.
- When God decides if you^(plur) are righteous or guilty, he will not pity you if you have not pitied others.
- For if a person did not have mercy/pity on others, God will not have mercy/pity on him when he judges him.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason why we should speak and act as it says in 2:12. We should speak and act mercifully (2:12a) because God will judge us without mercy if we are not merciful to others (2:13a).

judgment without mercy will be shown: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as judgment without mercy will be shown is literally “the merciless judgment.” There is no verb in Greek here, so most languages will have to supply a verb. The BSB has supplied the words will be shown to make the Greek phrase a natural English clause.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Use the verb “is” in the present or future. For example:

judgment is merciless (NET)

judgment will be without mercy (NRSV)

on the day of judgment there will be no pity (CEV)

- Use a verb that goes with “mercy” or “judgment.” For example:

God will not show mercy when he judges (GNT)

God will render judgment without mercy

- Translate judgment as a verb. For example:

God will judge without mercy

judgment: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as judgment is literally “the judgment.” It refers back to the fact that God will judge people (2:12).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

God will judge you

God will decide if you are righteous or guilty

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

without mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as without mercy refers to God’s choosing to withhold mercy. When God evaluates and decides if a person is righteous or not, he will not show mercy when deciding.

The word mercy means to show kindness toward people who are in need. Here it specifically means kindness beyond what a person deserves.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

there will be no pity (CEV)

without kindness

will not use grace (when he judges)

to anyone who has not been merciful: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to anyone who has not been merciful is literally “to the one who has not done mercy.” Here “mercy” refers to kindness shown to those who are suffering or in need, such as the poor believers mentioned in 2:1–6.

James was referring to an entire group of people. So in many languages, it may be more natural to translate this phrase in the plural. For example:

those who have not shown mercy to others.

merciful: Here the word merciful refers to the kindness that people show to their fellow human beings who are suffering or in need. Merciful people show this kindness whether or not their fellow human beings have offended them.

Here the sense of mercy is slightly different than the same word in the phrase “judgment without mercy.” There “mercy” refers to kindness that God shows to people who have offended him and deserve judgment/punishment.

What is common to both senses is the idea of being kind to people in need. If possible, you should try to use the same word or expression both times. If your language would normally use different words or expressions for these two senses, try to see if you can translate this in a way to show the connection between the two words. For example:

At the time of judgment, God will not be kind to those who have not been kind to others who are in need.

General Comment on 2:12a–13a

In some languages, it may be more natural to put the reason in 2:13a before the result in 2:12a. For example:

^{13a}Judgment without mercy will be shown to anyone who has not been merciful. ^{12a}So speak and act as those who are going to be judged ^{12b}by the law that gives freedom.

2:13b

Mercy triumphs over judgment.

- However, mercy will conquer judgment!
- Yet compassion knows it is stronger than judgment.
- But the person who is merciful to others does not fear the time when God will judge everyone.

There is a contrast between 2:13a and 2:13b. The contrast is between judgment without mercy (2:13a) and mercy triumphing over judgment (2:13b). Verse 2:13a is something that no one desires. Verse 2:13b is desirable. In some languages, it may be natural to use a conjunction that shows contrast. For example:

but (GNT)

Mercy triumphs over judgment: This is a type of proverb. It is stated in a few words using abstract nouns. In this proverb, Mercy is personified. This

means that Mercy is spoken of as if it were a person. This person triumphs over his opponent. This means that he has victory over him.

Some ways to translate this sentence are:

- Translate this like a proverb and keep the abstract nouns mercy and judgment and the personification. For example:

Mercy triumphs over judgment. (GW)

Mercy is confident when it confronts judgment.

Mercy is more powerful than judgment.

- Translate it like a proverb but without the personification. There is an interpretation issue that comes into play in any attempt to make the meaning of this proverbial expression more explicit. The question is whether mercy refers to people showing mercy/compassion to others or to God's mercy shown toward merciful people. The majority view (see, for example, Moo (2000), page 118; Ropes, page 202; Translator's Handbook, page 81; SSA, page 72; NLT; NCV) is clearly that mercy refers to people showing mercy or compassion to others. This follows the same sense of mercy as it was last used in 2:13a “to anyone who has not been merciful.” It expresses in positive terms what 2:13a has expressed in negative terms, and it lines up well with other verses about mercy such as Matthew 5:7. The weakness of this view is that James' choice of verb seems unusual to express such a meaning: mercy (shown by man) boasts/triumphs over God's judgment. The minority view is found in Martin, page 72, and the CEV. For example:

The person who shows mercy can be confident on the day when God judges everyone.

A man who is merciful to others does not need to have fear on the day when God will judge people.

- Translate the meaning. For example:

If you have been merciful, God will be merciful when he judges you. (NLT)

When anyone is merciful to others, God will judge him with mercy.

Mercy: Mercy here probably refers to the kindness or compassion that a person shows to others who are suffering or in need. It refers to how believers should be treating poor people in their congregation.

The same word with the same meaning occurs at the end of 2:13a.

triumphs over: The Greek word that the BSB here translates as triumphs over probably means that a person is joyfully confident even though something threatens him. “Mercy” (personified) knows that it is superior to judgment and so is not afraid of judgment. In other words, a merciful person is not afraid that God will condemn him. For ways to translate this word, see the examples above.

judgment: Here judgment refers to God’s act of judging people. It has the same meaning as in 2:12a and 2:13a.

James 2:14

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:14–17

In this paragraph, James used three rhetorical questions to emphasize that faith without good deeds is useless.

2:14

What good is it, my brothers, if someone claims to have faith, but has no deeds?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that faith without good deeds “is certainly no good” or “is no good at all.”

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

My brothers and sisters, what good does it do if someone claims to have faith but doesn’t do any good things? (GW)

My brothers, if a person claims to have faith but has no deeds, what good is it?

My brothers, if a person claims to have faith but has no deeds, that kind of faith is useless, right?

- As an emphatic negative statement. For example:

My brothers and sisters, if people say they have faith, but do nothing, their faith is worth nothing. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language to say that something is definitely worthless or useless.

2:14a

What good is it, my brothers,

- ¶ My brothers, what use/benefit is it
- ¶ My brothers and sisters,
- ¶ My fellow believers,

What good is it: In some languages, it will be more natural to put the clause What good is it at the end of the rhetorical question. For example:

My brothers, if a person claims to have faith but has no deeds, what good is it?

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

...is that real faith?

...what use/value is that?

If you translate the rhetorical question as a statement, you can translate this phrase as:

That kind of faith is useless.

That is not faith that will save you.

That is not real faith.

my brothers: The phrase my brothers also occurs in 1:2a. For advice on translating this phrase, see the note there.

The BSB places the phrase my brothers after the phrase “What good is it.” This follows the Greek text. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning of the verse. For example:

My friends, what good is it (GNT)

2:14b **if someone claims to have faith,**

- if a person says that he believes,
- if someone says that he trusts in Jesus,
- if any/one of you^(plur) says that you^(sing) trust in the Lord Jesus,

someone: The Greek word that the BSB translates as someone refers to either a man or woman. It does not refer to any particular person.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

one of you (GNT)

a person

claims to have faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as claims to have faith is literally “says he has faith” (as in the ESV). James did not say whether or not the person was telling the truth.

In some languages, a word like faith requires an object. If that is true in your language, use “Jesus Christ” or “our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

says that he has faith in Jesus Christ

says that he believes/trusts in our Lord Jesus Christ

says that he relies/depends on the Lord Jesus Christ

says that he has committed himself to Jesus Christ

For more help on translating the word faith, see the note on “faith” at 2:5c. Also see believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

2:14c **but has no deeds?**

- but he does no good works?
- but he does no good deeds, what use/value is it?
- but you^(sing) do nothing that shows that you belong to the Lord, that type of belief/trust is no good.

has no deeds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deeds means “actions.” (Older English versions translate it as “works.”) This word refers to “good deeds.” It refers to good activities that people do out of love for God or for other people. An example of a good deed is in 2:25.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

doesn't do any good things (GW)

actions do not prove it (GNT)

his actions do nothing to show it (REB)

General Comment on 2:14a–c

In some languages, 2:14 may be clearer if the order is changed. For example:

My brothers, ^{14b}if a man says that he has faith ^{14c}but he does no good deeds, ^{14a}what good is that kind of faith?

My fellow believers, ^{14b}if a person says that he believes in Jesus Christ, ^{14c}but he does no good actions, ^{14a}that type of belief is no good.

2:14d **Can such faith save him?**

- How will that kind of faith save him?
- That type of faith cannot save him, right?
- That type of belief/trust can/will certainly not save/rescue you^(sing) from punishment for sin.

Can such faith save him?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that faith without good deeds certainly cannot save a person.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can that faith save him? (REB)

That faith cannot save him, right?

- As a negative statement. For example:

Such faith certainly cannot save him.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

such faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as such faith is literally “the faith.” This phrase refers back to the phrase “have faith but has no deeds” in 2:14b–c. The BSB translates this phrase as such faith because it is more natural in English than “the faith.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

his faith (RSV)

that faith (REB)

this kind of faith (GW)

save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save means “rescue from danger or trouble.” In this context, it refers to rescuing someone from the spiritual dangers of sin and from spiritual death which is the punishment that results from sinning.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit what the person is saved from. For example:

save him from sin.

rescue him from punishment for sin.

This word also occurs in 1:21d. See also save, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

him: The pronoun him refers to any person who has faith but no good deeds. This is the person James referred to in 2:14b as “someone.” It does not refer to a particular person. Consider which pronoun or noun is natural in your language in this context.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

anyone (NLT)

you (GNT)

them (NCV)

people

James 2:15

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:14–17

In this paragraph, James used three rhetorical questions to emphasize that faith without good deeds is useless.

2:15a

Suppose a brother or sister

- Suppose that there is a fellow believer, man or woman,
- If there is a Christian brother or sister

Suppose: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Suppose is literally “if” (as in the RSV). This word introduces an example of faith without good deeds. Consider how your language naturally introduces an example. For example:

For example

For instance

If it happens

a brother or sister: The phrase a brother or sister refers to a male or female fellow-believer. Notice that James explicitly includes women here.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

A brother or sister in Christ (NCV)

a believer, whether a man or a woman (GW)

2:15b

is without clothes and daily food.

- and he or she does not have enough clothes and food for that day.
- who needs clothes and food,

without clothes and daily food: The phrase daily food means that the person did not have enough food even for that day. See Moulton & Milligan, Vocabulary of the Greek Testament, page 269; F. Field, Notes on the Translation of the New Testament, page 236. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

needs...food (GW)

lacks daily food (NET)

with not enough food for the day (REB)

don't have enough to eat (GNT)

without clothes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as without clothes here means “does not have enough clothes to keep him warm.”

In the Bible lands, it is often cold, especially at night, and one of the chief functions of a person's clothes is to keep him warm. (See Exodus 22:26–27). It is clear from the phrase “keep warm” in 2:16 that this is what James has in mind.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

needs clothes (GW)

is poorly clothed (NET)

does not have enough clothes to keep warm

James 2:16

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:14–17

In this paragraph, James used three rhetorical questions to emphasize that faith without good deeds is useless.

2:16a

If one of you tells him,

- If one of you^(plur) says to that person,
- and you^(sing) say to him,

one of you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as one of you is literally “any of you^(plur).” It refers to any person who claimed to be a Christian among those to whom James wrote this letter.

him: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as him is literally “them.” It refers to both men and women. Use whatever is natural in your language to refer to the “brother or sister” in Christ of 2:15a.

2:16b

“Go in peace;

- “Goodbye, and God bless you.”^(sing)
- “Goodbye. Have a good day.

Go in peace: The phrase Go in peace was a common expression among Jews to say “goodbye” to a person who was leaving. It was a blessing of peace on the person who was leaving.

You should translate this phrase with a common expression that is used in your language when someone leaves. If possible, the expression should include words that wish the person well or that send him off with God's blessing. For example:

God bless you (GNT)

good-bye and God bless you (NLT96)

Good-bye and have a good day (NLT)

2:16c**stay warm and well fed,”**

- May God keep you^(sing) warm and give you lots of food,”
- I hope you^(sing) stay warm and have plenty to eat,”

stay warm and well fed: This clause is a wish (or prayer) that the person may somehow become warm and get enough to eat. It is not a piece of good advice reminding the person to be sensible and look after himself properly.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I hope you stay warm and get plenty to eat (NCV)

May you be warm enough and have enough food to eat

2:16d**but does not provide for his physical needs,**

- but he does nothing to give him what his body needs,
- but you^(sing) do not give him the things that he lacks,

but does not provide for his physical needs: The Greek is literally “but you^(plur) do not give to them the needed things of the body.” Notice that the pronouns “you” and “them” are both plural in Greek. However, in some languages, singular pronouns are more natural. This is what the BSB does. The pronouns you use here should be consistent with those you used in 2:16a.

The phrase his physical needs refers to the food and clothing that the person needs. The believer wishes the person well but does not give the person what he needs to keep warm or to end his hunger.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

but you do not give what that person needs (NCV)

but does nothing to supply their bodily needs (REB)

but he does not give him clothing to wear and does not give him anything to eat

2:16e**what good is that?**

- what use are only words?
- that is no help at all.

what good is that?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that mere talk and good wishes were no help at all. These same words occur in 2:14a.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

...what good does it do? (GW)

Will that help him?

That will not help him, right?

- As a statement. For example:

It does no good at all.

...your words are worth nothing. (NCV)

You will certainly not help that person just by saying those words.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 2:16a–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:16e at the beginning of the verse. For example:

^{16e}What good is it ^{16a}if one of you tells him, ^{16b}“Go in peace; ^{16c}stay warm and well fed,” ^{16d}but does not provide for his physical needs?

James 2:17**Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless**

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:14–17

In this paragraph, James used three rhetorical questions to emphasize that faith without good deeds is useless.

2:17

In 2:17, James stated the lesson he was trying to teach in the illustration in 2:15–16.

2:17a

So too, faith by itself,

- It is the same with faith/believing. If a person just believes,
- Likewise, if you^(sing) only say that you believe/trust in Jesus Christ,

So too: The phrase So too introduces the general principle that 2:16 illustrates. Words of greeting are of no help to a cold and hungry man unless we also give him what he needs. So also, our faith is of no value unless we also do good deeds for God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

So also (NET)

Even so (KJV)

So it is with faith (GNT)

Likewise

faith by itself: The word faith in this context refers to the act of trusting in or relying on Jesus Christ (as in 2:14b). The phrase by itself means “when faith is alone.” This indicates that a person only believes, but he has no deeds to accompany his belief.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

faith alone

only/just trusting

In some languages, it is more natural to use a verb instead of the noun faith. For example:

a person just trusts

you only believe in Jesus

See believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

2:17b

if it does not result in action,

- and he does not also do good deeds,
- but you^(sing) do not also do good deeds which show it,

if it does not result in action: This phrase means that the person does not also do good deeds that show that he believes in Jesus. Instead, he behaves the same way as people who do not believe in Jesus.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

if that faith does not cause him to do any good deeds

if he does not also do things which show that his faith/trust is genuine

if he fails to show that he believes by what he does

2:17c

is dead.

- his faith/believing is a dead thing.
- your^(sing) kind of believing/trusting is useless.

is dead: The phrase is dead is a metaphor. James meant that the person's faith had no power to do anything and so was of no use. (Compare 2:14.) There are several ways to translate this phrase:

General Comment on 2:17a–c

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

is dead (NET)

has no life in it

- Use a simile. For example:

is as if dead

is like a dead thing

- Use a simile with a word that explains the metaphor. For example:

is powerless as if dead

is as useless as a dead thing

- Use a word or phrase that explains the metaphor. For example:

is powerless

is useless

is unable to do anything

he does not truly trust in God

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of the clauses in 2:17. For example:

^{17a}In the same way, faith by itself ^{17c}is dead ^{17b}if it doesn't cause you to do any good things. (GW)

James 2:18

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:18–19

In this paragraph, James said that we show that we have true faith by the way we behave.

2:18

But someone will say, “You have faith and I have deeds.” There are a number of difficult issues in this verse. Some of the difficulties are:

1. It is not clear whom the word someone refers to.
2. It is not clear whom the pronouns You and I refer to.

3. It is not clear where the quotation ends. This is because there are no quotation marks in ancient Greek manuscripts to indicate which words are direct speech.

Many interpretations have been proposed to try and overcome these difficulties. Three commentaries have done a good job of summarizing (and critiquing) the various interpretations: Dibelius (pages 149–151, 154–158), Ropes (pages 211–214) and McCartney (pages 157–160). Ropes gives six options and McCartney lists eight (while leaving out the option put forward by Huther (pages 89–92) and Lenski, (pages 581–582) which is described in footnote 52). The two interpretations that most English versions follow are:

1. The word someone refers to an imaginary opponent of James. The pronouns You and I in the quotation are a way to say that some people have faith; other people do good deeds. These pronouns do not refer specifically to James, to James' audience or to the imaginary opponent. The quotation includes only the words “You have faith; I have deeds.” According to this interpretation, the imaginary opponent was speaking to James. He implied that (a) faith alone can save a person and (b) works alone can also save a person. For example, the REB says:

But someone may say: ‘One chooses faith, another action.’ To which I reply: ‘Show me this faith you speak of with no actions to prove it, while I by my actions will prove to you my faith.’ (BSB, RSV, NIV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, NCV) This interpretation was defended by Ropes, pages 208–214; and is accepted by Davids (1982), pages 123–125; Laws, pages 122–124; Mitton, page 109; Moo (1985), page 105.

1. The word someone refers to a person who agrees with James. The pronoun I refers to the person who agrees with James. The pronoun You refers to an imaginary opponent. The quotation includes all of 2:18b–e. According to this interpretation, the person who agrees with James was speaking to an imaginary opponent. This opponent claimed to have faith but did not have good deeds. The words of the person who agrees with James were somewhat ironic. That is, he did not believe the imaginary opponent had true faith: “You have faith, do you?” For example, the NASB says:

But someone may well say, “You have faith and I have works; show me your faith without the works, and I will show you my faith by my

works.” (NJB, KJV, NASB, JBP) Alford, pages 298–299; Mayor, pages 95–96; Adamson (1976), pages 124–125.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation is supported by the majority of English versions and a number of commentators. Two other interpretations deserve mention though they are not followed by any of the main English versions: (3) “But someone will say, ‘Do you have faith?’ And I will say, ‘I have deeds. Show me your faith without deeds and I will show you my faith by my deeds.’” According to this interpretation, the words of the imaginary opponent continue only as far as faith, and these words are in the form of a question: “Do you really have faith?” Unlike James, the opponent thinks that faith in God is entirely separate from good deeds. So he asks whether James himself really has genuine faith. James replies that he has deeds to his credit and then challenges the opponent to prove that his own faith is real. Interpretation (3) was proposed by H. Neitzel in an article in German (1982) and is supported by Ronald Y. K. Fung (1992) and other writers: H. Neitzel, 1982, “Eine alte crux interpretum im Jakobusbrief 2:18”, *Zeitschrift für Neutestamentliche Wissenschaft*, pages 286–293. R. Y. K. Fung, “‘Justification’ in the Epistle of James”, in *Right With God: Justification in the Bible and the World*, ed. D. A. Carson, 1992. Pages 148–151 with endnotes pages 279–280 deal with this issue. Neitzel’s interpretation is not the first to take the opponent’s words as a question and I have deeds as the words of James. This was already the approach of F. J. A. Hort (1909). Neitzel’s interpretation is actually a refinement of Hort’s, taking *καὶ γὰρ* as standing for the speech introduction “And I will say”, rather than being the start of the content of what James said. In this way, Neitzel overcomes the objection raised against Hort’s interpretation by Moo (1985), page 105. (4) “But someone may say that you have faith and I have works.” This interpretation understands “you have faith and I have works” as indirect rather than direct speech. It takes you (sing.) to refer to the person that James has been opposing and I to refer to James. The objector is speaking to James and his opponent at the same time, saying that some people have faith and others have good deeds, implying that either is acceptable and you should not expect everyone to have both of them. Then James replies directly to his opponent, challenging him to prove the reality of his faith, and offering to prove the reality of his own faith from his deeds. The objections to this interpretation are: (a) Normally in this kind of Greek discourse the objector addresses the author, not the author and his opponent together; and (b)

usually in the NT after “to say” direct speech is used (James 1:13, 2:3, 4:13, also Luke 4:23; Romans 11:19, etc.), although in none of these examples is a third person addressing two people. (c) It refers to James’ opponent (the person who says that he has faith in 2:14) in the second person, though in 2:14–17, he is a hypothetical person addressed with indefinite third person forms (*τις* “someone” in 2:14, *τις αὐτοῖς* “someone among you” in 2:16). This interpretation was proposed by Huther, pages 89–92, and is accepted by Lenski, pages 581–582, R. B. Terry, D. J. Versenput, and others.

2:18a

But someone will say,

- ¶ But maybe someone will say,
- ¶ But perhaps someone will argue/debate and say to me,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* introduces a strong contrast. The contrast is between James’ statement in 2:17 that faith without deeds is dead and the argument that faith alone is enough.

someone will say: The phrase someone will say introduces a statement that an imaginary opponent might say to James. The statement in 2:18b–c is a type of debate or argument. One way to introduce this argument more clearly is to use a more specific verb. For example:

someone will argue

someone will debate me saying

Suppose someone disagrees and says

2:18b

“You have faith

- “Some people have faith; (NLT)
- “One person believes/trusts in Jesus Christ.

2:18c

and I have deeds.”

- others have good deeds.” (NLT)
- Someone else does good deeds.”

2:18b–c

You have faith and I have deeds: As mentioned above under interpretation (1), the pronouns *You* and *I* are a way to say that some people have faith, other people do good deeds. These pronouns do not refer specifically to James, to James’ audience or to the imaginary opponent.

Consider how speakers in your culture create imaginary persons as examples when they discuss a topic seriously. You may choose to use those types of references here. Also consider if it may be best to replace the pronouns You and I with more general words. For example:

“One person has faith, another has actions.” (GNT)

“Some people have faith; others have good deeds.” (NLT)

“One person trusts Jesus, another person does good deeds.”

The imaginary opponent was arguing that there are different ways to be saved. He said that some are saved because of their faith. Others are saved because of their good deeds. In some languages, it may be good to make this explicit. For example:

^{18a}But someone will argue ^{18b}that there are different ways in which people are saved. He may say “One person has faith, ^{18c}another has good deeds. Either one of these is enough.”

^{18a}But someone will disagree saying ^{18b}that people do not all follow God in the same way. He may say “One person has faith, ^{18c}another has good deeds.”

^{18b}“Some have faith; ^{18c}others have works; don’t expect everyone to have both.” (NET note)

2:18d–e

Verse 2:18d–e is James’ reply to the imaginary opponent of 2:18b–c. In some languages, it may be necessary to make it clear that James is now speaking for himself. One way to do this is to begin 2:18d with a short phrase. For example:

My answer is (GNT)

But I say (NLT)

But I, James, say

2:18d

Show me your faith without deeds,

- Show me that you^(sing) really believe in Jesus even when you do no good deeds,

- I will answer, “Can you^(sing) prove to me that you believe/trust in Jesus Christ when you do not do good deeds?”

Show me your faith without deeds: This clause challenges someone to prove that he has true faith when he does not have good deeds to support his claim.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Show me that you really believe/trust in Jesus, even when you do no good deeds.

Prove that you have faith without doing kind deeds (CEV)

I challenge you to prove to me that you have faith when you have no deeds.

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this clause as a rhetorical question. For example:

“How can you show me your faith if you don’t have good deeds?” (NLT)

If you believe only, but there are no good deeds, how will you show me that you really believe in Jesus?

2:18e

and I will show you my faith by my deeds.

- and I will show you^(sing) that I really believe in him by the good deeds that I do.
- I will use my good deeds to prove to you^(sing) that I believe/trust in him.”

and I will show you my faith by my deeds: This clause indicates that good deeds will prove that a person has true faith. Faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I will show you that I really believe/trust in Jesus Christ by the good deeds I do.

I will use my good deeds to prove my faith to you.

What I do will show you that I really have faith.

James 2:19

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:18–19

In this paragraph, James said that we show that we have true faith by the way we behave.

2:19

In 2:19, James gave more evidence to convince his readers that true faith is a matter of both faith and good deeds. People are wrong if they think that it is enough just to believe true things about God without doing good deeds.

2:19a

You believe that God is one.

- You^(sing) believe/think that there is only one God.
- You^(sing) accept as true that there is only one God.
- You^(plur) are convinced that there is only one God.

You believe that God is one: In this verse, James talked about a second meaning of the word believe. This type of belief is different than the type of belief that he talked about in previous verses. The two types of belief are:

1. The type of belief that people have when they trust in God and entrust themselves to Jesus, the Messiah. This type of belief results in salvation. This is the type of belief that James talked about in 2:14–18 and 2:20–26.
2. The type of “belief” that people have when they just believe something about God. This type of belief does not have any good works. This type of belief does not result in salvation. The demons have this same type of belief. This is the type of belief that

James talked about here in 2:19. It means “accept that a certain statement is true.” It refers specifically to the statement God is one.

James used the same Greek word to talk about these two types of belief. If your language uses two different terms for these two meanings of “believe/faith,” it may be helpful to indicate how they are related. See the General Comment on 2:19a–d at the end of 2:19d for some suggestions of how to do this.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You accept as true that there is one God

You affirm that there is one God

You are convinced that there is one God

See also believe, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

You: In this verse, James continued to address the person who disagreed with him. So in Greek, the pronoun You is singular. However, James was also writing to anyone who believed that it was possible to have faith without good deeds. So, in some languages, it will be more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

God is one: The Jewish belief that God is one was the most basic belief of all Jews. (This belief is expressed in Deuteronomy 6:4.) This belief was in contrast to belief in many gods. There is a textual issue here. There are a number of textual variants, but the main point of difference is whether the definite article appears with “God” (*εἷς ἐστιν ὁ θεός* vs. *εἷς θεός ἐστιν*). Some commentators (Moo (2000), page 130; Martin, page 77; Hiebert, page 186, for example) feel “God” with the article focuses on the unity of God (“God is one”) while “God” without the article would be a statement of monotheism (“there is one God”). Other commentators (Davids (1982), page 125; Lenski, page 584; Huther, page 92, Translator’s Handbook, page 89) suggest that the meaning of either reading would be the same – probably understood as an affirmation of monotheism. Independent of which textual variant is chosen (or whether one sees all variants as essentially expressing the same meaning), there is some question of whether this is a statement about the unity of God or his uniqueness (a statement of monotheism). The discussion in commentaries is somewhat confusing because some writers seem to use unity to mean uniqueness. That is, they state that this was about the unity of God, but then discuss unity in the sense of monotheism. Most English versions translate this

as a statement of monotheism (as the NIV does). For the versions that translate it as “God is one” (RSV, ESV, NASB, NET), it is not certain if they intend this to express the unity of God or his uniqueness (monotheism). In considering the context in which Deuteronomy 6:4 was spoken and the context of the book of James, it seems much more likely that this expresses monotheism (in contrast to belief in many gods) than it does the unity of God (in contrast to his fragmentation or division into three persons). In the Old Testament period (the context of Deuteronomy 6:4), the unity of God would have been assumed. And the trinitarian understanding of God existing in three persons was not well enough developed in James’ day to think that God’s unity (though existing in three persons) was in view. This clause may be translated as:

there is only one God (CEV)

2:19b Good for you!

- That is good/correct, but not enough/sufficient!
- You^(sing) do well!

Good for you!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Good for you is literally “You do well” (as in the RSV). James was not completely praising his readers for believing that there is only one God. His point was that such faith is good, but it is not good enough. Even the demons believe that. If their faith was no more than empty words without deeds, it was dead/useless.

Some ways to translate this phrase and indicate that such faith is not sufficient are:

- Put the implied information after 2:19b. For example:

That’s good but not enough

You do well, but it is not sufficient by/in itself

- Put the implied information after the word shudder in 2:19d. For example:

Good! ^{19c}But even the demons believe that— ^{19d}and shudder. So such faith is not enough/sufficient.

2:19c Even the demons believe that—

- But even the demons believe that,
- Evil spirits even/also believe that there is only one God,

Even: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Even here indicates:

1. something unexpected. It is not likely that demons would be described as believing in God. But even they believe. For example:

Even demons believe this (CEV)

1. an addition. James’ readers believed that there is one God. Demons also believe the same thing. For example:

The demons also believe (GNT)

If possible, translate this word with a word that can include both meanings. If you must make a choice, choose meaning (a).

demons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demons refers to spirits that are evil and can control people’s actions. The word demons refers to the same type of spirit as the Greek terms that are often translated as “evil spirits” and “unclean spirits.”

Some ways to translate demons are:

- Use a general term in your language that refers to spirits that are evil and can control people.
- Use a specific term in your language that refers to a certain type of spirit. These spirits should be ones that do evil things. Do not use a term that refers to spirits of dead people.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

evil/bad spirits

unclean spirits

spirits who oppose God Be sure that an expression like “unclean spirits” does not imply that the spirits are literally dirty.

believe that: The word that refers to 2:19a. It means “that there is only one God.” Even demons believe that there is only one God.

Another way to translate this phrase is:

even the demons have the same belief (NJB)

even demons believe like that

even demons believe that there is one God

believe: Here the word believe has the same meaning as believe in 2:19a. It means to accept that something is true.

2:19d and shudder.

- and they tremble with fear!
- and they shake because they fear him! So that kind of faith is not good enough.

shudder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as shudder means “shake” or “tremble.” Here it means to shake or tremble because of fear. Some ways to translate this word are:

shake with fear (CEV)

tremble in fear of him

shake with horror because they know that God will judge them

General Comment on 2:19a–d

James used the same Greek word to talk about two types of belief. Some languages use two different terms to translate these two meanings of “believe.” In such languages, it may be helpful to use both terms in 2:19 to show how they are related. For example:

You accept as true that there is one God. Good! But if that is all you mean when you say that you are trusting God, then you are just like the demons. Even they accept this as true, and it makes them shudder.

It is good that you are convinced that there is only one God. But the kind of trust in God that leads to salvation is more than that. Even the demons are convinced that there is only one God. They will certainly not be saved. Instead, thinking about this makes them shake with fear.

James 2:20

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:20

O foolish man, do you want evidence that faith without deeds is worthless?: This is a rhetorical question. It has two functions. First, it is a rebuke. James was rebuking anyone who thought that it was possible to have true faith without doing good deeds. The second function of this rhetorical question is to introduce the examples that James was about to give from the Old Testament (2:21–25).

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

You fool! Do you have to be shown that faith which does nothing is useless? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

You fool! Surely you do not need me to show you that faith without good deeds is worthless.

You fool! I will prove/show to you that faith without good deeds is useless. Here are two examples.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

2:20a

O foolish man, do you want evidence that

- ¶ You^(sing) fool! Do you need proof that
- ¶ You^(sing) are not thinking well/carefully! Can you not see/understand that
- ¶ It is crazy for you^(plur) to think that

O foolish man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolish literally means “empty.” Here it is used figuratively to describe a person who has “empty” thoughts. In other words, it is a person who does not think wisely and correctly. This person could be a man or a woman.

In this verse, James rebuked the person who disagreed with him. So in Greek, the pronoun man is singular. However, James was also rebuking anyone who believed that it was possible to have faith without good deeds. So, in some languages, it will be more natural to use the plural form “men” or “people” here.

Use a term that is natural in your language for a mild rebuke.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

You stupid person

You crazy/mad people

You^(sing) are not thinking carefully

You^(plur) are not being wise

Do you still not understand?

do you want evidence: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as do you want evidence is literally “do you want to know?” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Do you want to be shown (GNT)

Must you be shown (NCV)

Do you have to be told (REB)

Do I need to show/tell you

Can't you see (NLT)

2:20b

faith without deeds is worthless?

- when you^(sing) have faith/trust but do not do good deeds, such faith is no good?
- if a person believes/trusts in Jesus but he does not do good deeds, that type of belief/trust is empty/worthless?
- believing in God without doing good deeds is of any use/value.

faith without deeds is worthless: In Greek, the words faith and deeds are nouns. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate these nouns as verbs. For example:

If you believe in Jesus but do no good to show it, what use is that?

it's useless to believe if you do not do any good to prove it.

deeds: The word deeds is the same word that occurs in 2:14c.

worthless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worthless here means “without results,” or “unproductive.” The Greek manuscript copies do not all agree at this point. The modern English versions translate a word that means useless, while KJV and footnotes in GNT and NIV follow one that means “dead.” There is not much difference in the meaning, but it is recommended that you follow the UBS Greek text and the reading “useless.” Some other ways to translate this word are:

futile (REB)

worth nothing (NCV)

is of no value/use

James 2:21

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demon-

strate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:21

In 2:21, James gave the first of two examples from the Old Testament of someone whom God declared to be righteous. This example is about Abraham.

Was not our father Abraham justified by what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that Abraham was definitely justified or “considered righteous” (NIV) for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you remember that our ancestor Abraham was declared right with God because of what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? (NLT96)

- As a statement. For example:

Certainly Abraham, our ancestor, was declared right with God by what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar.

- As a question and a statement. For example:

Consider our ancestor Abraham. Did not God consider him righteous when he offered his son Isaac on the altar?

How was our ancestor Abraham declared right with God? It was through his actions, when he offered his son Isaac on the altar.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

2:21a

Was not our father Abraham

- Was not Abraham, our^(incl) forefather
- Think^(sing) about our^(incl) ancestor Abraham.
- Consider^(plur) Abraham, our^(incl) relative from long ago.

our father Abraham: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as our father Abraham is literally “Abraham our father” (as in the RSV). Abraham had lived many generations before James, and all Jews had descended from Abraham. So use a word that indicates an ancestor who was the beginning of a language group or a tribe.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

our forefather Abraham

Abraham our long ago ancestor

2:21b

justified by what he did

- declared to be righteous because of what he did
- What caused God to call him a straight/just person? It was because of his good deeds
- God declared/said that he was a righteous/good person as a result of his faith and actions,

justified by what he did: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as justified by what he did is translated by many English versions as “justified by works.” Before you translate this phrase, there are at least two issues to consider.

Issue 1: Which part of the meaning of the verb is the focus

The verb “justified” primarily means “declared innocent.” This word is used in a court or judgment setting. A judge examines the evidence and may then declare that an accused person is “innocent,” “just” or “righteous.” This is equal to saying, “Not guilty.”

Commentaries and English versions focus on different aspects of this word:

1. Some focus on the verdict or declaration. God considered/declared Abraham to be righteous. God did this because Abraham’s deeds proved that he was righteous. For example:

our ancestor Abraham was declared right with God because of what he did (NLT96)

1. Others focus on the evidence and what it showed. Abraham’s deeds showed/proved that he was righteous. For example:

our ancestor Abraham was shown to be right with God by his actions (NLT)

1. Still others focus on the accused person’s new condition after the verdict. God caused Abraham to be righteous. For example:

Abraham, our ancestor, was made right with God by what he did.... (NCV)

Most commentaries favor (a). So it may be better to translate in a way that follows (a). (Focus (c) is quite different and could be considered a different interpretation.)

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Was not our ancestor Abraham declared righteous because of what he did...?

Did not God consider our ancestor Abraham to be just/straight because of his good deeds...?

It was certainly because of what our ancestor Abraham did that God declared that he was a righteous/good person....

See also righteous, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

Issue 2: How to translate the passive verb

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as justified is a passive verb. Some ways to translate this verb are:

- As a passive verb. For example:

Was not our ancestor Abraham declared right with God because of what he did...?

It was certainly because of our ancestor Abraham’s good deeds that he was declared righteous.

- As an active verb. God was the one who declared Abraham righteous. For example:

Was it not because of what our ancestor Abraham did that God declared him to be righteous...?

God considered Abraham to be righteous/just because of his good deeds

by what he did: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by what he did is literally “by works/deeds/actions.” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by works (RSV)

as a result of what he did (GW)

because of his good deeds

Throughout 2:14–26, James compared faith with works to faith without works. He did not compare faith to works. When he said by what he did, this implies “by faith together with what he did.” Some ways to make this clear are:

General Comment on 2:21a–b

- Include the implied information in your translation. For example:

because of his faith plus works

because of his deeds that showed that he had faith

because of the kind of faith that was proven by his good deeds

- Include a footnote. For example:

In James 2:14–26, James compared faith with deeds to faith alone, that is, faith without deeds. When James wrote that Abraham was declared righteous because of his deeds, he meant “because of his faith with deeds.” Abraham’s deeds demonstrated that he had the kind of faith that can save.

In Greek, the order of words shows that James was emphasizing the phrase by what he did. Consider if there is a way in your language to emphasize these words. For example:

Was it not by his action,...that our father Abraham was justified? (REB)

2:21c

when he offered his son Isaac on the altar?

- when he took his son Isaac and went to the altar in order to sacrifice him?
- when he put his son Isaac on the sacrifice place.

when he offered his son Isaac on the altar: The clause when he offered his son Isaac on the altar means that Abraham put Isaac on an altar and was willing to sacrifice him. But God stopped him. Abraham did not actually kill Isaac.

If a literal translation of this clause will cause people to think that Abraham really did kill Isaac, you should make some adjustments. For example:

when he laid his son Isaac on top of the altar in order to offer him to God

It may also be helpful to readers who do not know the story to make it clear that Abraham was not acting on his own initiative. He was obeying God’s command. This can be done by saying:

he did not refuse to take his son Isaac to the altar to sacrifice him

son: Isaac was old enough to carry the wood for the sacrifice and to understand what was happening. He was a grown youth. Use a word for son that does not imply a small child.

on the altar: An altar is a type of platform on which people offer sacrifices. God had instructed his people to pile earth or large stones together to make altars to him. If an altar was made from stones, the stones were to be in their natural form. This means that people

were not to cut the stones to a regular shape (Exodus 20:24–26).

If your culture does not have a traditional name for such an altar, some other ways to translate this phrase are:

on the stones for sacrificing

on the offering burning rocks

on the sacrifice place to God

James 2:22

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:22

In 2:22, James explained the lesson that we can learn from the example of Abraham in 2:21. That lesson is that faith and deeds go together.

The GNT, KJV, REB, JBP translate this verse as a rhetorical question. For example:

Can't you see that his faith and his actions were, so to speak, partners—that his faith was implemented by his deed? (JBP)

Most other English versions follow the Greek text and translate 2:22 as a statement. You should translate this verse in a way that shows emphasis. This can be done as a rhetorical question or as an emphatic statement.

2:22a

You see that his faith was working with his actions,

- You^(sing) see/understand that his faith/belief was working together with his deeds,
- It is clear that Abraham not only trusted in God, he also did what God wanted him to do,
- Do you^(plur) not see? His believing/trusting and his good/obedient actions went together,

You see that: The clause You see that emphasizes that faith and deeds go together. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You can understand that

It is clear that

As in 2:20a, the word You is singular and refers to the person who disagreed with James. This is the person that James has been answering since 2:18c. However, James was also addressing anyone who believed that it was possible to have faith without good deeds. So, in some languages, it will be more natural to use the plural form of “you” here.

his faith was working with his actions: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as his faith was working with his actions is literally “his faith was working together with his works.” In some languages, it is not possible to say that two things like faith and actions “work together.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

his faith and what he did occurred together at the same time

Abraham's trust in God went together with his doing good deeds

he was not only trusting in God, but he was also doing what God told him to do

2:22b

and his faith was perfected by what he did.

- and his deeds completed his faith/belief.
- and so what he did showed that his believing/trusting was real/genuine.

and his faith was perfected by what he did: The clause his faith was perfected by what he did is passive. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

His faith was made complete by what he did—by his actions. (NLT96)

- Use an active verb. For example:

His actions made his faith complete. (NLT)

his faith was perfected by what he did: This clause indicates that Abraham's deeds showed that he had true faith. True faith leads to good deeds, so faith is not complete until there are good deeds to go with it. This should not imply that Abraham's faith was in some way faulty or inadequate before he offered Isaac.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

His faith was shown to be genuine by what he did. (GW)

He proved that his faith was real by what he did. (CEV)

What he did showed that his faith was real/genuine.

That which he did showed that there was no lack in his believing God.

James 2:23

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

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Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:23a

And the Scripture was fulfilled that says,

- And so, the Scripture was shown to be true that says,
- So his deed is an excellent example/illustration of what someone/Moses wrote in God’s book, which says,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And connects 2:23 to 2:21–22. Verse 2:23 gives two results of Abraham’s deed of offering Isaac in 2:21. The results were:

1. the scripture was fulfilled
2. Abraham was called God’s friend

Some other ways to connect 2:23 to 2:21–22 are:

And so (NLT)

In this way (NJB)

That is how

the Scripture: The phrase the Scripture refers to something that was written in the Old Testament. In this case, the words that James quoted are from Genesis 15:6. These words refer to events that took place about thirty years before Abraham offered Isaac to God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

what was written in God’s book

God’s written words

the word of God that someone/Moses wrote

This phrase also occurs in 2:8b. See the note there for more information.

was fulfilled: There are at least two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as was fulfilled:

1. It means that the Scripture was fully shown and demonstrated to be true. According to this interpretation, when Abraham offered Isaac, his action was the best possible illustration that what the scripture said about him was true. His action clearly showed that he believed/trusted God and that he was righteous (Genesis 15:6).
2. It means that the Scripture became true. According to this interpretation, God’s words in Genesis 15:6 were a prophecy. This prophecy was fulfilled when Abraham offered Isaac as a sacrifice. For example, the GNT says:

And the scripture came true that said,... (NLT, GNT, GW)

Many English versions translate this Greek word as “was fulfilled” and probably imply interpretation (2). However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most commentators follow this interpretation. The quoted Scripture verse is not a prophecy or promise that needed to come true. It is a statement

that was already true when spoken thirty years before Abraham was willing to offer Isaac as a sacrifice.

Some ways to translate this entire clause are:

And so the scripture was shown/demonstrated to be true that says

This fits/agrees perfectly with the Scripture that says

His action is a good/excellent example of the Scripture that says

And so his action perfectly demonstrated his trust in God as described in the scripture that says

2:23b-c

Verse 2:23b-c is a quotation of Genesis 15:6. If you have already translated the book of Genesis, you will probably want to quote that verse here just as you translated it there.

2:23b

“Abraham believed God,

- “Abraham trusted God,
- “Abraham had confidence that God would do what he promised,

Abraham believed God: The word believed here means “trusted in” or “relied on.” Abraham believed God’s promise in Genesis 15:5 that his descendants would be as numerous as the stars. In other words, he accepted God’s promise as true.

He believed God’s promise because of his deep level of trust in God and his loyalty to God. Abraham was confident that God would do what he had promised to do. He trusted God even when the promise seemed very difficult or impossible in human terms.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

had confidence/faith in God

trusted God

relied/depended on God

trusted/believed that God could do what he promised

See believe, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

2:23c

and it was credited to him as righteousness,”

- and because of that he was considered to be a righteous person.”
- and that is why God said that he was a person who had done what is right.”

it was credited to him as righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was credited means “regarded” or “considered.” The word it refers to Abraham’s faith in God (2:22b). So the clause it was credited to him as righteousness means that God considered Abraham righteous on the basis of his faith.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

because of that, he was considered by God to be just/righteous

because of his faith God accepted him as righteous (GNT)

so God declared him to be righteous (NLT96)

was credited: The verb was credited is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

that faith was counted to him as righteousness (REB)

- Use an active verb. God is the one who credited Abraham’s faith as righteousness. For example:

God declared him to be righteous (NLT96)

righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness means “doing what is right and good in God’s sight.” God considered Abraham to have done what was good and right.

The word righteousness here is closely related in form and meaning to the word that is translated as “justified by” in 2:21b, 2:24b, and 2:25b. If possible, you may want to translate them in a similar way so it is clear that they are related.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

it was credited to him by God as right behavior

and that faith made him right with God (NCV)

God declared him to have done what is right

he was considered a person who lived the kind of life that God desires

God approved Abraham

See righteous, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

2:23d

and he was called a friend of God.

- So he was called God's friend.
- As a result, God said about Abraham, "He is my friend."

and: Verse 2:23d is a result of 2:23b–c. The word and may give the impression that 2:23d is another part of the quoted scripture in 2:23b–c. But it is not. Notice the closing quotes at the end of 2:23c. Some ways to make this clear are:

And so (GNT)

As a result

he was called a friend of God: In Isaiah 41:8 God called Abraham "my friend." (See also 2 Chronicles 20:7.)

The verb was called is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it.

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Abraham was called God's friend (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God called him "my friend"

he was God's friend

James 2:24

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous "by deeds," it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on "for what he did" (2:21b) and "by his deeds" (2:24b).

2:24a

As you can see,

- You^(plur) see/understand that
- Therefore/So, this shows us^(incl) that

As you can see: The clause As you can see introduces James' final conclusion from the life of Abraham in 2:21–23. Some ways to introduce this conclusion are:

So you see (NLT)

Therefore, we can see/understand that

you: In Greek, James switches to the plural pronoun you. Up to this point, James used the singular pronoun you.

2:24b

a man is justified by his deeds

- a person is considered righteous because of his good deeds,

- it is on account of what people do that they are declared to be righteous.
- God declares us^(incl) righteous/straight because of our good/obedient actions which show that we trust him.

a man is justified by his deeds: This clause indicates that God declares a person righteous on the basis of faith that is demonstrated by his good deeds.

The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as justified is the same verb that is used in 2:21b. Use the same expression here as in 2:21b. For example:

a person is declared right with God because of the good deeds he does

we are considered righteous/straight because of what we do

It is on the basis of what someone does that God declares that he is a righteous/good person

The difference between this verse and 2:21b is that 2:21b refers to a particular time in the past when God declared that Abraham was righteous. This verse is a general statement about how God declares that people are righteous. Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language for expressing statements that are true for everyone.

This clause is also passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

a person is justified by works (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God declares a person righteous because of the good deeds he does

See also righteous, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

by his deeds: The Greek phrase that the BSB here translates as by his deeds is the same Greek phrase as in 2:21b. There the BSB translates it as “by what he did.” See the note there for advice on translating the implied information.

2:24c

and not by faith alone.

- and not by his faith/belief only.

- They are not declared righteous if they have belief/trust only.
- He does not consider us^(incl) just/straight if we only trust but do not have any good deeds.

not by faith alone: Here James left some words implicit. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply this implicit information. For example:

he is not declared righteous by faith alone

The phrase faith alone means “faith by itself” or “faith that does not have any good deeds accompanying it.” Many people have found this verse difficult, because at first sight it appears to contradict Paul who says, “For we hold that a man is justified by faith apart from works of law.” (Romans 3:28, RSV). However, if we look at the context closely, we see that James and Paul are talking about different things. Paul’s argument in Romans 3 and 4 is intended to show that God justifies Gentiles in the same way as he justifies Jews, on the basis of their faith, not their obedience to the laws of Moses. This means in practice that the fact that many Gentiles have not obeyed the law of Moses (especially in the matter of circumcision) is not a barrier to stop them joining the church. Notice that Paul speaks of works of law not just works. James’ argument has nothing to do with the problem of allowing Gentiles to become members of the church, but it is the problem of those in the church who say they have faith but do not do the deeds that should result from their faith. So for James, works (“deeds”) means “deeds done in obedience to God”. Notice also that James is not against faith, he is against faith without deeds. It does not mean that someone can be justified by good deeds instead of faith.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

not by faith without any good deeds

he is not declared righteous if he only has faith

God does not consider him just/straight if he only believes but does not have any good deeds

In this phrase, the emphasis is on the word alone.

Notice that the contrast is between “by what he does” in 2:24b and by faith alone here. Try to make this contrast clear in your translation.

James 2:25

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:25

In 2:25, James gave a second example from the Old Testament of someone whom God declared to be righteous. This example is about a prostitute called Rahab. Her story is told in the book of Joshua in two parts: Joshua 2:1–24 and Joshua 6:22–25.

In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute justified by her actions when she welcomed the spies and sent them off on another route?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that Rahab was considered righteous for what she did.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

And similarly, was not Rahab the prostitute also justified by works when she welcomed the messengers and sent them out by another way? (NET)

- As a statement. For example:

Rahab the prostitute is another example. She was declared to be right with God by what she did when she hid those messengers and sent them safely away by a different road.

- As a statement and a question. For example:

Another example is the prostitute Rahab. She hid some messengers and then helped them escape by another road. She also was declared righteous for what she did, right?

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. It is best to use wording that is similar to your translation of 2:21.

2:25a

In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute

- And similarly, was not Rahab the prostitute also (NET)
- It was the same with the prostitute called Rahab.
- Another example is Rahab the prostitute.

In the same way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In the same way introduces another example that is like the example of Abraham.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Likewise (NRSV)

Similarly

Another example is (NCV)

even: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as even:

1. It means also. God declared Abraham righteous. He also declared Rahab righteous. The phrase *ὁμοίως ... και* (“In the same way also” or “Likewise also”) is also found in Matthew 27:41; Luke 5:10; 10:32; 1 Corinthians 7:3–4. In each case, it means “also.” For example, the NET says:

was not Rahab the prostitute also justified by works (RSV, NJB, ESV, KJV, NASB, REB, NET, NLT, NCV)

1. It means even. According to this interpretation, this word indicates something unexpected. Here it indicates that Rahab was an unlikely person to be an example of someone who was declared righteous. For example, the CEV says:

Rahab had been a prostitute. But she pleased God... (BSB, NIV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of versions.

In some languages, the translation of “in the same way” will include the idea of also. For example:

Rahab the prostitute is another example. (NLT)

If that is the case in your language, you will not need to translate this word explicitly.

the prostitute: A prostitute is a woman who has sex with men in exchange for money. In some cultures, the word referring to such a woman may be considered too vulgar or explicit to be read aloud in church. If that is true in your language, translate this word using a more general term. For example:

immoral woman

woman whose reputation was bad

2:25b

justified by her actions

- declared to be righteous because of what she did
- What caused God to call her a straight/just person? It was because of her good deeds.
- God declared/said that she was a righteous/good person as a result of her good actions.

justified by her actions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as justified by her actions also occurs in 2:21b. You should translate it the same way in both places. (Also, it is almost identical with the phrase in 2:24b.)

by her actions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by her actions here is literally “by works” (as in the RSV). Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

because of what she did

because of her good deeds

This phrase also occurs in 2:21b.

2:25c

when she welcomed the spies

- when she received into her house the spies,
- She welcomed the spies into her home (NCV)
- Her good actions were that she hid the Israelites who secretly came to investigate her town.

when she welcomed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as welcomed means “received someone” or “welcomed someone into one’s house.” In this context, it also means “provided a place to stay and hide from the people who wanted to kill them.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

when she hid those messengers (NLT)

She welcomed the spies into her home (NCV)

when she gave shelter to those messengers and hid them

the spies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as spies is literally “messengers” (as in the RSV). In this context, it refers to men who were secretly looking at a town they hoped to conquer. Then they returned to report back to their commander.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Israelites who secretly came to investigate her town

Jewish men sent to secretly inspect her town to see the best way to attack it

2:25d

and sent them off on another route?

- and then sent them off by another way?
- and then showed them a different way to leave.
- Then she caused them to leave another way so that their enemies would not find them.

sent them off on another route: In Joshua 2:15–16, Rahab helped the spies escape by:

1. hanging a rope out of her window that they used to descend outside the city wall.

2. counseling them to go into the hills and hide for three days before they returned home.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as route can refer to a “road” or more figuratively a “way.” A number of English versions translate this word as “road”. (See the GNT, NLT, for example.) However, in this context it more likely refers to letting the spies out of the window by a rope. Support for understanding the word in this way includes: (a) The Greek verb, *ἐκβάλλω* (throw/cast/drive out, send away), goes better with the descent out the window than simply traveling home by a different road. (b) The Greek word *ἕτερος* (translated as “different” or “other”) usually refers to “other/another” of a different kind rather than of the same kind. So it goes better with going out of the window as opposed to the gate rather than taking one road as opposed to another road. (Contrast Matthew 2:12 where *ἄλλος* is used instead of *ἕτερος*.) (c) The common Greek idiom for taking a road uses the preposition *ἐν* followed by “road” in the accusative case. In this verse, “another way/road” is in the dative case. (See, for example, Matthew 10:5, 22:10.) (d) According to Joshua 2:16, Rahab did not counsel the spies to return by a different road. She counseled them to go off the road into the hills to escape notice for three days before returning home (presumably by the same road by which they came). Or, this word may refer to both escaping out of the window and then hiding in the hills.

If you have a word or phrase that can refer to both escaping out of the window and going into the hills, you could use it here. Otherwise be sure that your translation can refer to the spies going out of the window.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

sent them out by another way (NASB)

showed them a different way to leave (NJB)

helped them to escape by getting out of the city in/by an unusual/secret way

Some people are not familiar with this Old Testament story. So you may have to make some of the information explicit. For example:

Then she sent them home a different way so that their enemies would not find them.

General Comment on 2:25a–d

In some languages, it may be clearer to say what Rahab did before saying that God considered her righteous because of it. For example:

^{25a}Another example is Rahab the prostitute.

^{25c}When Israelite spies came to her town, she welcomed them. ^{25d}And she advised them to depart another way. ^{25b}It was because of what she did at that time that God considered her also to be a righteous person.

James 2:26

Section 2:14–26: Faith without good deeds is useless

In this section, James emphasized that true faith in Jesus is a matter of both believing and doing good deeds. There is no such thing as faith without good deeds to go with it. It is the good deeds that demonstrate that there is true faith. Faith without good deeds is not true faith at all.

James used examples from the lives of Rahab and Abraham to show that faith and good deeds always go together.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Faith and good deeds

If you really believe/trust you will also do good deeds

Real faith is proved by good deeds.

Paragraph 2:20–26

In this paragraph, James gave two examples to show his readers that faith without deeds is useless. He used the examples of Abraham and Rahab from the Old Testament. He argued that it was because of their deeds that both Abraham and Rahab were declared righteous by God.

Throughout section 2:14–26, James was contrasting faith without deeds (for example, 2:14, 2:17, 2:18) with faith demonstrated by deeds (2:18). In this paragraph, when James said that Abraham was declared to be righteous “by deeds,” it does not mean by deeds alone. It is implied that Abraham had faith and that this faith was demonstrated by deeds. You may want to put some of this information in the translation or in a footnote. Some suggestions are in the notes on “for what he did” (2:21b) and “by his deeds” (2:24b).

2:26

As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead: James concluded his discussion of faith and deeds by repeating the statement faith without deeds is dead. He had already made this statement in 2:17. Here, James used a simile to emphasize this statement.

In this simile, James compared faith without deeds to the body without the spirit. The way that they are similar is that both are dead and useless.

Some other ways to translate this simile are:

Just as a person's body that does not have a spirit is dead, so faith that does nothing is dead! (NCV)

faith without action is as dead as a body without a soul (JBP)

If someone believes/trusts but does not do good deeds, that belief/trust is as useless as a body that has no spirit.

If a person's spirit has left his body, he cannot do any good deeds because the body has no life. In the same way, if someone believes but does not do any good deeds, his belief has no life.

2:26a

As the body without the spirit is dead,

- Just as a person's body without his spirit is dead,
- If a person's spirit is gone from his body, that body is dead and useless.

In Greek, this verse is connected to the previous verse with a conjunction. The BSB does not translate this conjunction. Here this conjunction introduces a simile that concludes this section.

Some other ways to indicate that 2:26 is the conclusion are:

So then (GNT)

What we should understand here is this:

In conclusion

the body: The phrase the body refers to a human body.

without the spirit: The phrase the spirit here refers to the inner part of a person that continues to exist after the person has died.

is dead: If possible, translate the word dead with a word or phrase in your language that can refer to a body as well as to faith. For example:

has no life

is dead and useless

2:26b

so faith without deeds is dead.

- so also, the faith of a person who does no good deeds is dead.
- In the same way, if a person says that he trusts in Christ/God, but he does not do anything to show/prove it, such trusting is dead/useless.

without deeds: The phrase without deeds also occurs in 2:20b.

dead: The word dead here indicates that the person's faith has no power to do anything and so is of no use. (Compare 2:17c where the word dead also occurs.) In some languages, the word faith cannot be spoken of as dead. If that is the case in your language, you can:

- Use a simile. For example:

as if dead

like a dead thing

- Explain the meaning of the word dead here. For example:

useless

powerless

James 3:1

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations

to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

Introduction

3:1-2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

The tongue is compared to small things which have large effects

3:2b-3	A small bit can turn a horse
3:4-5c	A small rudder can turn a sailing ship
3:5d-6	A small fire can destroy much
3:7-8	Animals can be tamed but not our tongues

Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9-10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
3:12	Trees produce one kind of fruit

Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:1

This paragraph introduces this next section. James warned that it is a serious matter when a person becomes a teacher in the church.

3:1a

Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers,

- ¶ My brothers, not many of you^(plur) should become religious teachers,
- ¶ My fellow believers, only a few of you^(plur) should teach others in the church.

Not many of you should become teachers: In Greek, this sentence is literally “be not many teachers.” Many ambitious people wanted to have the honor of being a religious teacher. However, James told them that not all of them should be eager to become teachers.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

not many of you should become teachers in the church (NLT)

we should not all try to become teachers (CEV)

only a few of you should try to become teachers

Not many of you: The phrase Not many of you means “only some of you,” or “only a few of you.” Most of James’ readers should not try to become teachers.

teachers: The word teachers refers to those who had authority to teach in the church. They instructed other Christians in the meaning of what God had said in his word and how they should live.

Here the word teachers does not refer to a teacher in a school. This word refers only to people who teach the word of God and the good news about Jesus Christ. If many people in your area would confuse this and think of teachers of other subjects, then it may be necessary to make explicit what the teachers teach in this context. For example:

teachers in the church (NLT)

people who teach the word of God

people who teach the Christian faith/belief

my brothers: The phrase my brothers refers to other believers in Christ to whom James was writing. In the time of James, all the teachers were men. So here, this phrase does not include women as it does in 1:2a, 1:16, 1:19a, 2:1a, 2:5a, and 2:14a.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

My fellow believers

My Christian friends

My relatives in Christ

Here James used the phrase my brothers to introduce the topic of the need for believers to control their speech. If you have another way in your language to introduce a change of topic, you may use it here.

Notice that the BSB places the phrase my brothers in the middle of 3:1. This follows the Greek text. In some languages, it may be more natural to place it at the beginning. For example:

My friends, not many of you should become teachers... (REB)

This same phrase occurs in 1:2a.

3:1b because you know that

- because you^(plur) know that
- You^(plur) already know that

because you know that: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as because you know that is literally “knowing that.” This phrase introduces the reason for the statement in 3:1a. In some languages, it will be natural to follow the example of the BSB.

Some other ways to translate the phrase “knowing that” are:

you know (RSV)

Remember (JBP)

you may be certain (REB)

3:1c we who teach will be judged more strictly.

- we^(excl) teachers will be judged more strictly than others.
- God will evaluate/examine us^(excl) who teach God’s word more severely/harshly than those who are not teachers.

we who teach: The word we refers to all teachers of God’s word. It includes James. It does not include all of James’ readers.

will be judged more strictly: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will be judged more strictly means “will be examined and punished according to a stricter standard.” This refers to the day when God will judge all human beings. Teachers in the church will be judged more strictly than those who are not teachers. God will judge what they teach and how well their actions correspond to what they teach.

Here, the word judged does not refer to God judging unbelievers and condemning them eternally to hell.

Some ways to translate this are:

will be judged by a much higher standard (JBP)

will be evaluated/assessed more strictly than those who are not teachers

will receive more severe punishment if we fail

The BSB uses a passive verb. Some ways to translate this word are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be judged with greater strictness than others (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will judge us more strictly

- Translate judged as a noun. For example:

will receive more severe judgment

James 3:2

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

Introduction

3:1–2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

The tongue is compared to small things which have large effects

3:2b–3	A small bit can turn a horse
3:4–5c	A small rudder can turn a sailing ship
3:5d–6	A small fire can destroy much
3:7–8	Animals can be tamed but not our tongues

Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9–10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
3:12	Trees produce one kind of fruit

Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speechTranslator's Hand-book on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:2-3

In this paragraph, James explained why teachers are in danger of being condemned at the Judgment. It is because the most difficult thing for a human being to control is what he says. If he can control what he says, he can control everything he does. James illustrated his point by a comparison with how a man controls a horse.

3:2a

We all stumble in many ways.

- ¶ We^(incl) all frequently do wrong things.
- ¶ We^(incl) all often sin.

Verse 3:2 is connected to 3:1 by a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” (as in the RSV). Here it indicates that 3:2 is the basis for the warning in 3:1. Verse 3:2 also introduces the topic of speech. This topic applies to all people, not just to teachers.

Some versions are like the BSB and do not translate this conjunction.

We all: The phrase We all refers to all human beings. Here it does not just refer to teachers. Therefore, the word We includes James' readers as well as James himself.

stumble: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stumble is used figuratively. In this context of Christian believers, it refers to doing something wrong or sinning.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

sin

make many mistakes (RSV)

do...wrong things (CEV)

Here this word does not mean “physically slip and fall.” This word also occurs in 2:10b.

in many ways: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in many ways can mean:

- “many times.” For example:

often (GNT)

- “in many matters/ways.” For example:

in many ways (NJB)

The choice of one of these meanings does not need to exclude the other. If someone sins many times, it is likely that he also sins in many matters. If he sins in many matters, he also sins often. If possible, translate this word in a way that can include both meanings.

3:2b

If anyone is never at fault in what he says,

- If anyone does not sin in his speech,
- The person who never says anything wrong

If anyone is never at fault in what he says: This clause means “if anyone never says anything wrong.” It is not clear whether or not James thought that there are such people. It is best to leave it open in your translation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

But if a person never makes a mistake in what he says (GNT)

If people never said anything wrong (NCV)

the person who never sins in his speech

is never at fault: The words is...at fault translate the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “stumble” earlier in the verse. If possible, use the same expression in both places. Here James was talking about sins such as slander, insults, angry words, lying, and cursing. These words do not refer to speaking when it is not one's turn, or making grammatical mistakes.

3:2c

he is a perfect man,

- that person is perfect/mature,
- is perfect/complete.

he: The pronoun he refers back to “anyone” in 3:2b. In some languages, it is more natural to use another word or phrase here. For example:

such a person

Depending on how you translated “anyone” in 3:2b, you may have to translate this word as “they,” “you,” or “we.”

is a perfect man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfect also means “complete” or “mature” (CEV).

This word also occurs in 1:4. There, the BSB translates it as “mature.”

3:2d

able to control his whole body.

- and he is able to bridle his entire body.
- He is able to control himself completely.

able to control his whole body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to control is literally “to bridle” (as in the RSV). For example:

able to bridle his whole body (ESV)

This word refers to the way people control horses using rope or straps around the head and mouth. These straps are called a bridle. (See the illustration above.) The verb is also “bridle.” (For example, “He bridles his horse.”)

Here this word is a metaphor. James compared someone who is able to control his body to a horse that is bridled. They are similar in that both can be controlled. Both can be taught to obey.

This metaphor continues in 3:3a. So, if possible, you should translate the metaphor here. If it is not possible, you can translate the meaning without a metaphor. For example:

able to control the entire body (NET)

able to restrain/manage his whole body

This same Greek word occurs in 1:26.

his whole body: The phrase his whole body refers to “a person’s entire being.” It refers to “everything that he does.” James was saying that if a person can bridle/control what he says, he will have no difficulty controlling what he does with the rest of his body. He can control everything he thinks and does.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

every part of his body (REB)

everything he does (GW)

every other part of his personality (JBP)

control themselves in every other way (NLT96)

James 3:3

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

Introduction

3:1–2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

The tongue is compared to small things which have large effects

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Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9–10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
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Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speechTranslator’s Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:2–3

In this paragraph, James explained why teachers are in danger of being condemned at the Judgment. It is because the most difficult thing for a human being to control is what he says. If he can control what he says, he can control everything he does. James illustrated his point by a comparison with how a man controls a horse.

3:3

Verse 3:3 reinforces and illustrates the point that James made in 3:2. Human beings are like horses: by controlling the mouth one can control the whole body.

In some languages, it may be natural to introduce this verse with a phrase that indicates that it is an illustration. For example:

To illustrate: when we put bits...

Consider how we put bits...

This is like putting bits....

3:3a**When we put bits into the mouths of horses**

- If we^(incl) put a bit into a horse's mouth
- People put bridles/harnesses on horses/oxen
- For instance, when they tie a rope around an animal's neck

When we put bits into the mouths of horses: In Greek, the illustration of the horse is introduced with the word “if.” There is a textual problem at the beginning of 3:3a. At this point in the Greek text, the manuscript copies do not all agree. The difference is only one Greek letter: *ει δε* (“and if”) and *ιδε* (“look!”). The textual issue is further complicated by a question of spelling. The oldest manuscripts were written with no spaces between the words, so the variant readings are *ειδε* and *ιδε*. But *ει* and *ι* were pronounced similarly and so were also often confused in writing. So either *ειδε* or *ιδε* could be understood as *ει δε* (“and if”) or *ιδε* (“behold”). The reading *ιδε* has some strong arguments in its favor. Mayor, pages 104–106, has the fullest defense of *ιδε* “behold”, though he reads *ιδε γαρ*, following Codex Sinaiticus. Other commentators that support this reading are: Ropes, page 229; Adamson (1976), page 141; and Laws, page 146. Among other writers *ιδε* is accepted by Blass-Debrunner-Funk, §467; Moulton-Howard, Vol. 2, page 77; F. Field, Notes on the Translation of the New Testament, page 237. The reading *ει δε* is accepted by most English versions and the following commentators: Alford, page 303; Huther, page 146; Hiebert, page 209; Moo (1985), page 121; Martin, pages 103, 110; and McCartney, page 194. Davids (1982), page 138, has the fullest defense of this reading. See also Metzger, A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament, 1971, pages 681–682. It is the reading of the modern editions of the Greek text. The KJV follows yet another variant reading, *ιδου* (“be-

hold”). The BSB translates this word as *When*. Some ways to introduce this illustration are:

If we put bits into the mouths of horses to make them obey us, we guide their whole bodies. (NRSV)

We put bits in the mouths of horses to make them obey us, and we have control over everything they do. (GW)

By putting a bit into the mouth of a horse, we can turn the horse in different directions. (CEV)

we put: The phrase *we put* is a general statement concerning what people habitually do. In some languages, it may be more natural to say:

people put

they put

you put

bits into the mouths of horses: In Greek, the words *bits*, *mouths*, and *horses* are plural. In some languages, it will be more natural to use singular words. For example:

We put a bit into the mouth of a horse (GNT)

bits: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *bits* is the noun form of the verb “bridle” in 3:2d. A bridle is a rope or strap that goes over the horse's head to control it. (See the illustration of the horse above.) Attached to the bridle is a piece of metal that passes through the horse's mouth. In English, there is a specific word for this piece of metal. It is called a bit.

The Greek word used here normally refers to the whole bridle: both the straps and the piece of metal. But if your language has a specific word for the piece of metal that is put into the horse's mouth, you should use it here. That is what the BSB has done.

Some ways to translate this word are:

- Use a specific term for the thing that is put in the mouth of a horse to control it. For example, most English versions say:

bits

- Use a more general term for the things that people use to control a horse. In some cases, it will be more natural to leave the phrase into the mouths untranslated. For example:

bridles

reins on the head

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

When we put something into the mouths of horses to guide them

- Use a cultural substitute. For example:

rope around the neck

ring in the nose/snout

horses: Some people are not familiar with horses and have no word for them in their language. If that is the case in your language, you can:

- Use a generic term and describe the function of a horse. For example:

an animal one can ride

- Substitute a different animal that a person can ride and put a bridle on. For example:

an ox

a camel

3:3b

to make them obey us,

- to make it obey us^(incl),
- in order to cause/force them to do what they want.
- to make it obey,

to make them obey us: The clause to make them obey us is the purpose of using a bit and a bridle. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to cause them to obey/follow our will

to force/make them to do what we want

3:3c

we can guide the whole animal.

- we^(incl) can turn/guide the horse's entire body.
- In that way, they can make the whole horse/ox change directions.
- they can control the whole animal.

we can guide: The Greek word that the BSB translates as guide means to turn or change the direction of something that is moving. Some other ways to translate this word are:

we can turn

we guide (RSV)

we can direct (REB)

we are able to make it go where we want (GNT)

whole animal: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as whole animal is literally "whole body." It refers to the body of the horse. The same Greek words are found in 3:2d. When translating this phrase, it is best to use similar words in both verses so that the reader can see the connection between them. For example:

the whole body of the person (3:2d)

the whole body of the horse (3:3c)

James 3:4

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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3:1–2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

The tongue is compared to small things which have large effects

3:2b-3	A small bit can turn a horse
3:4-5c	A small rudder can turn a sailing ship
3:5d-6	A small fire can destroy much
3:7-8	Animals can be tamed but not our tongues

Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9-10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
3:12	Trees produce one kind of fruit

Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:4-5b

In this paragraph, James used the illustration of how a small rudder can turn a large ship. In a similar way, the tongue, even though it is a small part of the body, can have enormous effects.

3:4a

Consider ships as well.

- ¶ For another example, think^(plur) about sailing ships.
- ¶ Think^(plur) also about big boats.
- ¶ Another example is a large canoe.

Consider ships as well: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Consider ships as well is literally “Look, the ships also.” These words introduce James’ second comparison and call attention to that example. Use a natural expression for introducing an illustration in a way that gets the attention of the readers/hearers. For example:

Also, listen to this example of ships

Or think of a ship (GNT)

ships: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ships may refer to any kind of ship or boat. In this verse, James mentions the wind (3:4c). So it is clear that here he was thinking of sailing ships.

A sailing ship is a large boat that uses the power of the wind to move it across the water. One or more sails (very large pieces of strong cloth) are attached to tall

posts on the ship. The wind blows against the cloth which in turn pushes the whole boat.

Some ways to translate this word are:

big sailing ships

huge canoes with sails

very large boats

In some languages, it is more natural to use a singular word “ship” here.

If the idea of a large boat with sails is not known by the people of your region, you may want to include an illustration at this place in your translation.

3:4b

Although they are so large

- Even though they are very big,
- Even if a boat is very big
- A man can control a large canoe

3:4b-c

Although they are so large and are driven by strong winds: In this clause, James listed two things that make it hard to control a ship: its size and the powerful winds that blow on it.

3:4c

and are driven by strong winds,

- and strong winds drive/force them to move along,
- and it is moved only by strong winds,
- that a powerful wind pushes.

are driven by strong winds: The clause are driven by strong winds indicates that it takes strong winds to cause these ships to move. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

are pushed by strong winds

are carried by strong winds

are blown by strong winds

The verb is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it is pushed by strong winds (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

strong winds...move a large sailing ship (CEV)

and seamen use strong winds to move their large sailing ships

3:4d

they are steered by a very small rudder

- only a very small rudder steers/guides them.
- it can be turned by a tiny oar
- He can control it with/using just a small paddle

they are steered by a very small rudder: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as steered is from the same verb as the word translated “guide” in 3:3c. It refers to turning or changing the direction of something that is moving.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

they are guided by a very small rudder (RSV)

are controlled by a very small rudder (JBP)

This verb is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it can be steered by a very small rudder (GNT)

- using an active verb. For example:

a very small rudder controls that big ship (NCV)

the captain uses only a small rudder to make it go in any direction (CEV)

rudder: A rudder is a device that sailors use to steer a boat. It is attached to the back or the side of the boat. In ancient boats, it consisted of a wide, flat piece of wood attached to the end of a long pole. The man who steered the boat held one end of the pole and the other end with the flat piece of wood went down into the water. By pushing or pulling the pole, he was able to change the direction that the boat was going.

Some ways to translate rudder are:

- Use a specific word. For example:

rudder

- Use a word for the piece of wood that moves and turns canoes. For example:

paddle/oar

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

a small steering paddle/thing

Each ship had one rudder. If you have spoken of “ships” in the plural in 3:4a–b, you may need to speak of rudders in the plural.

3:4e

wherever the pilot is inclined.

- The pilot uses it to turn the ship in the direction he wishes to go.
- to go wherever the boatman decides.
- to make it go wherever he wants.

pilot: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pilot refers to the man who steers a boat using a rudder. Some other ways to translate this word are:

boatman

oarsman

the sailor/man who steers

Each ship had one pilot. If you have been talking about “ships,” consider whether you will need to say “pilot” or “pilots” here.

is inclined: James emphasizes that it is the man who steers the boat who determines its direction. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the direction the pilot wants to cause it to go

wherever the pilot chooses to go (NLT)

General Comment on 3:4a–d

In some languages, it may be helpful to reorder this verse so that 3:4b–c comes after 3:4d–e. For example:

^{4a}For another example, think about a sailing ship.

^{4e}The pilot directs it wherever he wishes ^{4d}by means of a tiny rudder, ^{4b}even though the ship may be very large ^{4c}and only strong winds can move it.

James 3:5

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:4–5b

In this paragraph, James used the illustration of how a small rudder can turn a large ship. In a similar way, the tongue, even though it is a small part of the body, can have enormous effects.

3:5a

In the same way, the tongue is a small part of the body,

- In a similar way, the tongue is only a small part of the human body,
- It is the same with our^(incl) mouths. Even though they are just a little part of our bodies,

In the same way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as In the same way introduces the application of the ship illustration to the tongue. Some other ways to translate this word are:

Likewise (NIV)

So too (NET)

So it is with (GNT)

In some languages, it may be natural to make this word a separate sentence. For example:

It is the same with the tongue. (NCV)

the tongue: In some languages, it is difficult to say the tongue without saying whose tongue it is. In such cases, it may be better to say:

a person's tongue

the tongue of people

our tongue(s)

In this passage, the tongue represents the words that a person says with his tongue. In some languages, “the lips” or “the mouth” represent the words that a person says.

a small part of the body: Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

is a very little part of our body

is very small

3:5b

but it boasts of great things.

- but it can brag about doing important things. (GW)
- we^(incl) use them to boast about the great things that we have done.

but: There is a contrast between the tongue (a small part of the body) and the great boasts that it can make. Some versions do the same as the BSB and use the word but to indicate this contrast. It is also possible to show the contrast without a conjunction. For example:

So it is with the tongue: small as it is, it can boast about great things. (GNT)

it boasts of great things: The phrase it boasts of great things here indicates that the person’s tongue boasts or brags about the great things that it has done.

Notice that this is a personification. The meaning is that people use their tongues to boast about the great things they have done. There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the personification. For example:

it can brag about doing important things (GW)
- Translate the meaning. For example:

people use their tongue to boast about the great things that they have done.

Paragraph 3:5c–6

Many versions begin a new paragraph in the middle of 3:5.

This paragraph illustrates the power of the tongue by comparing it with a small fire.

3:5c

Consider how small a spark sets a great forest ablaze.

- ¶ Think^(plur) about how a large forest can be burned by a very small flame/fire.
- ¶ Look^(plur) at this example: a small fire can burn a large forest.

Consider: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Consider is literally “behold!” or “look!” It is the same word as in 3:4a. This word introduces the next comparison and calls attention to it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

- Just think (GNT)
- Let us consider
- Look

how small a spark sets a great forest ablaze: This sentence is more literally “Look how a small fire burns a great forest.”

James was probably referring to a small fire that a person may light in a wooded area. If he does not

control the fire, it will set fire to a large area. This is something that can happen and does sometimes happen. James was not referring to any specific event.

a spark: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as how small a spark means “a small fire” (as in the RSV).

sets a great forest ablaze: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sets...ablaze is an active verb meaning “kindle,” “cause to burn” or “ignite.” The small fire ignites or sets fire to the forest.

Translate this in the way that best emphasizes the contrast between the large size of the forest and the small size of the fire that starts burning it.

a great forest: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a great forest refers to a large area where there are lots of trees. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

- many trees
- a large area full of trees
- lots of brush/grass

James 3:6

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speechTranslator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:5c-6

Many versions begin a new paragraph in the middle of 3:5.

This paragraph illustrates the power of the tongue by comparing it with a small fire.

3:6

In 3:6, James applied the illustration of 3:5c-d to the tongue. Like a fire, the tongue can be destructive.

In this verse, James made a general statement that applies to everyone. Some languages make general statements in other ways. For example:

A person's tongue

Your tongues

Our tongues

3:6a

The tongue also is a fire,

- A person's tongue is like a fire.
- Similarly, the words that we^(incl) say with our tongues/mouths are as dangerous/harmful as a fire.
- A fire destroys things, and the mouth is also like that.

The tongue also is a fire: The clause The tongue also is a fire is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the tongue is compared to a fire. Some ways that they are similar are that both can destroy things and cannot be controlled.

In some languages, a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Some other ways to translate it are:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

the tongue is like a fire (GNT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

the tongue can destroy like a fire

the words that the tongue says are like a fire because they can destroy

The words that we say with our tongue/mouth can cause much harm just like a fire can cause much harm

also: The word also indicates that, in addition to ordinary fires, there is another thing that has characteristics similar to a fire. It is the tongue.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

too

as well

similarly

3:6b

a world of wickedness among the parts of the body.

- It is the part of the body that is very evil.
- Among the parts of the body, the tongue/mouth has great, evil power.

Some versions begin a new sentence here. For example:

It is a world... (GNT)

a world of wickedness: The phrase that the BSB translates as a world of wickedness means that the tongue can do much evil. Differences of interpretation regarding the meaning of "world of evil" are reflected in English versions and discussed at length in commentaries. The two main views are: (1) "world" is used in the common biblical sense of the evil world-system that includes all that opposes God and his ways, and (2) "world" is used as sort of a metaphor for something huge that contains all sorts of things. According to interpretation (1), James was saying that the tongue is the part of our body that has the greatest tendency to serve the evil world-system that is opposed to God. According to interpretation (2), James was highlight-

ing the tongue's great capacity for all sorts of evil. The majority of English versions (which translate in a way similar to "the tongue ... is a world of evil") will be understood to follow interpretation (2). The majority of commentators (including Davids, page 142; Johnson, page 259; Laws, pages 149–150; Moo (2000), page 157; McCartney, page 187; Mitton, pages 126–127; Mayor, pages 114–115; Martin, page 114; SSA, pages 96–97; Translator's Handbook, page 109) favor interpretation (1). They argue that this sense of "world" is common to the Bible and particularly to James, while the meaning of "world" according to interpretation (2) is extremely rare. The definite article "the" preceding "world," they say, also supports understanding "world" in its common and specific sense as the evil world system. In the notes, we have chosen not to present this as an interpretation issue for the following reasons: a) the difference between the two interpretations is slight when one considers the meaning of the metaphor: the tongue has great capacity for evil. b) Many languages do not use the word "world" in a figurative sense to mean what is suggested for either interpretation (1) or (2). So giving translation models for each that do not use the word "world" is quite difficult. c) The idea that the tongue "represents" the evil world (as some would translate interpretation (1), see REB, for example) and the idea that the tongue is a huge sphere/ realm where evil takes place are both quite abstract. We preferred to present a more concrete and simple model for translation. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

it is very, very evil

It is an evil power (CEV)

it is against God

among the parts of the body: James was comparing the tongue with the other parts of the body, like the nose, fingers, and legs. He said that it was the tongue that was causing the trouble.

Some languages do not have a general word or expression for "part of the body." Another way to translate this word is:

in our bodies

3:6c

It pollutes the whole person,

- It contaminates/dirties a person's whole body/being.
- The tongue/mouth can spread evil throughout our^(incl) entire soul/heart.

It pollutes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pollutes literally means "stains." Here it is used in a figurative sense to refer to the tongue's negative, evil effects on a person's inner character.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

it corrupts (NIV)

it completely contaminates (GW)

It stains (NRSV)

It can poison (JBP)

and spreading evil (GNT)

it makes dirty

A related Greek word that the BSB translates as "polluted" occurs in 1:27c.

the whole person: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the whole person is literally "all the body." In this context, it is referring to the inner, moral being of the person, including his thoughts and emotions.

Some other ways to translate this are:

the whole body

all the parts of your being

the whole inner being

3:6d

sets the course of his life on fire,

- It causes his whole life to burn up
- It can destroy our^(incl) whole life.

sets the course of his life on fire: This clause is another description of the destructive power of the tongue. Here, James again used the metaphor of fire.

There are two main ways to interpret this clause:

1. It refers to a person’s entire existence from birth to death. According to this interpretation, the evils of a person’s tongue have a destructive effect on every part of his life. Huther, page 157; Mayor, page 113; Mitton, page 128; Hiebert, pages 217–218; Laws, page 150; Davids (1982), page 143; Moo (1985), page 125; Martin, page 115. For example, the CEV says:

sets a person’s entire life on fire (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, REB, NASB, NLT, CEV, NCV, GW, ESV)

1. It refers to the events of nature, for example, from one season to the next. According to this interpretation, the evils of a person’s tongue have a destructive effect on the whole created world. Alford, page 306; Ropes, page 235. For example, the RSV says:

the cycle of nature (KJV, RSV, NJB)

From the general context of James’ letter, it seems that he is concerned with relationships between human beings, not the rest of the created world. This is the view of the majority of commentators. Therefore it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

sets a person’s entire life on fire (CEV)

burns every aspect of his life

turns his whole life to ashes

- Translate the meaning without keeping the figure of speech. For example:

ruins the whole life of a person

is able to destroy his entire life

3:6e
and is itself set on fire by hell.

- with fire that comes from hell.
- It is like the fire of hell is in/on it.
- Hell has given it this power.

and is itself set on fire by hell: The pronoun itself refers to the tongue. The tongue gets its fire from hell. Hell is the source of the tongue’s destructive fire/

power. This implies that hell has given to the tongue the power to ruin lives.

This clause does not mean that the tongue itself is burned or destroyed.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and it is as if the fire of hell is in it

with flames that come from hell itself (CEV)

and it gets its power to destroy from hell itself

by hell: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hell refers to the place where Satan, his demons, and ungodly people will be punished after the final Day of Judgment.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

eternal fire

the place of unending fire

Satan

James 3:7

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:7-8

In this paragraph, James contrasted taming wild animals with taming the tongue.

3:7

In Greek, a conjunction connects 3:7 to the verses before it. Older English versions translate this conjunction as "For" (as in the RSV). However, this verse is not giving a reason for something. This conjunction introduces some further thoughts on the dangers of the tongue. Most modern English versions do not use any connecting word here. If your language uses a word to introduce further thoughts on a topic, then you may want to use it here.

Some examples of how to translate this word are:

Furthermore

Moreover

In addition

3:7a

All kinds of animals, birds, reptiles, and creatures of the sea

- ¶ Every kind of wild animal, flying thing, crawling thing, and sea creature
- ¶ As for every kind of wild animal, bird, snake, and fish,

All kinds of animals, birds, reptiles, and creatures of the sea: In this verse, all living creatures are divided into four categories:

1. animals
2. birds
3. reptiles

4. creatures of the sea

Different languages divide living creatures in different ways. So it may not be possible to find exact words in your language for each of these four categories. In some languages, it is more natural to divide living creatures in some other way. For example:

wild animals, birds, snakes, and fish

animals that walk, animals that crawl, animals that fly, and animals that swim

every kind of moving thing, even birds and snakes

Some languages have only two or three categories. Use the divisions that are natural in your language.

animals: The Greek word that the BSB translates as animals refers to certain four-footed animals that live on land. It could include the animals that people normally keep under their control like cows, sheep, goats, and dogs. However, the animals in focus here are those that normally live in the wild and that men go out to hunt. These are animals like deer, antelopes, wild pigs, and so on.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

wild animals (GNT)

bush animals

birds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as birds includes all kinds of birds. James may have wanted to include other flying things as well like bats, locusts, and other insects.

reptiles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reptiles refers to all creatures that move about close to the ground. This includes creatures that slide along the ground such as snakes. It also includes creatures that run close to the ground such as lizards.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

creatures that crawl on the ground (REB)

snakes

creatures of the sea: The Greek word that the BSB translates as creatures of the sea includes all crea-

tures that live in water. This includes fish, whales, eels, crabs, and so on.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

creatures that...swim in the sea (REB)

fish (GNT)

3:7b

are being tamed and have been tamed by man,

- is tamed/subdued and has been tamed/subdued by people.
- human beings are controlling them all, and they have been controlling them for a long time.

are being tamed and have been tamed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as tamed occurs twice in 3:7b. This verb is a general word that means “gained control” over a creature. “To gain control” over an animal is: (a) to tame it to be a pet, (b) to make it work for someone, (c) to stop it from eating crops, and even (d) to kill it and eat it. F. Field, *Notes on the Translation of the NT*, pages 237–238. Mitton, pages 129–130, says, “[The Greek word] would represent also man’s power to destroy such animals as threatened human welfare, as well as to compel other animals to submit to domestic service.” The English word “tamed” is perhaps too specific a word here. It covers only part of the meaning.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

subdued (REB)

caused to be submissive

made to obey

controlled

The word tamed occurs twice, but the second time the tense is different. This is to make the point that taming creatures has always happened. Men are doing it today, and they have been doing it since the world began.

Both of these verbs are passive. There are at least two ways to translate them:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

can be subdued and have been subdued by man (REB)

- Use active verbs. This may involve reordering 3:7a–b. For example:

People can tame every kind of wild animal, bird, reptile, and fish, and they have tamed them. (NCV)

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man means “mankind” or the “human race.” Here the focus is on all humans as a group.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

people

humans

human beings

General Comment on 3:7a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 3:7b before 3:7a. For example:

^{7b}Human beings are subduing and have subdued

^{7a}all kinds of animals, birds, reptiles, and creatures of the sea.

James 3:8

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

Introduction

3:1–2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

The tongue is compared to small things which have large effects

3:2b–3	A small bit can turn a horse
3:4–5c	A small rudder can turn a sailing ship
3:5d–6	A small fire can destroy much

3:7-8	Animals can be tamed but not our tongues
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Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9-10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
3:12	Trees produce one kind of fruit

Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:7-8

In this paragraph, James contrasted taming wild animals with taming the tongue.

3:8a

but no man can tame the tongue.

- But nobody can tame/subdue his own tongue.
- However, no human being is able to control what he says with his tongue/mouth.

but: There is a contrast between 3:7 and 3:8a. People are able to tame all of the creatures mentioned in 3:7, but no one can tame the tongue.

Some other ways to translate this contrast are:

However

Yet (GW)

In contrast

no man can tame the tongue: James was referring to people being unable to control their own tongues. In some languages, it may be best to supply that implicit information by using a pronoun. For example:

no man can tame his own tongue.

no man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man is the same word that James used in 3:7b. Here the focus is on each individual human. So it refers to women as well as to men.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

no human being (RSV)

no one (REB)

no person

tame: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tame is the same word as in 3:7b. If it is unnatural to use the same word here, you may be able to use a word meaning “control.” For example:

But our tongues get out of control. (CEV)

the tongue: As in 3:5a, the tongue represents the words that we speak with our tongues. In some languages, “the lips” or “the mouth” represent the words that a person says. Use the same expression here as in 3:5a.

3:8b

It is a restless evil,

- It is wild/uncontrollable and evil.
- It is an evil thing that does not stay under control.

It is a restless evil: The Greek word that the BSB translates as restless primarily means “unstable.” The sense of “unstable” in this context includes:

1. The tongue is restless. It does not rest but is always busy doing evil. For example:

It is restless and evil (NLT)

it is a pest that will not keep still (NJB)

1. The tongue is uncontrollable. There is also a textual variant, *ἀκατάσχετον*, that means “uncontrollable.” It is not clear whether versions that translate “uncontrollable” are following this textual variant or whether they are simply interpreting the sense of *ἀκατάστατον* (“unstable”) to mean “uncontrollable” in this context. The KJV is clearly following the variant reading as found in the Textus Receptus. Most other English versions that translate “uncontrollable” are probably interpreting *ἀκατάστατον* in that way. It cannot be controlled. No one can stop it from doing evil. For example:

It is evil and uncontrollable (GNT)

The two meanings are close. Something that is restless and determined to do evil is probably also uncontrollable. If you have a word that is close in meaning to

both “restless” and “uncontrollable,” it would be good to use it here.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

always busy doing evil

constantly doing wrong

3:8c full of deadly poison.

- It is full of poison that causes death.
- It is harmful/painful like the poison/venom of a deadly snake.
- It does terrible harm to others.

full of deadly poison: The phrase full of deadly poison is a metaphor. In this metaphor, James compared the human tongue to the mouth of a poisonous snake. (Compare Psalm 58:3–4 and Psalm 140:3 for the thought.) One way that they are similar is that both can do great harm.

There are at least three ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the metaphor. If it is not difficult to understand the metaphor in your language, then you should keep the metaphor. For example:

always spreading deadly poison (CEV)

- Use a simile and add the meaning. For example:

very harmful like the venom from a poisonous snake

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

a source of terrible harm/pain

James 3:9

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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3:1–2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

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3:9–10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
3:12	Trees produce one kind of fruit

Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator’s Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

In this paragraph, James showed how inconsistent the tongue is. Both good words and bad words come out of the same mouth. This is something that should not happen. It is also contrary to nature.

3:9a

With the tongue we bless our Lord and Father,

- ¶ We^(incl) praise/bless our^(incl) Lord and Father with our tongues,
- ¶ You^(plur) use your lips/mouths/words to praise the one who is our^(incl) Master and our Father.

With the tongue: As in 3:5a, the tongue represents the words that we speak with our tongues. In some languages, “the lips” or “the mouth” represent the words that a person says.

we bless our Lord and Father: This clause is a general statement. In some languages, it is more natural to use a different noun or pronoun in place of the pronoun we. For example:

people praise their Lord and Father

you^(plur) praise your Lord and Father

we bless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we bless means “speak well” of God, “praise” God or “thank” God. It contrasts with the phrase “curse men” in 3:9b.

James was perhaps thinking of prayer here. Jews, and no doubt Jewish Christians, started many of their prayers of praise to God with the words “Blessed are you.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

we speak well of

we praise (NIV)

We...give thanks (GNT)

See bless, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

our Lord and Father: Some manuscripts and the KJV have “God” instead of “Lord.” “Lord” has the strongest manuscript support and is followed by the majority of English versions. The phrase our Lord and Father contains two titles that both refer to the one God. Make sure your translation clearly refers to one God.

Some ways to do this are:

the one who is our Lord and our Father

our Lord who is our Father

our Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “one who is in authority,” or “master.” Here it refers to God. He is the one who has supreme authority.

Some other ways to translate Lord are:

our Master

our Owner

our supreme Chief/Leader

God, our Lord

See also Lord in the Glossary.

3:9b and with it we curse men,

- and we^(incl) also speak evil against people with our tongues,
- You^(plur) also use your lips/mouths/words to condemn your fellow humans,

we curse: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we curse means “we speak against a person.” It means “we call on God (or another spiritual power) to do harm to someone.” It is stronger than insulting or abusing someone. It is the opposite of blessing a person.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

we speak evil against

we condemn with words

we call upon God to harm

men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men refers to human beings in general. It includes women and children. Check how you translated this same word in 3:7b and 3:8a.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

people

other human beings

It is particularly important here to use a word that includes all human beings. This is so that your translation does not convey the wrong meaning that only men “have been made in God’s likeness” (in 3:9c).

3:9c who have been made in God’s likeness.

- even though they were made/created to be like God.
- in spite of the fact that God made/created them to be like himself.

The clause in 3:9c points out why it is wrong for the same tongue to praise God and then curse men. It is wrong because humans are made in God’s likeness. Doing such a thing is praising God and then cursing his likeness.

who have been made in God’s likeness: The BSB and most other English versions translate 3:9c as a relative clause. In some languages, translating this clause as a relative clause may imply that there are other people who have not been created in God’s likeness. It may

also hide the point that cursing men is cursing God's likeness.

Some other ways to translate this clause to give the correct meaning are:

and they have been made in God's likeness

though they are made in God's likeness (REB)

in spite of the fact that they are created in God's likeness

have been made in God's likeness: The BSB translates the Greek verb here as the passive verb have been made. Some ways to translate this verb are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

who were created to be like God (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

whom God made like himself (NCV)

in God's likeness: The phrase in God's likeness indicates that God made people to resemble him in certain ways. Theologians debate as to what ways people are in God's likeness. Some of the ways they suggest are: people can love, talk, create, reason, make moral choices, rule God's creation, and appreciate beauty. You will not want to say all this in your translation. But avoid translating this in a way that will make readers think that people look like God. It is speaking more of their character and abilities, not of their physical appearance.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are in the examples above.

This phrase comes from Genesis 1:26.

James 3:10

Section 3:1-12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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3:1-2a: Becoming a teacher in the church is a serious thing to do

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Each of us should be consistent in using our tongue for good

3:9-10	The tongue should not be used for both blessing and cursing
3:11	Springs produce one kind of water
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Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speech
Translator's Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:9-12

In this paragraph, James showed how inconsistent the tongue is. Both good words and bad words come out of the same mouth. This is something that should not happen. It is also contrary to nature.

3:10

In this verse, James summarized the statement he made in 3:9 and then made a comment on it.

3:10a

Out of the same mouth come blessing and cursing.

- Words of praise and words of cursing, both come out of the same mouth.
- You^(plur) praise one person and curse another person with the same mouth.

Out of the same mouth come blessing and cursing:

In some languages, blessing and cursing are not normally described as things that can come or go. So it may not be possible to translate this clause literally. It may be necessary to say something like:

We use our mouths both to bless and to curse.

The same mouth speaks praises and curses.

with our tongues we speak both praises and curses (CEV)

blessing and cursing: When you translate the words blessing and cursing, use words that are the same as, or related to, the words you used in 3:9. For example:

blessing and cursing (RSV)

you speak well of one and evil against the other

3:10b
My brothers, this should not be!

- My brothers and sisters, we^(incl) should not do this.
- My fellow believers, that is not right/good.

My brothers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My brothers refers to other believers in Christ. It refers to both the men and women to whom James was writing. James used the term of address My brothers here to soften his rebuke (“this should not be”). You may have another way in your language to soften a rebuke and could use it here.

This same phrase occurs at 1:2a.

The Greek text actually places the phrase My brothers in the middle of “this should not be.” In some languages, it may be more natural to place it at the end. For example:

This should not be so, my friends. (REB)

this should not be!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this should not be is a strong rebuke. It means that it is quite wrong for people to speak both praises and curses. James is not saying that it is wrong to speak praises. He is saying that it is wrong to speak curses.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

this should not happen (GW)

this isn’t right (CEV)

what is being done should not be like that

we should not do this

James 3:11

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

In this section, James warned believers to be careful with their speech. When believers do not control what they say, it can have a devastating, evil impact. This was an especially serious danger for those who taught others in the church. James reinforced his warning with a series of comparisons or illustrations to show how important it is that Christians control their speech.

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We must control our speechTranslator’s Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

In this paragraph, James showed how inconsistent the tongue is. Both good words and bad words come out of the same mouth. This is something that should not happen. It is also contrary to nature.

3:11–12

In 3:11–12, James supported his teaching with illustrations from nature. He showed how inconsistent it is for the same mouth to speak both good and bad words.

3:11

Can both fresh water and salt water flow from the same spring?

- Can both pure and impure water flow from the same spring?
- A spring/well certainly cannot produce both good drinking water and bitter water from the same hole.

Can both fresh water and salt water flow from the same spring?: In Greek, this sentence is more literally, “Does a spring pour out both fresh and bitter water from the same hole?” Notice that the BSB has combined the words “spring” and “hole” into one expression.

This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that a spring certainly does not give two types of water from the same hole.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can clean water and dirty water both flow from the same spring? (CEV)

A spring does not pour out fresh water and bitter water from the same opening, does it? (NET)

Fresh water and salt water cannot both flow from the same spring, right?

- As a statement. For example:

No spring of water pours out sweet water and bitter water from the same opening. (GNT)

Obviously good and bad water do not both flow from the same spring.

Translate this sentence in a way that is natural in your language for emphasizing well-known facts.

fresh water: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fresh water describes water that tastes good. Some other ways to translate this word are:

good water

drinking water

clean water

Some English versions (GNT, KJV) translate this word as “sweet water.” But this does not mean that the

water has been sweetened. It is an expression that means that the water is good to drink.

salt water: The Greek word that the BSB translates as salt water describes water that tastes foul or bitter. It is water that is not good to drink.

This Greek word does not literally mean salt. Some English versions translate it as salt water:

1. to contrast it with fresh water,
2. because the word “salt” occurs in 3:12c where it is contrasted with fresh water, and
3. because salt water is an example of water that is not good to drink.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

dirty/bad water

polluted water (GW)

bitter water

brackish water (REB)

spring: A spring is a source of water where the water flows out from a hole in the ground or rock. Some other ways to translate this word are:

water source

place where water springs/pours out

place in the ground where water comes/gushes out

In languages where springs are not known, the word spring can be translated as “a water well.”

James 3:12

Section 3:1–12: Believers must be careful what they say

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

We must control our speechTranslator’s Handbook on James, page 100.

Controlling the things we say (NCV)

Paragraph 3:9–12

In this paragraph, James showed how inconsistent the tongue is. Both good words and bad words come out of the same mouth. This is something that should not happen. It is also contrary to nature.

3:12b or a grapevine bear figs?

- Or, can a grapevine produce figs?
- Are guavas found on a passion fruit vine? Of course not!
- nor can a grapevine produce figs.

3:12a–b can a fig tree grow olives, or a grapevine bear figs?:

This is a rhetorical question. James used this question to rebuke his readers by emphasizing a well-known fact: each plant produces its own kind of fruit. He was saying that a fig tree certainly cannot produce olives and a grapevine cannot produce figs. This means that good people should not produce curses.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can a fig tree produce olives...or a vine produce figs? (NET)

A fig tree cannot bear olives, and a grapevine cannot bear figs, right?

- As a statement. For example:

A fig tree...cannot bear olives; a grapevine cannot bear figs (GNT)

A fig tree certainly cannot produce olives, and a grapevine certainly cannot produce figs.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

fig tree...olives...grapevine...figs: In many languages, there are no words for the exact kinds of trees and fruit that James mentions here. However, the important part of the meaning here is not the exact kind of tree or fruit. The point is the fact that a tree cannot bear fruit that is not of its own kind.

James used these particular trees and fruits in his illustration because they were common in the region where he lived. Figs were a delicious fruit that was typical of the good things of that land. Olives were important as the main source oil used for cooking in that region. Grapes were squeezed to obtain juice, which was made into wine, the main drink of the region.

One way to translate these terms is to use trees and fruit that are common in your area. For example:

Does a guava tree produce mangos? Or does a passion fruit vine produce guavas? Of course not!

3:12a My brothers, can a fig tree grow olives,

- My brothers and sisters, can a fig tree produce olives?
- My fellow believers, are mangos found on a guava tree?
- My brothers and sisters, a fig tree certainly cannot produce olives,

My brothers: Once again, James used the term of address My brothers to soften the rebuke in 3:10–12.

See the notes on “my brothers” at 1:2a and 3:10b.

3:12c Neither can a salt spring produce fresh water.

- Neither can a bitter-water spring produce fresh/ drinking water.

- Likewise, a spring that gives bad water can/does not produce good water.

Neither: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Neither introduces the last sentence of this paragraph. Some other ways to begin this sentence are:

Likewise

In the same way (GW)

It is just as impossible (JBP)

The picture has changed from trees and their fruit back to a spring and its water. The point here is not only that one kind of spring cannot produce water of a different kind. The point is that a bad spring cannot produce good water. The translation of KJV “so can no fountain [that is, spring] both yield salt water and fresh” depends on different manuscript copies from the ones followed by the modern versions. The text followed by KJV says the same thing in other words as 3:11, but the text that BSB and the other modern versions follow says that bad cannot produce good. This is an advance in James’ argument, preparing the way for the next section 3:13–18. Therefore it seems likely that the text followed here by KJV is not original, and so it is not recommended. The implied information is that bad people cannot produce good praise to God.

salt spring: The Greek word that the BSB translates as salt spring is literally “salty.” (The noun spring is not in the Greek text here but is implied from 3:11.) This word is different than the word meaning “bitter” (BSB “salt”) in 3:11. But the meaning is similar. It refers to a spring that always produces water that is not good to drink.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

a spring whose water tastes salty

a spring that produces water not fit to drink

In Israel, there are springs that are so full of minerals that it is not safe to drink the water. If salt springs are unknown in your area, you may want to replace salt spring with something that is more common in your area. For example:

a salty pool (NLT96)

a salt pond (ESV)

a well that gives foul water

fresh water: Here the phrase fresh water refers to water that tastes good. This same word occurs in 3:11.

James 3:13

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:13

This verse introduces the topic of spiritual wisdom by challenging people who claim to be wise. James said that their claim must be tested.

See the General Comment on 3:13a–c at the end of 3:13c for ways to reorder this verse.

3:13a

Who is wise and understanding among you?

- ¶ Do any of you have wisdom and insight? (GW)
- ¶ If there is anyone among you^(plur) who thinks that he is wise and knows what is right and wrong,
- ¶ Those of you^(plur) who think/claim that you are truly wise

Who is wise and understanding among you?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to focus on a specific group of people and to address them. He addressed those who thought that they were wise and understanding. For example:

Who among you thinks/says that he is wise and understanding?

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Are there those among you who are truly wise and understanding? (NCV)

Do any of you have wisdom and insight? (GW)

- As a conditional clause. For example:

If you are wise and understand God's ways (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

Anyone who thinks he is wise and understanding

Regarding those who think that they are wise and understanding

Now I want to talk to those of you who think/claim that you are wise and understanding.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

is wise and understanding: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as wise and understanding are a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. In some languages, both words can be translated by one emphatic word or phrase. For example:

truly wise

is wise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wise here describes a person who lives in a way that agrees with what God wants. Wisdom in the Bible is concerned with choosing between right and wrong actions.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

has wisdom

thinking is good

makes good/godly choices

understanding: The Greek word that the BSB translates as understanding here describes a person who knows what is right and what is wrong.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

has insight

is perceptive

3:13b

Let him show it by his good conduct,

- If you^(plur) do, show it by/through the way you behave/live.
- he should show this by/in his good living.
- must prove it and behave well.

Let him show it: The clause Let him show it is a command. The pronoun him refers to the person in 3:13a who is wise and understanding. The verb show here means “prove to everyone” or “demonstrate.” The pronoun it refers to the claim to be wise in 3:13a. So this clause means:

He must show/prove to others that he is wise and understanding

Another way to translate this clause is:

He must do what is wise and understanding, then people will know/see it in him.

Your translation of this clause must correspond with the way you translated “Who is...” in 3:13a. For example:

^{13a}Do any of you have wisdom...? ^{13b}Show this... (GW)

^{13a}If you are wise..., ^{13b}prove it... (NLT)

^{13a}Are there those among you who are truly wise...? ^{13b}Then they should show it (NCV)

^{13a}A person who thinks that he is wise ^{13b}must prove that he has wisdom.

by his good conduct: The phrase by his good conduct is the means by which a person shows that he is wise. The phrase good conduct refers to the person's good behavior or good conduct. The KJV says “out of a good conversation.” When the KJV was translated, the word “conversation” meant “behavior.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by his good life (NIV)

by living right (NCV)

with/through his good behavior

in his good works

3:13c

by deeds done in the humility that comes from wisdom.

- In other words, show^(plur) it by doing good deeds with the humility that wisdom brings.
- He must show it by/with good works that he does gently and wisely.
- Do^(plur) good deeds humbly. This humility comes from being wise.

by deeds done in the humility that comes from wisdom: There are several ways to connect this phrase to the rest of the verse:

1. Make it a more specific restatement of the phrase “by his good conduct” (in 3:13b). For example:

^{13b}You are to prove it by your good life, ^{13c}by your good deeds performed with humility and wisdom. (GNT)

1. Make it the second clause that is parallel to “by his good conduct.” For example:

^{13b}Then show it by living right ^{13c}and by being humble and wise in everything you do. (CEV)

1. Make it the object of the verb “show.” For example:

^{13b}he should show ^{13c}his works done in the gentleness that wisdom brings. (NET)The NET accurately follows the Greek grammar here by translating “his works” as the object of the verb “show.” However, this solution makes it difficult to naturally connect the phrase “by his good conduct” (3:13b) to the rest of the sentence.

deeds done in...humility: The clause deeds done in... humility means “good deeds that are done with a humble attitude.” In other words, the deeds are done modestly and not proudly. It is not clear from the Greek text whether the phrase in the humility that comes from wisdom is to be connected to the word “show” or whether it is to be connected to the word “deeds.” In other words, does it mean that when the man shows the deeds he has done, he is to do it humbly, not

proudly? Or does it mean that the deeds he has done must be deeds that are done humbly, not selfishly? The second interpretation makes better sense in the context and is accepted by BSB, GNT, NIV, and many commentators.

deeds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deeds is more literally “works” (as in the RSV). This word refers to “good deeds.” It refers to good activities that people do out of love for God or for other people. This same word occurs in 2:14c.

the humility that comes from wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the humility that comes from wisdom is literally “the humility/meekness of wisdom.” This probably means the humility that comes from wisdom (as the BSB translates it). In other words, wisdom is the source from which humility comes.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the gentleness that wisdom brings (NET)

humility. This humility comes from wisdom

When someone has humility that comes from wisdom, he has both humility and wisdom. So another way to translate this phrase is:

humility and wisdom (GNT)The Translator’s Handbook (page 122) and Exegetical Summary (page 136) both treat “humility and wisdom” (GNT) as a separate interpretation from “humility that comes from wisdom.” However it is not certain whether the GNT (and similar CEV) really interpret the meaning of the genitive differently or have simply chosen to translate it differently.

humility: The Greek word that the BSB translates as humility refers to a submissive and teachable attitude. This attitude is expressed by a person being gentle or mild rather than being harsh or ready to fight.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

meekness (ESV)

gentleness (NCV)

being mild

See the note on 1:21c “humbly” which translates the same phrase in Greek.

wisdom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wisdom here refers to the ability to know and choose what is right. Use an expression that corresponds to the one you have chosen for “wise” in 3:13a.

General Comment on 3:13a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 3:13a–c. For example:

^{13a}You who claim to be wise and to perceive things well ^{13b}need to prove it. In order to prove it, you should behave well. ^{13c}That is, you should do good without boasting about it. This is the attitude that wise people have.

^{13a}Some of you think that you are wise and understand what is right and wrong. ^{13b}So then, behave well. ^{13c}Do good deeds in a gentle/humble way. ^{13b}This will show/prove that you are wise, ^{13c}since truly wise people are humble.

General Comment on 3:13c

In some languages, it may be necessary to divide this complex clause into several sentences. For example:

^{13c} He must also show his wisdom by his good deeds. He does these good deeds with a humble attitude. This humility comes from wisdom.

^{13c}He must do good and not think he is great or important. That way he will show people that he is wise.

James 3:14

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:14–16

In 3:14–16, James discussed false wisdom. People who have envy and personal ambition show that the wisdom that they claim to have is false. It does not come from God.

3:14a–b

if you harbor bitter jealousy and selfish ambition in your hearts: This clause begins with the word if. But James was assuming that some of his readers did have bitter envy and selfish ambition. In some languages, it may be best not to translate this as an “if” sentence. It may be better to say:

Some of you harbor bitter envy and selfish ambition in your hearts.

From the context, it seems that James was still addressing men who wanted to be recognized as teachers in the church. No doubt there was more than one teacher, and they were competing with one another. Every teacher and his supporters thought that their way was correct. They were dedicated to their way so much that they argued bitterly and fiercely with their opponents.

3:14a

But if you harbor bitter jealousy

- ¶ But if you^(plur) have a lot of envy
- ¶ But some of you^(plur) are extremely jealous of other people

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast with 3:13c. The “bitter envy and selfish ambition” that James saw in people are in contrast to the “humility” (3:13c) that he wanted to see.

you harbor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as harbor is literally “have” (as in the RSV). Some other ways to translate this word are:

you have (NET)

you are (NCV)

bitter jealousy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bitter is often used to describe water that is not drinkable because of its bad taste (as it was used in 3:11). It is used figuratively here to refer to an attitude that is harsh, unpleasant, and resentful.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as jealousy also means “envy.” It is intense, negative feelings when someone else succeeds in ways that you have not succeeded.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

bitter envy (NIV)

severe envy

very jealous

extremely unhappy when others succeed

3:14b

and selfish ambition in your hearts,

- and selfishness in your^(plur) hearts,
- and selfish.

and selfish ambition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as selfish ambition can also be translated as “selfishness” (as in the NET). It refers to the attitude of someone who works to advance his own interests even if it harms or offends others.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

self-centered ambition (GW)

selfishness (NET)

and you want only you yourself to be dominant

and you only think about yourself

want to succeed more than others are succeeding

In this verse, James seems to have been warning teachers not to seek to increase the number of people in the church who supported them. He was also warning their groups of supporters not to promote their own teacher and try to destroy the reputation of the other teachers.

This same word occurs in Philippians 2:3–4.

in your hearts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hearts refers to the part of a person where his thoughts and feelings come from. Some languages refer to this part of a person as the liver or stomach. In other languages, it may be most natural to omit this

phrase altogether and leave the meaning implicit. For example:

if you are bitterly jealous and selfish

Or you may translate it in another way that refers to someone’s inward thoughts and attitudes. For example:

if you have bitter jealousy and selfishness inside yourself

if you are bitterly jealous and filled with self-centered ambition (GW)

3:14c

do not boast in it

- do not boast of your wisdom. (JBP)
- So do not brag and say that you^(plur) are wise.

do not boast in it: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as do not boast in it is literally “do not boast” (as in the RSV). Most scholars agree that the boast is a claim to be wise. You may want to make this clear in your translation. For example:

do not boast of your wisdom (JBP)

don’t brag about being wise (NLT96)

boast: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as boast here means to brag or say good things about oneself. James was telling his readers not to make confident or arrogant claims that they were wise.

3:14d

or deny the truth.

- Do not lie^(plur) like that.
- It’s not true.

or deny the truth: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as deny the truth is literally “do not lie against the truth.” There are several ways to interpret this clause. The two most common ways are: There is a third view: the truth which is contradicted is the truth that true wisdom is accompanied by meekness. When someone claims to be wise but is full of selfishness and jealousy, his life contradicts this truth. (See Martin, pages 130–131; Moo (2000), page 172; Laws, page 160–161.)

1. The word truth refers to the truth regarding the boast that they are wise. According to this inter-

pretation, those who boasted that they were wise were not telling the truth. They were lying. Huther, page 167; Mayor, page 123; Mitton, page 137; Davids (1982), page 151. For example:

^{14c}Don't say that you are wise ^{14d}when it isn't true. (GW) (GW, NLT96; possibly REB, NLT, CEV, NCV) These last four versions which speak about hiding, covering up, or defying the truth may mean "do not cover up the truth that you are really full of jealousy and selfish ambition and so cannot have true wisdom."

1. The word truth refers to the truth that is found in the gospel or God's word. (Or it may refer more specifically to the truth about what wisdom really is like.) According to this interpretation, those who boasted that they were wise "denied, contradicted, or hid from others" the truth of the gospel by the way they lived. They prevented or hindered people from knowing what real truth was.

Many English translations are ambiguous, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This is a lie.

Do not lie like that.

You are lying. It's not true.

when what you do contradicts the truth

James 3:15

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:14–16

In 3:14–16, James discussed false wisdom. People who have envy and personal ambition show that the wisdom that they claim to have is false. It does not come from God.

3:15a

Such wisdom does not come from above,

- Wisdom like that does not come from God above
- That is not the type of wisdom that comes from God in heaven.
- It is not God who makes people "wise" like that.

Such wisdom: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Such wisdom refers to the false type of wisdom indicated by the pronoun "it" in 3:14c. James was critical of this type of wisdom. He did not think that it was really wisdom at all.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

That kind of wisdom (CEV)

This so-called wisdom

The kind of wisdom that is like that

This is not the kind of wisdom that

does not come from above: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as does not come down from above means that this wisdom did not come from God. Those people who claimed to be wise and yet had bitterness in their hearts did not have the true wisdom that is from God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

does not come from above (NET)

does not come from God (NCV)

The phrase "is from above" also occurs in 1:17a. See also heaven, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 3:15a

Some other ways to translate 3:15a are:

God is not the one who gives such wisdom.

God is not the one who makes people wise like that.

3:15b but is earthly,

- but from this earth.
- Instead, it comes from this world.
- Rather, it comes from people here on the earth.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a strong contrast. The contrast is between the place where this false wisdom (3:15a) does not come from and the place where this wisdom (3:15b–d) actually does come from.

This same conjunction occurs in 2:18a.

earthly: The Greek adjective that the BSB translates as earthly indicates that false wisdom comes from the earth. It comes from humans. This word contrasts with the word “above” in 3:15a.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

from the world (NCV)

it comes from this world (JBP)

it comes from people here on the earth

3:15c unspiritual,

- It comes from the thoughts of human beings.
- It comes from people who do not have the Spirit of God.
- It is human thoughts.

unspiritual: The Greek adjective that the BSB translates as unspiritual indicates that false wisdom comes from natural, human life. In other words, this type of wisdom comes from people who do not have the Spirit of God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

It comes from the thoughts of human beings.

It does not come from the Holy Spirit.

It comes from people who do not have the Holy Spirit in them.

3:15d demonic.

- And it is from demons.
- It comes from the devil/Satan.

- It is the way that evil spirits think.

demonic: The Greek adjective that the BSB translates as demonic is literally “of demons.” This indicates that false wisdom comes from demons. When people are guided by this kind of wisdom, they do the kind of wicked things that demons do.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

devilish (RSV)

demonic (GNT)

it is from the devil (NCV)

and comes from the devil himself (CEV)

James 3:16

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:14–16

In 3:14–16, James discussed false wisdom. People who have envy and personal ambition show that the wisdom that they claim to have is false. It does not come from God.

3:16a

For where jealousy and selfish ambition exist,

- For wherever there is jealousy and selfishness/rivalry,
- In any place where people are jealous of one another and put themselves first,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the basis for the comment in 3:15. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction.

where jealousy and selfish ambition exist: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as where jealousy and selfish ambition exist is literally “where envy and selfish ambition.” There is no verb in Greek here. James meant “where there is envy and selfish ambition....”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

where you have envy and selfish ambition (NIV)

Whenever people are jealous or selfish (CEV)

jealousy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as jealousy is the same word as in 3:14a–b. It can also mean “envy”.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

envious

jealous (CEV)

unhappy when others succeed

selfish ambition: The Greek word that the BSB translates as selfish ambition can also be translated as “selfishness” (as in the NET). This is the same word as in 3:14a–b. It refers to the attitude of someone who works to advance his own interests even if it harms or offends others. Here you may use the same word as in 3:14, or you may use a synonym.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

selfishness (NET)

rivalry (GW)

For some other ways to translate this word, see the examples at 3:14a–b.

3:16b

there will be disorder

- there is also chaos/unrest
- they will cause trouble/quarrels

there will be disorder: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disorder describes an unstable state of affairs. It is the opposite of peace and calm. In this context, it means unrest in the church community. The adjective related to this word is used in 1:8b (“unstable”) and 3:8b (“restless”).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

there you will have chaos

there will be confusion (NCV)

you also find disharmony (JBP)

they will cause trouble

3:16c

and every evil practice.

- and every kind of evil. (GW)
- and do many wicked deeds.

every evil practice: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as every evil practice means “all kinds of bad actions/behavior.” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

every kind of evil (GW)

wickedness of every kind (NRSV)

all kinds of wicked deeds

James 3:17

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:17–18

This paragraph discusses true wisdom. This wisdom is from God.

3:17

In this verse, James used seven Greek terms to describe true wisdom. The number of words that you need in your language to translate these seven terms

is not the important matter. In some languages, it may be natural to translate these seven Greek terms with fewer than seven terms. In other languages, more than seven terms may be needed. For example, the CEV uses eight terms:

But the wisdom that comes from above leads us to be pure, friendly, gentle, sensible, kind, helpful, genuine, and sincere.

You should use the number of terms necessary in your language to cover the same area of meaning that the Greek does with its seven terms.

3:17a

But the wisdom from above is first of all pure,

- ¶ But the wisdom that is from heaven/above is firstly pure.
- ¶ But the people whom God makes wise are most importantly pure/clean.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. The contrast is between earthly wisdom (in 3:15) and heavenly wisdom (here in 3:17).

the wisdom from above: The term “from above” refers to God. For example:

the wisdom that comes from God (NCV)

(This same term also occurs in 3:15a.)

This clause contains a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, James speaks of wisdom as if it were a person who is pure, peace-loving, considerate, and so on.

There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the personification. For example:

the wisdom from above (NLT)

the wisdom that comes from above (CEV)

the wisdom that God gives

- Translate the meaning. For example:

the person whose wisdom comes from God

the person whom God makes wise

is first of all pure: The phrase first of all means “most importantly.” James listed seven Greek terms to describe wisdom. Being pure is the most important one.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

is firstly pure

is most importantly pure

In some languages, the most important term in a list occurs last. If this is the case in your language, you should put your word for “pure” at the end of the list.

pure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pure means “free from faults,” and “morally undefiled.” If a person is pure, he is not contaminated by any desires that do not come from God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

faultless

without sinful desires

only desires to please God

3:17b

then peace-loving,

- It is also peaceful,
- They do not cause quarrels/fights,

peace-loving: A peace-loving person is someone who has peaceful relationships with other people. He also helps others get along peacefully. For example, he may try to stop people from quarreling or try to make peace among enemies.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

peaceful (GNT)

cooperative

friendly (CEV)

does not cause quarrels/fights

3:17c

gentle,

- and considers the feelings/opinions of others,

- they are not harsh towards people,

gentle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentle in the sense of not insisting on one's own rights and opinions. A person with this quality considers the feelings and needs of others. This word often describes a leader (king or judge) who is considerate/merciful in dealing with people rather than being strict and severe.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

considerate (NIV)

considers the opinions/needs of others

respectful to others

not harsh toward people

3:17d

accommodating,

- and obedient,
- they are not stubborn/obstinate,

accommodating: The Greek word that the BSB translates as accommodating refers to someone who is:

1. open to listen to and be persuaded by the good reasons and ideas of others
2. obedient and submissive

Such a person is not stubborn. If you have a word that combines the ideas of (a) and (b), it would be good to use it here. If you have words that mean either (a) or (b), it is recommended that you choose a word that means (a).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

willing to yield (NRSV)

open to reason (RSV)

not stubborn

open-minded (REB)

listens to what other people say

3:17e

full of mercy and good fruit,

- and is very compassionate, and does many good deeds/works
- they have pity for other people and are always doing good deeds.

full of mercy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as full of mercy means always ready to show kindness to people who are in need. It is not just feeling sympathetic but includes doing deeds that express love and concern for them.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

completely merciful

has pity/mercy

always ready to help those who are troubled (NCV)

See also the note on mercy at 2:13a.

full of...good fruit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as full of...good fruit describes a person who does many good, kind actions. The word fruit refers to the actions that wisdom produces. So other ways to translate this are:

filled with...good deeds (GW)

always ready to...do good for others (NCV)

helpful (CEV)

generous

These two expressions, mercy and good fruit, describe the same behavior in two different ways.

3:17f

impartial, and sincere.

- and is not prejudiced and is honest.
- They do not show favoritism and are not hypocrites.

impartial: There are two main ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as impartial:

1. It means without making distinctions, without being partial. This person is someone who treats everyone fairly. He is not one who treats some people kindly and other people unkindly. Laws, page 164; Davids (1982), page 154; Mitton, page 141; Moo (1985), page 136; Martin, page 134. For example, the GNT says:

it is free from prejudice (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NJB, NET, GW, GNT, KJV, ESV, NLT, NCV, JBP)

1. It means without doubting, without uncertainty. A person such as this stands wholeheartedly for the truth and does not have divided loyalties. Alford, page 310–311; Huther, page 169; Mayor, page 127; Ropes, page 250; Adamson (1976), page 156; Hiebert, page 236; McCartney, page 202. For example, the NASB says:

unwavering (NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is followed by the majority of recent versions and commentators.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

does not treat people differently

does not show favoritism

does not prefer/favor one person above another

sincere: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sincere describes a genuine servant of God and the church. It describes someone who is not trying to deceive others. He is not pretending to be something that he is not.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

honest (NCV)

without hypocrisy (KJV)

does not pretend

James 3:18

Section 3:13–18: The wisdom of God is quite different from the wisdom of the devil

This section has three paragraphs. First, in 3:13 James introduced the topic of wisdom. Then he continued with two paragraphs. In each paragraph he discussed one type of wisdom. The first type he discussed (in 3:14–16) is the false wisdom that does not come from God. The second type he discussed (in 3:17–18) is the true wisdom that does come from God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

True Wisdom Comes from God (NLT)

Two Kinds of Wisdom (NIV)

Paragraph 3:17–18

This paragraph discusses true wisdom. This wisdom is from God.

3:18a–b

Peacemakers who sow in peace reap the fruit of righteousness: This sentence is a proverb. It also contains a metaphor. There are at least two main issues to consider as you translate this verse.

Issue 1: How to translate naturally

This Greek sentence is more literally “the fruit/harvest of righteousness is sown in peace by the ones making peace.” It may be strange to speak of a harvest being sown. So it may be more natural to speak of sowing seeds that result in a harvest. For example:

And those who are peacemakers will plant seeds of peace and reap a harvest of righteousness. (NLT)

Issue 2: How to translate the metaphor

The words sow and raise a harvest are a metaphor. James compared the activity of sowing (seeds) and harvesting a crop to the activity of a peacemaker. These activities are similar in that certain actions naturally lead to certain results. Just as planting a crop leads to a harvest, promoting peace among the community of believers leads to righteous actions in that community.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

When peacemakers plant seeds of peace, they will harvest justice. (CEV)

And those who are peacemakers will plant seeds of peace and reap a harvest of goodness. (NLT96)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Peacemakers are like people who plant and then harvest a crop. When they make/promote peace, it results in righteous actions.

- Translate the meaning without using a metaphor. For example:

When people live peacefully and help others to be at peace, then the result is righteous actions in their lives and the lives of others.

3:18a

Peacemakers who sow in peace

- When peacemakers plant seeds of peace, (CEV)
- Peacemakers are like people who sow
- When people live in peace and work for peace,

Peacemakers who sow in peace: The phrase who sow in peace describes all peacemakers. It does not indicate that some peacemakers sow in peace and others do not.

Some ways to make this clear are:

When people who are peacemakers sow in peace

Peacemakers, because they sow in peace

Peacemakers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Peacemakers is literally “those who make peace” (as in the RSV). It refers to people who:

1. live in peace with other people, and
2. help others to stop quarreling and live together peacefully.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

People who live peacefully and who help others to live together peacefully

People who live in peace and who help others stop quarreling

Those who are peaceful and who settle conflicts

who sow in peace: The way you translate the phrase in peace will depend on whether you keep the metaphor or translate the meaning. For example:

- If you keep the metaphor, the word peace here refers to that which is sown. For example:

The peace sown by peacemakers (NJB)

When peacemakers plant seeds of peace (CEV)

- If you translate the meaning, the phrase in peace refers to the manner or attitude in which peacemakers act. In other words, peacemakers do things in

a manner or attitude that leads to peace between people. For example:

When people live peacefully and help others to be at peace

When people behave in a peaceable way

3:18b

reap the fruit of righteousness.

- they harvest righteousness/goodness.
- and then harvest a crop. When they make/promote peace, it produces righteous actions/deeds.
- then the result is good deeds in their lives and the lives of others.

reap the fruit of righteousness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as reap the fruit of righteousness is literally “a crop/harvest of righteousness.” It is a noun phrase. Some versions, like the BSB, translate it as a verb phrase. (Some other examples are below.)

The phrase the fruit of righteousness means “a harvest that consists of righteousness.” Right living that pleases God is the fruit or crop that is produced by wise people who sow peace.

The way you translate this phrase will depend on whether you keep the metaphor or translate the meaning. For example:

- If you keep the metaphor, you will translate the word harvest literally. For example:

reap a harvest of righteousness (NLT)

they will harvest justice (CEV)

- If you translate the meaning, you will translate the word fruit as “result” or “produce” or some similar word. For example:

then the result is righteous actions in their lives and the lives of others

it produces righteousness

righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness means:

1. actions that are right and good in God’s sight. Righteous actions will result when people live in peace with others and promote peace.

2. acting in a right and fair way toward other people. Peaceful people who promote peace will reap justice in return.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

good acts/behavior

right deeds

goodness (GNT)

See righteous, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

James 4:1

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:1–3

In this paragraph, James discussed why Christian people quarrel with each other. He introduced this topic by means of a rhetorical question (4:1a). He then responded to his question, using another rhetorical question (4:1b). Christians quarrel because they selfishly desire things. In 4:2–3 he explained the answer in more detail.

4:1a

What causes conflicts and quarrels among you?

- ¶ Where do all the fights and quarrels among you come from? (GNT)
- ¶ What causes you^(plur) to have conflicts with one another?
- ¶ Think^(plur) about why you believers argue and fight with one another so much/often.

What causes conflicts and quarrels among you?:

This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to introduce a new topic. He wanted his readers to think about what was causing people in the church to quarrel and fight with one another.

Some ways to introduce this new topic are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Where do all the fights and quarrels among you come from? (GNT)

- As a command/imperative form to draw the readers' attention to the new topic. For example:

Now consider what causes you^(plur) to fight...

Think about why you^(plur) fight....

- As a statement expressing James' wish. For example:

I want you^(plur) to think about why you fight.

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this new topic.

What causes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as What causes is more literally "From where." For example:

Where do the conflicts and where do the quarrels among you come from? (NET)

The conflicts and quarrels come from inside people. So in some languages, it is more natural to say:

What causes...

Why do you fight and argue with each other? (CEV)

conflicts and quarrels: The Greek words that the BSB translates as conflicts and quarrels refer to serious conflicts. These words can refer to both physical fighting and verbal arguments.

Some other ways to translate these words are:

fights and arguments (NCV)

conflicts and disputes (NRSV)

Notice the plural forms. This shows that these conflicts were happening frequently. James was not thinking of just one problem.

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate these nouns as verbs. For example:

you fight and quarrel so often

The words conflicts and quarrels are a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. In some languages, both words can be translated by one word. For example:

Where do your frequent conflicts come from?

among you: The phrase among you indicates that James was talking about quarrels and disputes among Christian people.

4:1b–c

Don't they come from the passions at war within you?: This is a rhetorical question. It is a response to the rhetorical question in 4:1a. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that the fights and quarrels came from people's evil desires.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't they come from the evil desires at war within you? (NLT)

They come from your^(plur) desires that battle within you, right?

- As a statement. For example:

They come from the selfish desires that war within you. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

James was not informing his readers of something they did not know. He was reminding them of something they already knew.

4:1b

Don't they come from the passions

- They come from your^(plur) selfish desires
- Your^(plur) own evil/selfish desires cause these situations.
- It is because each of you^(plur) desires/wants many different things for only yourselves

they: The pronoun they refers to the “fights and quarrels” in 4:1a.

come from: Use a verb that corresponds with the verb in 4:1a. For example, if you used the verb “come from” in 4:1a, you can use come from here. If you used the verb “causes” in 4:1a, you may want to use “caused” here. For example:

Aren't they caused by...? (GW)

the passions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as passions here refers to wrong, selfish desires. These passions are desires for personal wealth, glory, and pleasure. Mitton, page 146. See also Alford, page 311. James was perhaps particularly thinking of the desire of some people to be powerful and popular and to have authority. Martin, page 145. Huther, page 174, thinks of the pursuit of earthly riches in particular. The Greek word *ἡδονή* can in some contexts refer to the pursuit of physical and sensual pleasures, but the context in James does not support that reference.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

selfish desires (GW)

desires for pleasure (GNT)

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the phrase the passions with a clause. For example:

you^(plur) selfishly desire to have

you^(plur) really want

4:1c

at war within you?

- that are fighting inside you^(plur), right?
- They are struggling inside your^(plur) hearts/spirits against what you should want.
- that are opposite/contrary to the good that you^(plur) should want.

at war within you: The clause at war within you refers to your desires “which are constantly fighting within you.” (GNT)

This clause is a figure of speech called personification. The word “passions” in 4:1b is the subject of the word war. It is as if the “passions” were people who could fight.

There are at least two ways to translate this personification:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

that fight to control you (GW)

- Translate the meaning of the figure. For example:

that are opposed/contrary to what you should want

that are against your desire to do good

The text does not state against whom or against what the desires of the person are fighting. There are basically three interpretations:

1. The desires in a person are fighting a war against his conscience or his soul. The struggle is inside him. Interpretation (1) is supported by Mayor, page 129; Adamson (1976), page 166; Hiebert, page 244; Davids (1982), page 157; Moo (1985), page 139.
2. The desires in a person are fighting a war against other people as he tries to do what pleases God and not what pleases them. Interpretation (2) is supported by Alford, page 312; Huther, page 127; Ropes, page 253; Martin, page 140.
3. The different desires in a person are fighting a war with each other inside the person. Interpretation (3) is supported by JBP and by Laws, page 168.

English versions do not say whom the desires are fighting. If you must be specific, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

within you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as within you can also be translated as:

inside you (NET)

in your^(plur) hearts

in your^(plur) souls/spirits

James 4:2

Section 4:1-12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:1-3

In this paragraph, James discussed why Christian people quarrel with each other. He introduced this topic by means of a rhetorical question (4:1a). He then responded to his question, using another rhetorical question (4:1b). Christians quarrel because they selfishly desire things. In 4:2-3 he explained the answer in more detail.

4:2a-f

Scholars disagree over how to punctuate this verse. The problem centers on how the word “kill/murder” is connected to the rest of the verse. The two interpretations are:

1. The verb “kill/murder” is primarily connected to what comes before it. So it should be separated from what follows by strong punctuation, such as a full stop. Ropes, page 254; Mitton, page 147; Laws, page 169; Hiebert, page 245; Moo (1985), page 140. Mayor, page 130-131, would accept this, but he prefers to emend (i.e., reconstruct) the text. See also Blass-Debrunner-Funk, A Greek Grammar of the NT, §494, and the margin of Westcott & Hort's Greek text. For example, the ESV says:

You desire and do not have, so you murder. You covet and cannot obtain, so you fight and quarrel. (NIV11, RSV, GNT, REB, CEV, NASB, NJB, GW, NLT, ESV)

1. The verb “kill/murder” is primarily related to what comes after it. Alford, page 312; Huther, page 176; Adamson (1976), page 167-168; Davids (1982), page 158; Martin, page 140-141. It is also the punctuation of Westcott & Hort in the text, and of the UBS Greek New Testament. So there should be punctuation separating it from what comes before it. For example, the NET says:

You desire and you do not have; you murder and envy and you cannot obtain; you quarrel and fight. (BSB, NIV84, NET, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation that the majority of English versions follow.

See the General Comment on 4:2a-f at the end of 4:2f for examples of how this verse can be reordered.

4:2a You crave

- You want something (NIV)
- You^(plur) want/desire things,

You crave: The Greek word that the BSB translates as You crave is literally “You want/desire.” James did not say what his readers wanted or desired. In some languages, it may be more natural to supply an object, as the BSB has done. For example:

You want something (CEV)

You want things (NCV)

You want what you don’t have (NLT)

4:2b

what you do not have;

- but don’t get it (NIV)
- but you^(plur) do not have them,

what you do not have: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as what here introduces a contrast that many versions translate as “but.” The contrast is between what people want and what they actually have. For example:

you want something but don’t get it (NIV)

you do not have: The Greek verb that the BSB translates literally as you do not have indicates that the believers were not receiving the thing or things that they wanted.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

don’t have (CEV)

you do not have them (NCV)

4:2c

you kill

- so you^(plur) murder.
- so you^(plur) are ready to kill. (GNT)

you kill: The clause you kill is a result of not having what you want. In some languages, it is more natural to make the relation between 4:2b and 4:2c clear by supplying a conjunction. For example:

^{2a}You want ^{2b}what you don’t have, ^{2c}so you commit murder. (GW)

kill: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as kill normally means “murder” (as in 2:11a–b). Here it is probably a hyperbole. James used this word to startle his readers. He warned them that if they were not careful, their bad desires would soon lead to actual murder. Ropes, page 255; Laws, page 172. It is unlikely that James’ readers were actually killing one another. If they had been killing one another, he would have written more to criticize them even more harshly.

Some ways to translate this word are:

- Translate it literally. For example:

you murder (ESV) If you translate it literally, it may be good to add a footnote saying that this is an exaggeration.

- Translate it in a way that shows that cases of murder had not actually occurred. For example:

you are ready to kill (GNT)

4:2d

and covet,

- You^(plur) strongly desire something that someone else has,
- You^(plur) are envious of the things of others,

covet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as covet means “desire to possess something that someone else has.” This could be a material possession (like a big house) or a special honor or position of authority. Some translations understand the Greek verb here to mean “to envy, be jealous of [someone]” (NASB, REB, NLT, NET). This is also a valid possibility, but it does not fit so well with the next verb, “you cannot have,” which implies the object is a thing, not a person.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

you^(plur) want what someone else has

you strongly desire things (GNT)

You are jealous of what others have (NLT)

4:2e

but are unable to obtain it.

- but you^(plur) are not able to obtain it.
- but you^(plur) do not succeed in getting these things.

but are unable to obtain it: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as are unable to obtain it is more literally “you are not able to obtain.” This clause indicates that the believers were unable to get the thing or things that they were coveting. As in 4:2b, it may be natural to supply an object. For example:

cannot obtain it (NRSV)

you cannot get them (GNT)

you^(plur) are not able to get what you want

4:2f

You quarrel and fight.

- You^(plur) argue and fight with one another.
- So you^(plur) fight with each other.

You quarrel and fight: The clause You quarrel and fight is the result of not obtaining what you want. In some languages, it is more natural to make this relationship between 4:2e and 4:2f clear by supplying a conjunction. For example:

^{2e}but you cannot get them, ^{2f}so you quarrel and fight (GNT)

quarrel and fight: The verbs quarrel and fight are related to the nouns “fights and quarrels” in 4:1a. So the translations of them should correspond if possible. Try to use words that can include both verbal disputes and physical fighting.

Another way to translate these verbs is:

argue and fight (NCV)

The verbs quarrel and fight are a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. In some languages, the two verbs can be translated by a single verb. For example:

^{2e}you cannot have what you want, ^{2f}so you fight with each other.

General Comment on 4:2a–f

Verse 4:2a–f is made up of two sentences. Each sentence tells what the people want and how they react when they do not get what they want. In some languages, it is more natural to first tell how people react and then the reason that they react that way. For example:

^{2c}You kill each other ^{2b}because you do not have ^{2a}what you crave. ^{2f}You quarrel and fight each other ^{2e}because you are unable to obtain ^{2d}what you covet.

4:2g

You do not have,

- You^(plur) do not have what you want,
- You^(plur) do not have the things you want,

You do not have: Here James left some words implicit. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply this implicit information. For example:

You don’t have the things you want (GW)

You do not have what you want (GNT)

4:2h

because you do not ask.

- because you^(plur) do not ask God for it.
- because you^(plur) don’t pray for them. (GW)

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that people do not get what they desire.

you do not ask: Although the BSB translates this clause literally, many English versions supply the word God to make clear whom the people did not ask.

This clause refers to praying to God. For example:

because you don’t pray for them. (GW)

General Comment on 4:2g–h

Verse 4:2g–h gives the reason that people do not get what they want. In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{2h}You do not ask God for what you want, ^{2g}so/therefore you do not have what you want.

This is a general statement about a situation that frequently happened. It does not mean, however, that James’ readers never asked God for things. This is made clear in 2:3.

James 4:3

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified

the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:1-3

In this paragraph, James discussed why Christian people quarrel with each other. He introduced this topic by means of a rhetorical question (4:1a). He then responded to his question, using another rhetorical question (4:1b). Christians quarrel because they selfishly desire things. In 4:2-3 he explained the answer in more detail.

4:3a

And when you do ask,

- When you^(plur) ask God for something,
- When you pray for things, (GW)

4:3b

you do not receive,

- you^(plur) do not receive it from God,
- you don't get them (GW)

4:3a-b

And when you do ask, you do not receive: The clause And when you do ask, you do not receive refers to prayer. James' readers were praying to God for certain things, but God was not answering their prayers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

And even when you ask, you don't get it (NLT)

When you pray for things, you don't get them (GW)

Yet even when you do pray, your prayers are not answered (CEV)

4:3c

because you ask with wrong motives,

- because you^(plur) are asking for the wrong reasons.
- because the reason why you^(plur) pray, it is not right.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that people do not get what they pray for.

you ask with wrong motives: The clause you ask with wrong motives is more literally "you ask wrongly" (as

in the RSV). This indicates that James' readers were asking for things from God for the wrong reasons. They were asking for things for selfish reasons rather than for God's glory.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the reason you ask is wrong (NCV)

the reason why you^(plur) ask is not right

you pray just for selfish reasons (CEV)

4:3d

that you may squander it on your pleasures.

- You^(plur) want to use these things only for your own evil desires.
- You^(plur) pray for things just so that you can satisfy your own passions.

that you may squander it on your pleasures: The clause that you may squander it on your pleasures means that James' readers intended to use what they prayed for to satisfy their own desires.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You want things so you can use them for your own pleasures. (NCV)

The reason you^(plur) ask for it is so that you might fulfill your evil desires.

squander: The Greek word that the BSB translates as squander means "use wastefully." It does not only refer to spending money, although wasting money is one aspect.

Another way to translate this word is:

use (GNT)

pleasures: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pleasures is the same as the word translated "passions" in 4:1b. This word refers to wrong, selfish desires. It is a desire for personal wealth, glory, and pleasure.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

passions (RSV)

selfish desires

enjoyment

satisfy your heart

General Comment on 4:3a–d

In some languages, it is more natural to put the reason (in 4:3c–d) before the result (in 4:3a–b). For example:

^{3c}You ask with wrong motives ^{3d}that you may spend what you get on your pleasures.

^{3b}Therefore, you do not receive ^{3a}what you ask for.

General Comment on 4:3b–d

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 4:3b–d. For example:

^{3b}you do not receive, ^{3c}because you ask for things

^{3d}so that you can spend/use what you get on your pleasures. ^{3c}That is the wrong reason for praying!

James 4:4

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:4–6

James said that to love the world's evil way is to hate God. God is angry with people who do this.

4:4a

You adulteresses!

- ¶ You^(plur) are adulteresses!
- ¶ You^(plur) are like wives who are immoral.
- ¶ You people aren't faithful to God! (CEV)

You adulteresses!: The KJV translation "Ye adulterers and adulteresses" follows a different Greek text, but the meaning is also metaphorical. The Greek word that the BSB translates as You adulteresses is literally

"adulteresses." This word is feminine and often refers to women who are unfaithful to their husbands. Here this word is a metaphor. In this metaphor, James was rebuking some of his readers by comparing them (both men and women) to women who had committed adultery.

One way that they are similar is that they were not loyal.

Some of James' readers had not been loyal to God. They had promised that they would follow God, just as a bride promises to stay with her husband. But they had been unfaithful to him like adulterous women are unfaithful to their husbands. So James rebuked them by calling them adulteresses. (This same word is also used metaphorically in Matthew 12:39 and Mark 8:38.)

There are several ways to translate this figure of speech here:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Adulterers! (NRSV)

You are adulterous people!

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You are like unfaithful wives (JBP)

You are like married women who are immoral

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

You unfaithful people! (GW)

you are not loyal to God! (NCV)

Make sure your translation is acceptable for public reading in church.

In some translations, it may be helpful to include a footnote to further explain the metaphor of adulteresses. An example for such a footnote is:

The word "adulteresses" here comes from a common Old Testament metaphor that describes God as the husband and his people as his wife. When God's people were unfaithful to him by worshipping idols, they are described as "adulteresses"

and “prostitutes.” See Jeremiah chapter 3; 13:27 and Isaiah 54:5–7; 57:3.

4:4b–c

Do you not know that friendship with the world is hostility toward God?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to express emphasis. He wanted to emphasize that friendship with the world is hatred toward God.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you know that to be the world’s friend means to be God’s enemy? (GNT)

Friendship with the world is hatred toward God. You know that, don’t you?

- As a statement. For example:

You should know that loving the world is the same as hating God. (NCV)

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

4:4b

Do you not know that friendship with the world

- Do you^(plur) not know that friendship with the evil world
- You^(plur) know, do you not, that if you befriend/love the ways of this evil world,
- You^(plur) should know that if you love the evil pleasures/desires of the people of this world,

friendship with the world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as friendship may also be translated as “love” or “affection.”

The Greek word that the BSB translates as world here refers to evil ways of thinking and acting. These evil ways of thinking and acting are the characteristics of people who are opposed to God and his ways.

So friendship with the world means “having a love/preference for the evil ways of the people of this world.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

love for this evil world (GW)

if you love the world (CEV)

following the evil pleasures/ways of this world

preferring the ways of the ungodly people in this world

wanting to do whatever God hates

The word world also occurs with a similar meaning in 1:27c.

4:4c

is hostility toward God?

- means that you^(plur) hate God?
- you^(plur) are an enemy of God?
- you^(plur) are against God.

is hostility toward God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as hostility toward God refers to a state of hating God. It is being opposed to God. It is the opposite of “friendship” (4:4b).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

you are God’s enemies (CEV)

means to be God’s enemy (GNT)

is the same as hating God (NCV)

4:4d

Therefore, whoever chooses to be a friend of the world

- Therefore, the person who decides to be a friend of this evil world
- So, whoever wants to be a friend of the ways of this evil world
- So, if you^(plur) choose/decide to love worldly pleasures/desires,

Therefore: The Greek word that BSB translates literally as Therefore is a conjunction that introduces 4:4d. This conjunction indicates that 4:4d–e is the logical conclusion to the points James has just presented in 4:4b–c. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

So (NET)

whoever chooses: The phrase whoever chooses can also be translated as:

whoever chooses

the person who chooses

This phrase does not refer to any person in particular. In some languages, a plural subject may be more appropriate than a singular. It is also possible to use the second person. For example:

All the people who choose

And if you decide (CEV)

chooses: The Greek word that the BSB translates as chooses means “deliberately decides” to live that way. Some other ways to translate this word are:

decide (CEV)

want (GNT)

to be a friend of the world: The phrase to be a friend of the world refers to “living the way that the world wants,” or “pleasing the people of the world.” (The people of the world are people who do not love God.)

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to be a friend of this evil world

to be a friend of the ways of this evil world

to love all the evil pleasures of this world

This phrase is similar in meaning to “friendship with the world” in 4:4b.

4:4e

renders himself an enemy of God.

- makes himself an enemy of God.
- becomes God’s enemy.
- you^(plur) make yourself God’s enemy. (GNT)

renders himself an enemy of God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as renders himself can also be translated as “makes himself” (as in the RSV). In other words, if a person decides that he will be a friend of the world, this decision automatically causes him to be God’s enemy. God does not have or want friendship with the world.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

makes himself God’s enemy (NET)

you make yourself God’s enemy (GNT)

an enemy of God: An enemy of God is a person whom God is against.

James 4:5

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God’s enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:4–6

James said that to love the world’s evil way is to hate God. God is angry with people who do this.

4:5a–c

Or do you think the Scripture says without reason that the Spirit He caused to dwell in us yearns with envy?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to emphasize that his readers should not think that the Scripture says things without reason. In this rhetorical question, James used scripture to support his statement in 4:4. That statement is that friendship with the world cannot exist together with friendship with God.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Or do you suppose it is to no purpose that the Scripture says, “He yearns jealously over the spirit that he has made to dwell in us”? (ESV)

^{5b}The scripture says, ^{5c}“He yearns jealously over the spirit which he has made to dwell in us.” ^{5a}Do you^(plur) think that ^{5b}the scripture says that without reason?

- As a statement. For example:

You^(plur) must not think that there is no truth in the scripture that says that God jealously desires the spirit that he placed in us.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

4:5a

Or do you think

- Moreover, do you^(plur) think that
- You^(plur) should not think that

Or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Or often occurs before a rhetorical question. It implies that the following sentence will support James' statement in 4:4. Here this word is not used to indicate a choice between two options. It is perhaps for that reason that some English versions omit this word.

do you think: The clause do you think introduces a rhetorical question. It implies that the reader should not think that way. One way to translate this clause is to make the entire sentence a statement. For example:

you should certainly not think

Consider what form of question or statement will translate this naturally in your language.

4:5b

the Scripture says without reason

- God's word/message has no purpose when it says
- what God says in his book means nothing when he says

the Scripture says: In the clause the Scripture says, the word Scripture is personified. This means that Scripture is spoken of as if it were a person that says things. In some languages, it may be necessary to say that it is God who says these things. For example:

in Scripture, God says

God said in his book

it is written in God's word

Usually in the New Testament, the words the Scripture says introduce a direct quote from the Old Testament. But here, the sentence that these words introduce does not match any Old Testament sentence very closely. Many commentators Alford, page 314; Mayor, page 136; Mitton, page 154; Moo (1985), page 146; Martin, page 149. suggest that 4:5c is a summary of Old Testament teaching. Alternatively, some commentators (Laws, page 174; Hiebert, page 254) and versions (Revised Version (1881): "Or think ye that the scripture speaketh in vain? Doth the spirit...?" and JBP: "Or do

you think what the Scriptures have to say about this is a mere formality? Do you imagine that this spirit...?" take the verse as two separate sentences. In this case the words "the scripture" might refer back to 3:4 or forward to the rest of 3:5. However, it is more natural to take the Greek words translated Scripture says as simply introducing what Scripture says. For this reason punctuating as one sentence, as in BSB, is recommended. They say that it is not a quotation of the exact words of a verse in the Old Testament. There are similar cases in John 7:38 and John 7:42. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

scripture teaches

in scripture God teaches

The word Scripture also occurs in 2:8b.

without reason: The Greek word that the BSB translates as without reason means "for no purpose" or "in vain." James used this word to indicate that the words of Scripture that follow are not useless or worthless words. They are true.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

in vain (RSV)

for nothing (NRSV)

to no purpose (ESV)

no truth (GNT)

4:5c

that the Spirit He caused to dwell in us yearns with envy?

- that he jealously desires the spirit that he gave us?^(incl)
- God created our^(incl) spirit. So, he strongly desires us^(incl) to only love/worship him like a jealous husband wants his wife to love only him.
- God put a soul into man to give him life. Because of that, he strongly desires that we^(incl) be only his.

the Spirit He caused to dwell in us yearns with envy:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the Spirit He caused to dwell in us is ambiguous. In Greek, it is unclear whether:

1. the spirit refers to the human spirit or the Holy Spirit

2. the spirit is the subject or the object of the verb that the BSB translates as yearns with envy

The main ways to interpret the phrase the Spirit are:

1. It refers to the human spirit and is the object of the verb. According to this interpretation, God has strong feelings of jealousy for us. God will not tolerate his people loving the world. He wants their total loyalty. According to this interpretation, this verse is connected with 4:4. It is a metaphor of God as the jealous husband who has an adulterous wife. For example, the RSV says:

He yearns jealously over the spirit which he has made to dwell in us. (NIV11, RSV, ESV) Although only a few English versions follow the recommended interpretation, many commentaries support this interpretation. Some that do are: Huther, pages 181-183; Ropes, pages 262-264; Mitton, pages 154-156; Davids (1982), page 164 (reluctantly); Moo (1985), pages 144-146; Tasker, page 90; Dibelius, page 224. See also C. Spicq, *Theological Lexicon of the N.T.*, Vol. 2 page 59, and Vol. 3 page 434; also Spicq's earlier article in French "Epiphothein, Désirer ou chérir", *Revue Biblique*, 1957, pages 184-195, especially 189-191.

1. It refers to the human spirit and is the subject of the verb. According to this interpretation, the human spirit that God made to live in us has strong envious desires. Adamson (1976), pages 171-173; see also Adamson (1989), pages 330-333. Laws, page 178, takes it as a rhetorical question: "Does the spirit which he made to dwell in us long enviously?" with the implied answer that according to Scripture it does not, it longs for God. According to this interpretation, this verse is connected with 4:1-3. It continues to describe the evil desires that are in humans. For example, the NLT says:

the spirit God has placed within us is filled with envy (NIV84, GNT, NET, REB, KJV, NLT)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit and is the subject of the verb. According to this interpretation, the Holy Spirit that God sent to live in us his people feels strongly possessive of us. Alford, page 315; Mayor, page 137; Hiebert, pages 255-257; Martin, pages 149-150. Also R. Buth, *START 2*, pages 11-12. For example, the NCV says:

The Spirit that God made to live in us wants us for himself alone (BSB, GW, NLT96, NCV)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit and is the object of the verb. According to this interpretation, God cares strongly about the Holy Spirit. For example, the CEV says:

God truly cares about the Spirit he has put in us (CEV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation:

1. works well grammatically. God is the subject of:

- 4:5c he caused to dwell in us
 - 4:6a he gives more grace So it is natural that God is also the subject of the verb envies intensely.
1. fits well with James' appeal for Christians to turn away from friendship with the world. We must not be friends with the world because:
 - if we are friends with the world, we are enemies with God.
 - God jealously desires us for himself. He does not want us to be like an adulterous wife.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God jealously desires for himself the spirit that he placed in us.

God put the spirit into man to give him life. Because of that, he is jealous of what we do with our lives.

This word also occurs in 2:26a.

yearns with envy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as yearns with envy is literally "desires with jealousy." Here it describes God as a jealous God who desires that we belong to him alone. (Exodus 20:5 says, "I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God.") Be sure that the way you translate this phrase is an appropriate way to speak about a perfect God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

he jealously desires

God strongly desires that this spirit must submit to him alone.

he wants us to love/worship only him like a jealous husband wants his wife to love only him.

James 4:6

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:4–6

James said that to love the world's evil way is to hate God. God is angry with people who do this.

4:6a

But He gives us more grace.

- But God is very merciful/kind to us.^(incl)
- But God treats us^(incl) very kindly/favorably.

But He gives us more grace: Most commentators agree that the words But He gives us more grace are the words of James. They are not an additional part of the scripture that James mentioned in 4:5c. Note that although the 1973 and 1978 editions of NIV included these words as part of the quotation, the 1984 edition finishes the quotation at the end of 4:5 like all other major English versions.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a mild contrast. The contrast is between our unfaithfulness (4:4) and God's grace. The contrast is also between God's high standard (4:5) and his grace.

He gives us more grace: The expression gives... more grace translates a Hebrew idiom meaning "treat someone very favorably and kindly". Here more grace means "very much grace." God's grace is completely adequate to meet his requirements. Ropes, page 265; Laws, page 180; Moo (1985), pages 146–147; Martin, page 151. In NT Greek the comparative form of an adjective is quite often used in an elative sense, where no direct comparison is intended. The translation in this case would be "very much."

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he treats us very kindly

he acts towards us in a favorable/merciful way

he is very kind to us

He: The pronoun He refers to God.

us: The pronoun us is inclusive: that is, all believers, including both James and his readers.

4:6b

This is why it says:

- Just as God's word/message says,
- It is just as God says in his book/word,

This is why it says: The Greek word that the BSB translates as This is why indicates that what follows supports James' statement in 4:6a. That statement is that God gives grace.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

As the scripture says (GNT)

just as the Scriptures say (CEV)

Scripture says (GW)

it says: The pronoun it here refers to Scripture. Since Scripture does not itself literally speak, in some languages it may be better to say:

God says in the Scriptures

God says in his written word

Here it refers to one verse from Scripture in particular, Proverbs 3:34. This verse is quoted in 4:6c and 4:6d.

4:6c

"God opposes the proud,

- "God opposes/resists proud people,
- "God is against arrogant people,

God opposes the proud: The clause God opposes the proud means that God "resists" or "is against" proud people. Notice the present tense of the verb. This indicates that God always has this attitude.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God opposes arrogant people (GW)

God resists the proud (GNT)

God is against the proud (NCV)

the proud: The word proud describes people who think they are more important and better than other people. In this context, they are people who think that they do not need the grace of God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

people who think that they are important

those who think they are better than other people

people who are not humble

Many languages have idioms for such people.

4:6d

but gives grace to the humble.”

- but he is merciful/kind to humble people.”
- but he treats kindly/favorably those who are meek/modest.”

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast. The contrast is between how God acts towards the proud (4:6c) and how he acts towards the humble (4:6d).

gives grace: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gives grace translates a Hebrew idiom. It means “treats someone favorably and kindly.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

he is kind (CEV)

he shows favor (NLT96)

This phrase also occurs in 4:6a.

the humble: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the humble refers to people who are meek and modest. They know that they need God’s help. They depend on God and not on themselves. They are the opposite of “the proud” people in 4:6c.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

meek/modest people

people who do not think that they are very important

This Greek word also occurs in 1:9a, but the sense is not quite the same. There the focus was on a person’s lowly social or financial situation. Here the focus is on how a person thinks of himself.

James 4:7

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God’s enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:7–10

In this paragraph, James gave a series of exhortations or commands on how to get back into a proper relationship with God. He said that his readers should turn back to God and submit to him.

The exhortations in this paragraph are all plural. They are general and are addressed to everyone to whom James was writing.

4:7a

Submit yourselves, then, to God.

- ¶! So place yourselves under God’s authority. (GW)
- ¶! Therefore, obey^(plur) God and do what he wants you to do.

Submit yourselves, then, to God: The clause Submit yourselves...to God means “Put yourselves under God’s control,” “Accept God’s authority,” or “Surrender to God.” For example:

Surrender to God! (CEV)

place yourselves under God’s authority (GW)

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then introduces a new paragraph. In this new paragraph, James gave many exhortations (or commands). These exhortations are based on all that James said in this chapter up to this point.

Some other ways to introduce these exhortations are:

So then (GNT)

therefore (RSV)

In many languages, this conjunction should come at the beginning of the sentence.

4:7b–c

In Greek, 4:7b–c begins with the conjunction that indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what we should do for God and what we should do in regard to Satan. One way to translate this contrast is:

But resist the devil (NET)

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here.

4:7b

Resist the devil,

- Stand^(plur) against the devil,
- Fight^(plur) the devil,
- But refuse^(plur) to do what the devil wants you to do,

Resist: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Resist means “Oppose” or “Stand firmly against” the enemy. This means that we should not listen to or yield to the devil’s temptations. Resist is the opposite of “submit.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Oppose

Do not obey

Refuse to do what the devil wants you to do

Fight

the devil: The phrase the devil refers to Satan, the leader of the evil spirits. You may already have a word in your language that describes the supreme evil being. If not, some other ways to translate this word are:

Satan

the leader/chief of the demons

the supremely bad/evil one

the enemy of God

4:7c

and he will flee from you.

- and he will run away from you.^(plur)
- and if you^(plur) do this, he will quickly leave you.
- and he will soon stop tempting you.^(plur)

he will flee from you: The clause he will flee from you is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Satan is compared to a human enemy. They are similar in that both will flee if you resist them.

There are at least two ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

he will run away from you (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

he will soon stop tempting you

James 4:8

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God’s enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:7–10

In this paragraph, James gave a series of exhortations or commands on how to get back into a proper relationship with God. He said that his readers should turn back to God and submit to him.

The exhortations in this paragraph are all plural. They are general and are addressed to everyone to whom James was writing.

4:8a

Draw near to God,

- Come/Go^(plur) close to God in your hearts,
- Know^(plur) God better,
- Develop^(plur) a close relationship with God,

Draw near to God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Draw near refers to approaching God in a spiritual sense. It means “Develop a close relationship with God.” It does not mean that we should change our physical location.

Consider how you speak of being in a good relationship with someone. If your readers will not understand the spiritual sense of Draw near, you will have to adjust how you express this idea. For example:

In your hearts come/go near to God

Know God better

4:8b

and He will draw near to you.

- and then he will come close to you.^(plur)
- and he will cause you^(plur) to understand him better.
- and he will reward/help you.^(plur)

and He will draw near to you: The verb draw near is the same verb as in 4:8a. Some languages will use the same verb in both 4:8a and 4:8b. But other languages will use different verbs for “people going near to God” and “God coming near to them.” In any case, this does not mean that God actually changes his physical location. The verbs in 4:8a and 4:8b refer to our spiritual relationship with God.

If you made an adjustment to your translation of “Draw near” in 4:8a, you will also have to make an adjustment here. For example:

and he will reward/help you

4:8c–d

Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you double-minded: This sentence has a grammatical structure called a parallelism. In this parallelism, 4:8c and 4:8d are poetic ways to say the same thing. The similar parts are underlined in the same way:

^c Cleanse your hands, you sinners,

^dand purify your hearts, you double-minded

The phrase Cleanse your hands is similar in meaning to purify your hearts. The phrases you sinners and you double-minded are two ways to talk about the same group of people.

See the General Comment at the end of 4:8d to see examples of how to combine 4:8c–d.

4:8c

Cleanse your hands, you sinners,

- Wash sin off your hands, you^(plur) sinners,
- You sinners, clean sin out of your lives. (NCV)
- You^(plur) who are sinners, remove sin from your lives.

Cleanse your hands: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as Cleanse your hands is a figure of speech. It is not a literal command to get some water and use it to clean their hands.

There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

Cleanse your hands (NET)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Clean up your lives. (CEV)

clean sin out of your lives (NCV)

Whichever way you translate this phrase, it is good to put the other option in a footnote.

you sinners: The phrase you sinners functions as a strong rebuke. It also strengthens James’ command about washing hands.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

You are sinners!

Realize that you have sinned. (JBP)

because you are sinners

and stop sinning

Notice that the BSB places the phrase you sinners at the end of 4:8c. This follows the word order in the Greek text. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning of 4:8c.

sinners: The word sinners refers to people who habitually offend God by doing what is contrary to his law. The ways people may offend God include doing and thinking things that God does not approve. People may also offend God by their attitudes and by not doing

what God wants them to do. Some ways to translate sinners are:

people who sin

people who do not obey God

wrongdoers

See also the note on “sin” at 1:15b.

4:8d and purify your hearts, you double-minded.

- and clean sin from your hearts, you^(plur) who want to go two ways at once.
- You who are trying to follow God and the world at the same time, make your thinking pure. (NCV)
- You^(plur) who have minds/hearts that are divided between pleasing God and pleasing yourselves, remove sin from there.

purify your hearts: The phrase purify your hearts is a metaphor. In this metaphor, removing sin from our lives is compared to purifying our hearts. The way that the two actions are similar is that something bad is removed.

In both Hebrew and Greek, the heart refers to a person’s thoughts and desires. So to purify one’s heart means to remove evil thoughts and desires.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

make your hearts pure (NET) In some cultures, an organ other than the heart may be used to describe the part of the person where thoughts and desires come from. For example:

Make your liver pure/good

- Translate the meaning without using a metaphor. For example:

make your thinking pure (NCV)

you double-minded: The Greek word that the BSB translates as double-minded functions as a strong rebuke. It refers to people who seem to have two minds or hearts that are fighting each other. One mind wants to please God. The other mind wants to please the world, and so it is fighting God. If your language has an idiom for this term, consider using it here.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

you people who can’t make up your mind (CEV)

You who are trying to follow God and the world at the same time (NCV)

because you are thinking two ways

and stop trying to follow both sin and God

Notice that the BSB places the phrase you double-minded at the end of 4:8d. This follows the word order in the Greek text. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning of 4:8d.

This same word occurs in 1:8a.

General Comment on 4:8c–d

The parallel parts of 4:8c and 4:8d should be understood as repeating the same thought. So you sinners and you double-minded should not be understood as separate categories of people. If a parallel structure in your language wrongly implies different groups, you may need to combine the parallel parts in these lines. For example:

You^(plur) sinful people who are thinking two ways, clean your hands and your hearts.

You people who want to please both the world and God, remove evil thoughts and evil actions from your lives.

James 4:9

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God’s enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:7–10

In this paragraph, James gave a series of exhortations or commands on how to get back into a proper relationship with God. He said that his readers should turn back to God and submit to him.

The exhortations in this paragraph are all plural. They are general and are addressed to everyone to whom James was writing.

4:9a

Grieve, mourn, and weep.

- Be^(plur) very sad/sorrowful. Mourn/Cry and shed tears.
- Be very sorry and cry because of your^(plur) sins.

Grieve, mourn, and weep: The three verbs Grieve, mourn, and weep refer to the same act and attitude and all mean approximately the same thing. James used these three verbs to emphasize to his readers that they should be very sad because of their sin. In some languages, it is more natural to show this emphasis with one or two verbs plus an intensifier. For example:

Really be sad and cry over your^(plur) sins

Be very sorry that you^(plur) have sinned

Grieve: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grieve refers to expressing inner sorrow. James wanted his readers to be sorry and sad because of their sin.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Be sorrowful (GNT)

Be sad (CEV)

mourn: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mourn refers to a severe form of grief or sadness that results in crying. Some other ways to translate this word are:

cry (GNT)

be sorry

weep: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weep means to cry. For example:

wail (NIV)

cry (GW)

4:9b

Turn your laughter to mourning,

- Instead of laughing, you^(plur) should start mourning/crying,
- Stop laughing and start crying. (CEV)

Turn your laughter to mourning: The word laughter refers here to the foolish laughter of people who are following the ways of the world. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Replace your laughter with crying

Let your laughter become crying

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate both laughter and mourning as verbs. For example:

Stop laughing and start crying. (CEV)

mourning: The word mourning is the same Greek word that is translated as “mourn” in 4:9a.

4:9c

and your joy to gloom.

- and instead of being joyful/cheerful, you^(plur) should be sad.
- Stop being happy, and start being sorry for your^(plur) sins.

and your joy to gloom: Here James left a word implicit. In some languages, it may be necessary to supply this implicit information. For example:

and change your joy to gloom

This clause is parallel to the one in 4:9b. That one referred to the noises that people make (“laughter”, “mourning”). This clause seems to refer to the expressions on their faces. Another way to translate this clause is:

and your joy into sadness (NCV)

In some languages, it will be more natural to translate joy and gloom as verbs. For example:

Be gloomy instead of glad. (CEV)

joy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as joy refers to a state of being cheerful and happy.

gloom: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gloom means sadness (as in the NCV). Your language may have an idiom describing someone who goes around with a gloomy, sad face.

General Comment on 4:9a–c

In 4:9a–c, James tells his readers three times that they should mourn because of their sin. He does this for emphasis. In some languages, it is more natural to show this emphasis in another way. For example:

Stop laughing and being so happy. Become deeply sorry and cry that you have sinned.

James 4:10

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:7–10

In this paragraph, James gave a series of exhortations or commands on how to get back into a proper relationship with God. He said that his readers should turn back to God and submit to him.

The exhortations in this paragraph are all plural. They are general and are addressed to everyone to whom James was writing.

4:10a

Humble yourselves before the Lord,

- Be humble in the Lord's presence, (CEV)
- Submit yourselves to the Lord God,

Humble yourselves before the Lord: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Humble yourselves is a command that literally means "Make yourselves low." Here it refers to making our attitudes low. It means "Submit yourselves" to the authority and greatness of God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Be humble in the Lord's presence (CEV)

Don't be too proud in the Lord's presence (NCV)

This verb is related to the adjective humble in 4:6d.

before the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as before the Lord can also be translated as:

to the Lord

in front of the Lord

the Lord: The word Lord also occurs in 3:9a. See the Note there for translation advice. See also Lord in the Glossary.

4:10b

and He will exalt you.

- and he will lift you up in honor. (NLT)
- and he will honor you. (CEV)

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces what God will do if and when people obey the command in the previous verse. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

Then (GW)

He will exalt you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as He will exalt you contrasts with "humble yourselves" in 4:10a. James meant that God would honor this person and make this person truly great.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

he will lift you up in honor (NLT)

he will honor you (CEV)

he will give you a high position (GW)

James did not say when God will do this. If you must be specific, it is best to translate this in a way that includes both this life and the future life.

James 4:11

Section 4:1–12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified

the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God's enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:11–12

In this paragraph, James wrote about not saying cruel words about one's fellow Christians. If a person says cruel words about others, it means he is setting himself up as a judge over them.

4:11a

Brothers, do not slander one another.

- ¶ My brothers, do not speak^(plur) evil of one another.
- ¶ Fellow Christians, do not say^(plur) cruel/false words about one another.
- ¶ Do not criticize one another, my friends. (GNT)

Brothers: James switched from calling his readers “adulterous people” to Brothers. This indicates that he wanted to:

1. introduce a new subject, and
2. show his love for his readers. He did this so that he could more strongly ask them to change their behavior.

The word Brothers means “Fellow believers.” Some other ways to translate this word are:

My friends (CEV)

Brothers and sisters (GW)

This word also occurs in 1:2a and 3:12a–b.

do not slander one another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slander is more literally “speak against.” For example:

Do not speak against one another (NET)

To “speak against” someone means “speak evil of someone” or “say cruel words about someone when he is not present.” It means “criticize someone in order to destroy that person's reputation.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

don't say cruel things about others (CEV)

do not tell evil lies about each other (NCV)

Do not criticize one another (GNT)

4:11b–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 4:11b–e. For example:

^{11b}Anyone who speaks against his brother,
^{11d}speaks against the law. ^{11c}Anyone who judges his brother, ^{11e}judges the law.

^{11b}If anyone speaks against his brother, ^{11d}he speaks against the law. ^{11c}If anyone judges his brother, ^{11e}he judges the law.

4:11b

Anyone who speaks against his brother

- He who speaks evil of a brother
- If any/one of you^(plur) says cruel words about your^(sing) fellow Christian
- If someone does that,

speaks against: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as speaks against is the same verb that is translated as “slander” in 4:11a.

Some ways to translate this verb are:

- Use the same verb as in 4:11a. For example:

^{11a}stop slandering each other. ^{11b}Those who slander (GW)

- Use a synonym: For example:

^{11a}Don't speak evil against each other, my dear brothers and sisters. ^{11b}If you criticize each other (NLT96)

- Use a general verb. For example:

^{11a}My friends, don't say cruel things about others!
^{11b}If you do... (CEV)

his brother: The Greek word that the BSB translates as his brother is literally “brother.” The pronoun his is not in Greek. Some ways to translate this word are:

another Christian (GNT)

a fellow believer (NET)

each other (NLT)

4:11c or judges him

- or harshly accuses him of doing wrong
- and condemns him in a mean/unkind manner,
- or if he says that his brother is not good,

or judges him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as judges means “criticize/ accuse others of doing wrong in a mean or severe manner.” This does not refer to the kind of judging that a judge does in court. Nor does it imply that people are never to judge whether something is right or wrong.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

or if you condemn others (CEV)

or harshly/severely accuses him of doing wrong

or criticizes/rebukes him in a mean/unkind manner

See judge, meaning 2, in the Glossary. The same word and same idea occur in Matthew 7:1.

4:11d speaks against the law

- speaks evil of God’s law
- it is as if you^(sing) are saying cruel things about God’s commands
- he criticizes the law

speaks against the law: The Greek word that the BSB translates as speaks against is the same as the word translated “slander” in 4:11a. Some ways to translate this phrase are:

speaks evil of the law

says evil words against the law

criticizes the law

The law demands that Christians love one another (2:8). If someone criticizes his fellow believer, he is not loving him. So he is not doing what the law demands. When someone does not do what the law says, he communicates by his actions that the law is

not worthy of his respect and obedience. So it is as if he is speaking against the law. You may want to make this clear in your translation. For example:

it is as if he speaks evil of the law

the law: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the law refers to God’s law. In other words, it refers to everything that God has commanded his people to do in their lives.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

God’s Law (CEV)

God’s teachings (GW)

God’s rules

This word also occurs in 1:25a.

4:11e and judges it.

- and accuses it of being wrong.
- and condemning them.
- and says that it is not good, because he has not kept the Scripture that says, “Love your^(sing) neighbor as yourself.”

judges it: The phrase judges it indicates that whenever you judge a brother, it is as if you are judging the law. This means that you are “finding fault” with certain laws and are deciding that you do not have to obey them. Specifically, you are not obeying the law that says that you should love your brother.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

it is as though he judges it

condemning God’s law (NLT96)

acts like the judge of the law

The same Greek word meaning judges occurs in 4:11c. See also judge, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 4:11b–e

In some languages, it may be necessary to make explicit how judging one’s brother is the same as judging the law. For example:

^{11b}Anyone who speaks against his brother ^{11c}or judges him ^{11d}speaks against the law ^{11e}and judges it because he has not kept the Scripture that says, “Love your neighbor as yourself.”

4:11f

And if you judge the law,

- And when you^(sing) accuse the law of being wrong,
- If you^(sing) condemn the law,
- When you^(sing) do that,

And: In Greek, this sentence has a conjunction that commonly indicates a change or contrast. Here James uses it to introduce a further stage in his discussion. One way to translate this conjunction is:

And (CEV)

In some languages, it is natural to use a conjunction here. In other languages, no conjunction is necessary.

if you judge the law: In this verse and the following verse, the pronoun you is singular. By using the singular form, James addresses every person individually, and therefore very forcefully. Consider whether in your language a command spoken to every individual should be in the singular or plural form.

See also judge, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

4:11g

you are not a practitioner of the law,

- you^(sing) are not a doer of the law,
- you^(sing) are not following it,
- you^(sing) are not obeying the law.

you are not a practitioner of the law: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you are not a practitioner of the law literally says “you are not a doer of the law” (as in the RSV). Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

then you are no longer one who obeys the Law (GNT)

you are no longer a follower of the law (NCV)

4:11h

but a judge of it.

- but a judge of it.
- rather, you^(sing) are condemning it as if you were the judge of the law.
- Instead, you^(sing) place yourself above/over the law and decide what part is good and what part is not.

but a judge of it: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as but a judge of it is literally “but a judge.” Being a “judge of the law” contrasts with being a “doer of the law” in 4:11g. A “judge of the law” is someone who has authority over the law. He decides which part of the law is worthy or necessary to obey and which part is not necessary.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

become a judge over it (NJB)

but you are condemning it as if you were its judge

but you are acting as if you have the right to say/choose which laws should be obeyed

See also judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

General Comment on 4:11f-h

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the three clauses of 4:11f-h as two clauses. For example:

But you are not a judge who can decide whether the law is right or wrong. Your job is to obey it. (NLT96)

James 4:12

Section 4:1-12: Believers must submit to God, not to their own selfish desires

In this section, James wrote about the problem of Christians quarreling among themselves. He identified the root of the problem as our human selfish desires. Then he pointed out that the solution is to humble ourselves and submit to God.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning against being God’s enemy (UBS)

Submit Yourselves to God (NIV)

Paragraph 4:11-12

In this paragraph, James wrote about not saying cruel words about one’s fellow Christians. If a person says cruel words about others, it means he is setting himself up as a judge over them.

4:12a

There is only one Lawgiver and Judge,

- There is one giver of and judge of the law.

- But God alone gave/made the law and is the true/ultimate judge of the law and people.
- But it is God who made/wrote the law and judges people. Not you^(sing).

There is only one Lawgiver and Judge: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as There is only one Lawgiver and Judge is more literally “There is one lawgiver and judge” (as in the RSV). The BSB and NIV add the word only to make the meaning clearer in English.

The Greek text does not say explicitly who the Lawgiver and Judge is. But to James’ readers, it was obvious from the rest of the sentence that it is God. In some languages, it may be necessary to mention God explicitly. For example:

God is the only lawgiver and judge. (GNT)

Lawgiver: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lawgiver is a noun. In some languages, it is more natural to translate the word Lawgiver as a clause. For example:

the giver of the law

the one who gave the law

It may also be more natural to use a verb other than “give.” For example:

the one who made the law

God who wrote/commanded laws

God is where the law came from

Judge: Here the word Judge refers to God. He is the ultimate judge. He is the only one who has authority over the law and can be its judge. He is the only one who has authority to judge people concerning their eternal destiny (4:12b). This contrasts with humans, who do not have authority to judge the law, nor to decide the eternal destiny of people. In some languages, it may be good to make this contrast explicit. For example:

true Judge

ultimate Judge of the law and people

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun Judge as a clause. For example:

one who can judge all things

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

4:12b

the One who is able to save

- It is he who is able to save people
- He is the one who can rescue people eternally

the One who is able to save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to save means “to rescue from danger or trouble”. In this context, it refers to God rescuing people from eternal death and punishment.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to free us from punishment

to rescue people

save from eternal death

This word also occurs in 1:21d and 2:14d. See save, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

4:12c

and destroy.

- and to destroy people eternally.
- or punish them.

and destroy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroy refers to eternal ruin and loss. It does not refer to an end of existence. Another way to translate this word is:

to punish us eternally

4:12d

But who are you to judge your neighbor?

- Who do you^(sing) think you are that you can accuse/condemn another person?
- So, why do you^(sing) criticize and judge your fellow person?
- So it is not right for you to judge your neighbor. (NCV)

But who are you to judge your neighbor?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses a rebuke. James used this rhetorical question to rebuke those who were judging their neighbors. He has just stated in 4:12a–

c that judging is God's work. This rhetorical question implies, "You have no right to do that!"

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who do you think you are, to judge someone else?
(GNT)

Why do you^(sing) judge your neighbor?

Do you now think that you are that type of person
that has power to judge his fellow person?

- As a statement. For example:

So it is not right for you to judge your neighbor.
(NCV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

But who are you: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between the word "One" (in 4:12b), that is, God, and you. James emphasized the pronoun you by making it the first word of this sentence and the NIV reflects this emphasis by repeating the word you:

But you—who are you (NIV)

Verse 4:12d is also the conclusion to this paragraph. Another way to connect 4:12d to the rest of the verse is:

So (GW)

judge: The word judge is the same word as in 4:11c. Some ways to translate it are:

- Follow the advice given at 4:11c:

condemn

harshly/severely accuse your neighbor of doing
wrong

criticize/rebuke your neighbor in a mean/unkind
manner See judge, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

- Use your word for the work of a judge:

judge (verb) See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

- Combine both options Both translation options (with the word "judge" or not) probably preserve part of James' logic. 1) Using the word "judge" connects with James' statement that there is only one Judge. God has the authority to judge people; we do not have authority to judge our brother or neighbor. 2) When we judge in the sense of "harshly criticizing" our brother, we fail to keep the command to love our neighbor. We, therefore, judge the law. But there is only one who has authority to judge the law, the one who gave it. We do not have this authority. Therefore, we do not have the right to judge our neighbor. above:

criticize and judge

your neighbor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as neighbor includes anyone that you know. It does not just mean someone who lives nearby or someone who belongs to the same language-group.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

someone else (GNT)

anyone (CEV)

The word neighbor also occurs in 2:8c-d.

James 4:13

Section 4:13–17: Trust in the Lord and not in yourselves

In this section, James rebuked the merchants who made plans to get rich but did not think about God. It is not clear whether or not the people whom James was denouncing belonged to the Christian community. It may be that among the Jewish traders of the time there were some who claimed to follow Christ but were not living as they should. On the other hand, there were no doubt many rich traders and merchants outside the church (see the references to "the rich" in 2:6–7), and James' words would have served as a warning to Christians not to desire to follow their example.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Don't Brag About Your Plans for the Future (GW)

Warning against Boasting (GNT)

Paragraph 4:13–17

James described the way traders made plans to get rich (4:13). Then he explained that those who think like that are ignoring God (4:14). He told them that instead they ought to submit to the Lord's will (4:15). He reminded them that their behavior was arrogant (4:16) and warned them that God considered it sinful (4:17).

4:13a**Come now, you who say,**

- ¶ Listen to me, you^(plur) people who are saying,
- ¶ Those of you^(plur) who say that

Come now: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as Come now is an idiomatic way of getting people's attention. This expression introduces a warning. So you should use an expression that indicates that James was about to say something that his hearers would not be happy to hear.

Some other ways to translate this expression are:

Now listen to me (GNT)

Pay attention to this! (GW)

Here the word now is not the time word that means "at the present time."

you who say: Some traders and merchants were talking (or at least thinking) in the way that follows. James was addressing these people. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Some of you say (NCV)

anyone who says

4:13b**"Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city,**

- "Today or tomorrow we will go to a certain city,
- you^(plur) will travel to such and such a town today or tomorrow

Today or tomorrow: The phrase Today or tomorrow means "in the future" or "soon." The traders intended to go and buy and sell goods, but they had not decided exactly when they would start their trip. Commentators have suggested an alternative way to understand and punctuate the Greek text: Some of you say, "Today we will go..." others say, "Tomorrow we will go..." This understanding is supported by Hiebert, page 274; Lenski, page 639; Tasker, page

101. However, as none of the major English versions have followed this punctuation of the text, it is recommended that you punctuate in accordance with the BSB, as in the notes. For support for this punctuation, see Adamson (1976), page 178, and Motyer, page 160.

we will go: The traders meant that they would leave the place where they were and begin their journey to another place. The GNT translates this as:

we will travel

we: James imagined traders who were making their plans. But it is uncertain who they may have been talking to. They may have been making plans among themselves. Or they may have been telling other people what they planned to do. So for languages that have inclusive and exclusive forms for "we", probably either could be used here.

to this or that city: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this or that city refers to a city whose name was not important to James. The traders of whom James was speaking would have known the particular city they were going to. So the expression does not mean "some town or other, but we are not sure which one." Some commentators have not expressed themselves clearly and a number of English versions are ambiguous, but see Blass-Debrunner-Funk, §289; Liddell-Scott-Jones, 9th ed. The reference of the Greek hode (which takes the form tēde in this verse) is to a particular entity.

Some languages have an expression to refer to a particular location without mentioning the name. When someone quotes another person's words or tells a story, he can use this expression in place of a name. He does this when the exact name is not important. In English, the expressions "such and such" or "so and so" can be used for this purpose.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to a certain city (GNT)

to such-and-such a city (JBP)

4:13c**spend a year there,**

- stay there a year,
- and live there for a year

spend a year there: The phrase spend a year there means "live in that city for a year". For example:

We will stay there a year (NCV)

4:13d carry on business,

- trade things,
- and work buying and selling goods

carry on business: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as carry on business means “work buying and selling goods for profit.” Some other ways to translate this verb are:

do business (CEV)

trade (RSV)

4:13e and make a profit.”

- and make some money.”
- and earn/gain a profit, listen^(plur) to me!

make a profit: The phrase make a profit means to gain money.

General Comment on 4:13a–e

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in this verse. For example:

Some people are saying, ^{13b–e}“Today or tomorrow we will go....” ^{13a}Now, you who are saying such things, listen to me!

In some languages, it is more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

^aListen to me, those of you who say that ^btoday or tomorrow you are going to some city ^cto stay a year there ^dto trade and ^emake a profit.

James 4:14

Section 4:13–17: Trust in the Lord and not in yourselves

In this section, James rebuked the merchants who made plans to get rich but did not think about God. It is not clear whether or not the people whom James was denouncing belonged to the Christian community. It may be that among the Jewish traders of the time there were some who claimed to follow Christ but were not living as they should. On the other hand, there were no doubt many rich traders and merchants outside the church (see the references to “the rich”

in 2:6–7), and James’ words would have served as a warning to Christians not to desire to follow their example.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Don’t Brag About Your Plans for the Future (GW)

Warning against Boasting (GNT)

Paragraph 4:13–17

James described the way traders made plans to get rich (4:13). Then he explained that those who think like that are ignoring God (4:14). He told them that instead they ought to submit to the Lord’s will (4:15). He reminded them that their behavior was arrogant (4:16) and warned them that God considered it sinful (4:17).

4:14a–b

You do not even know what will happen tomorrow!

What is your life?: There are two ways to punctuate 4:14a–b. Consequently, there are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as What is your life. They are:

1. It is a rhetorical question and goes with what follows in 4:14c–e. According to this interpretation, James was emphasizing the shortness of life. Ropes, page 278; Hiebert, page 276; Laws, page 191; Moo (1985), page 155. In addition, some other modern editions of the Greek text (Tischendorf, von Soden, Vogels, Merk, and Bover), versions (KJV, LB, JBP) and commentators (Alford, page 319; Huther, page 194; Mayor, page 145; Adamson (1976), page 179) follow a different manuscript reading where the word *γάρ* is inserted, thus ensuring that (1) is inevitably followed. For example, the NET says:

You do not know about tomorrow. What is your life like? (BSB, RSV, NIV, REB, KJV, NET, GW, NLT96, NCV, ESV, CEV, JBP)

1. It is a statement and goes with what precedes in 4:14a. According to this interpretation, James was emphasizing that the traders were ignorant of what their life would be like tomorrow. Martin, page 158. For example, the GNT says:

You don’t even know what your life tomorrow will be! (GNT, NASB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is followed by the majority of commentators and English

versions. James' point is not about what your life will be like tomorrow, but whether you will be alive at all. This is clear from 4:15.

4:14a

You do not even know what will happen tomorrow!

- However, you^(plur) do not know what events will happen/occur tomorrow!
- But do you^(plur) even know what will happen tomorrow? Of course not!

There is a contrast between 4:13 and 4:14. The contrast is between the rich people's plans, and the fact that they do not know what will happen the next day. Some ways to show this contrast are:

But (NCV)

You talk like that, however

You do not even know what will happen tomorrow!:

The BSB uses even as a way of communicating the exclamation in English. The NIV tries to show this exclamation and the contrast mentioned above by using the word "Why."

Some ways to translate this sentence are:

- As an exclamation. For example:

Why, you do not even know what will happen tomorrow. (NIV)

But you do not know what will happen tomorrow! (NCV)

You have no idea/clue what will happen tomorrow!

- As a rhetorical question that emphasizes that we do not know what will happen tomorrow. For example:

But do you even know what will happen tomorrow? Of course not!

What do you know about tomorrow? (CEV)

4:14b

What is your life?

- What is your^(plur) life like?
- Think about your^(plur) life!
- You^(plur) live

What is your life?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes how uncertain life is. James responded to his own rhetorical question in the next sentence.

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What is your life after all? (REB)

Do you know how long you will live?

To what can your life be compared?

- As a statement. For example:

Think about your life.

Consider the time you have to live.

- As a phrase connected to and introducing 4:14c. For example:

Your life is.... (NCV)

The time you live is like

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

4:14c-e

Most English versions use no connecting word at the beginning of this sentence. In Greek, there is a connector showing that this sentence explains the reason why life is uncertain. The RSV translates the Greek conjunction as "For." Use a natural way of connecting this sentence to the question that came before it.

You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, James compared a person's life to a mist. The way that they are similar is that both exist for only a short time.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

It is nothing more than mist that appears for only a little while before it disappears. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

For your life is like the morning fog—it's here a little while, then it's gone. (NLT96)

- Translate the meaning without using the metaphor. For example:

You live for a brief while and then pass away.

4:14c

You are a mist

- You^(plur) are like a puff of smoke
- It is very brief like steam
- for only

You are: The words You are introduce an answer to the question “What is your life?” In some languages, it may be necessary to say “Your life is....” For example:

your life is like (NLT)

a mist: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a mist means “a vapor or smoke that goes into the air.” Some other ways to translate this word are:

puff of smoke (NET)

morning fog (NLT)

steam

4:14d

that appears for a little while

- that is here only a short time.
- that is seen for a moment (GW)
- a brief time.

appears for a little while: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appears means “exists” or “is here.” Some other ways to translate this clause are:

it's here a little while (NLT)

that is seen for a moment (GW)

You can see it for a short time (NCV)

4:14e

and then vanishes.

- Then it disappears.
- then goes away.

- Then you^(plur) die.

and then vanishes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vanishes also means “disappear.” Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and then disappears (GNT)

then it goes away (NCV)

If you translate the meaning of 4:14c–e without using a metaphor, some ways to translate vanishes are:

and then you pass away

then it's over

and then you die

James 4:15

Section 4:13–17: Trust in the Lord and not in yourselves

In this section, James rebuked the merchants who made plans to get rich but did not think about God. It is not clear whether or not the people whom James was denouncing belonged to the Christian community. It may be that among the Jewish traders of the time there were some who claimed to follow Christ but were not living as they should. On the other hand, there were no doubt many rich traders and merchants outside the church (see the references to “the rich” in 2:6–7), and James' words would have served as a warning to Christians not to desire to follow their example.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Don't Brag About Your Plans for the Future (GW)

Warning against Boasting (GNT)

Paragraph 4:13–17

James described the way traders made plans to get rich (4:13). Then he explained that those who think like that are ignoring God (4:14). He told them that instead they ought to submit to the Lord's will (4:15). He reminded them that their behavior was arrogant (4:16) and warned them that God considered it sinful (4:17).

4:15a

Instead, you ought to say,

- Instead of what you^(plur) are saying, you should say,
- Rather than talking about your^(plur) plans, what you should say is this:

Instead, you ought to say: The clause Instead, you ought to say means “Rather than saying today or tomorrow we will do this and that, you ought to say what follows.” Some English versions do not use the word Instead. They use another construction to indicate the contrast between this verse and 4:13.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

What you should say is this: (GNT)

Instead of saying that, here is what you should say

Rather than talking about your plans, what you should say is this:

4:15b

“If the Lord is willing,

- “If the Lord wants/desires it,
- “If it pleases the Lord God,

If the Lord is willing: The clause If the Lord is willing means “If the Lord wants us to live and do these things.” Some other ways to translate this clause are:

If the Lord wants

If the Lord desires it

If the Lord agrees

If the Lord God likes

the Lord: The phrase the Lord refers to God. It means “Master”, the One who has supreme authority over everyone and everything. See the note at 4:10a. See also Lord in the Glossary.

4:15c

we will live

- we will continue to live
- then we will still be alive

we will live: The Greek verb that the BSB translates here as we will live means “we shall continue to live.” For example:

we shall still be alive (JBP)

In some languages, it may be necessary to add a word to indicate that this verb begins the second part of an “if” clause. For example:

then we will live (NET)

4:15d

and do this or that.”

- and we will do this event or that event.”
- and be able to go and do this business.”

and do this or that: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as this or that refers to the particular event that the traders planned to do. See Davids (1982), page 173; Hiebert, page 278. Most commentators do not discuss this point. They planned to do business and make money.

Some other ways to translate this expression are:

We will do these things. (CEV)

carry out our plans (GW)

do so-and-so (JBP)

James was saying that people should continue to make definite plans but should make them subject to the condition: “If it is the Lord’s will.”

General Comment on 4:15b–d

In some languages, it will be necessary to include parts of 4:15c–d in the “If” clause of 4:15c. For example:

^bIf the Lord wants us ^cto live ^dand do this or that, it will happen.

If the Lord wants us to live, we will live. If he wants us to do this or that, we will do it.

James 4:16

Section 4:13–17: Trust in the Lord and not in yourselves

In this section, James rebuked the merchants who made plans to get rich but did not think about God. It is not clear whether or not the people whom James was denouncing belonged to the Christian community. It may be that among the Jewish traders of the time there were some who claimed to follow Christ but

were not living as they should. On the other hand, there were no doubt many rich traders and merchants outside the church (see the references to “the rich” in 2:6–7), and James’ words would have served as a warning to Christians not to desire to follow their example.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Don’t Brag About Your Plans for the Future (GW)

Warning against Boasting (GNT)

Paragraph 4:13–17

James described the way traders made plans to get rich (4:13). Then he explained that those who think like that are ignoring God (4:14). He told them that instead they ought to submit to the Lord’s will (4:15). He reminded them that their behavior was arrogant (4:16) and warned them that God considered it sinful (4:17).

4:16a

As it is, you boast in your proud intentions.

- But instead of saying that, you^(plur) boast about your arrogant plans.
- But in reality, you^(plur) are proud of what you want to do.

As it is: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *As it is* is more literally “But now” (as in the GNT). This phrase introduces a description of how the traders usually behave. It also indicates a contrast. They should be saying, “If the Lord wills.” But instead of saying that, they are boasting.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

But now (GNT)

But instead (REB)

But in reality

But your words are not like that

you boast in your proud intentions: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *you boast in your proud intentions* is literally “you boast in your arrogances.” There are at least two ways to interpret the phrase “in your arrogances”:

1. It is the object or content of the traders’ boasting. In other words, it is what the traders were boasting

about. They were boasting about the certainty of their plans. They were boasting in their own ability to do things without any help from God. For example, the NIV11 says:

you boast in your arrogant schemes (BSB, NIV11, NLT, JBPCCommentators that support this interpretation are Ropes, page 280; Moo (1985), page 157; Martin, pages 167–168.)

1. It is the second description of the traders and is parallel to boast. The traders were boasting and they were bragging. For example, the REB says:

you boast and brag (NIV84, GNT, NJB, REB, NCV-Commentators that support this interpretation are Alford, page 319; Huther, page 196; Adamson (1976), page 181; Laws, page 192; Davids (1982), page 173.)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There are two reasons for this choice:

(a) The word “boast” occurs with the preposition “in” sixteen other places in the New Testament. In all these cases, the phrase that follows is the object of boasting. As in ‘boast in/about one’s high position’ in James 1:9.

(b) The noun “arrogances” is plural. This indicates that James was referring to the traders’ plans in 4:13b–e.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

you^(plur) boast about the plans that you think are so good

you speak so proudly of what you consider to be wise plans

you are bragging about what you will do

boast: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *boast* refers to the traders proudly talking of their plans. They talked as if they did everything without God’s help. This word indicates how people talk when they are proud.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

are proud (GNT)

brag (GW)

4:16b**All such boasting is evil.**

- That kind of boasting is evil/wrong.
- It is wrong to be proud like that.

All such boasting is evil: The clause that the BSB translates as All such boasting is evil refers to boasting about your plans. Boasting about your ability to do things without God's help is evil.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and it is wrong to be so proud (CEV)

When people boast like that, it is wrong/bad.

James 4:17**Section 4:13–17: Trust in the Lord and not in yourselves**

In this section, James rebuked the merchants who made plans to get rich but did not think about God. It is not clear whether or not the people whom James was denouncing belonged to the Christian community. It may be that among the Jewish traders of the time there were some who claimed to follow Christ but were not living as they should. On the other hand, there were no doubt many rich traders and merchants outside the church (see the references to “the rich” in 2:6–7), and James' words would have served as a warning to Christians not to desire to follow their example.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Don't Brag About Your Plans for the Future (GW)

Warning against Boasting (GNT)

Paragraph 4:13–17

James described the way traders made plans to get rich (4:13). Then he explained that those who think like that are ignoring God (4:14). He told them that instead they ought to submit to the Lord's will (4:15). He reminded them that their behavior was arrogant (4:16) and warned them that God considered it sinful (4:17).

4:17b**yet fails to do it,**

- and does not do it,
- but does not behave like that,

4:17**Anyone, then, who knows the right thing to do, yet fails to do it, is guilty of sin:**

In this sentence, James warned people to behave properly. He stated the warning in general terms, but he was probably warning people against making plans with a boastful attitude (4:13–16). He wanted people to be humble when they made plans for the future. Commentators disagree on what James is talking about. There are three interpretations: (1) The verse refers to the topic of making plans with a boastful attitude (4:13–16). In this context doing the good he ought to do means being humble when making plans, as James recommended in 4:15. (Interpretation (1) is followed by Alford, page 319; Adamson (1976), page 181; Hiebert, page 280; Moo (1985), page 158.) (2) In the good he ought to do the idea of “doing good” means doing good deeds (see chapter 2). The traders were guilty of trying to make a profit for themselves instead of sharing it with the poor. (Interpretation (2) is followed by Laws, page 193.) (3) The statement does not refer particularly to this paragraph, but to all the teaching that James has given so far. (Interpretation (3) is followed by Mayor, page 147; Mitton, page 172; and apparently by RSV since that version omits the connecting word then.) All three of these interpretations are supported by different commentators. However, three points show that James meant this verse to be understood together with the verses before it (4:13–16), as in interpretation (1). First, the verse has a connecting word in the Greek, translated then. Secondly, the word good is the opposite of the word “evil” in 4:16. Thirdly, if James wanted this statement to apply to all his teaching, he would have put it near the end of chapter 5. Interpretation (1) is recommended because it is the only interpretation in which this verse is understood together with 4:13–16.

Some other ways to translate this verse are:

Therefore, the person who knows the good thing to do in this situation, but he does not do it, he has sinned.

You know what is the right thing to do in this matter. So if you do not do it, you have sinned.

4:17a**Anyone, then, who knows the right thing to do,**

- So, the person who knows the right thing to do
- Therefore, if someone knows the right way to behave in this matter

Anyone...who knows: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Anyone who knows refers to people in general. Use whichever word is appropriate when warning people in your language. For example:

Whoever knows (GW)

we know (GNT)

you know (CEV)

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then here introduces the conclusion of all that James wrote in 4:13-16. Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

So then (GNT)

So (NET)

Therefore

knows the right thing to do: The phrase the right thing to do refers to doing what is right. It probably refers to acting in a humble way when planning for the future.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

knows what is right to do (RSV)

the good he ought to do (NIV)

4:17c is guilty of sin.

- he is guilty of sin.
- that person has done evil.

is guilty of sin: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is guilty of sin is literally “to him it is sin.” This is an Old Testament expression. Deuteronomy 15:9; 23:21-22; 24:15. The meaning is “it is counted against him by God as sin.” In other words, God considers him guilty of committing a sin.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

sins (NIV)

commits sin (NRSV)

This word also occurs in 1:15b. See the note there for more details.

James 5:1

Section 5:1-6: James warned rich people who mistreat others

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God’s judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God’s judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly (“you rich people”). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:1a**Come now, you who are rich,**

- ¶ Listen to me, you^(plur) rich people!
- ¶ All you^(plur) who are wealthy, pay attention!

Come now: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as Come now is an idiomatic way of getting people's attention. This expression introduces a warning. So you should use words or an expression that are natural in your language to indicate that the next words are a serious matter. James was about to say something that his hearers would not be happy to hear.

Some other ways to translate this expression are:

And now...listen to me (GNT)

Pay attention to this (GW)

Think carefully about what I am going to say

Here the word now is not the time word that means "at the present time."

you who are rich: The Greek word that the BSB translates as you who are rich is literally "the rich men." James was probably referring to rich landowners who were not Christians.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

you rich (RSV)

if you're rich (GW)

you^(plur) who are rich

As mentioned above, in some languages it may be more natural to translate this section without using the pronouns "you." For example:

rich people

5:1b**weep and wail**

- Cry^(plur) and wail
- You^(plur) should cry loudly

weep and wail: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as weep and wail are a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. In some languages, both words can be translated by emphasizing one action. For example:

cry loudly

weep: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weep means to "cry." For example, the CEV says:

cry

This same Greek word occurs in 4:9a.

wail: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wail means to make a loud screaming noise that expresses great emotion. It generally includes "crying."

Some other ways to translate this word are:

howl (ESV)

cry aloud (NET)

5:1c**over the misery to come upon you.**

- because of the troubles that are coming on you.^(plur)
- over the sufferings that God will send you.^(plur)
- because God is about to cause you^(plur) to suffer greatly.

over the misery to come upon you: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as over is a preposition. It also means "on." For example:

over the miseries that are coming upon you (GNT)

about the misery that is coming to you (GW)

It is also possible to start a new sentence here. For example:

Terrible things are going to happen to you. (CEV)

misery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as misery is plural. For example:

miserias (GNT)

This word means “great pains/ sufferings.” Some other ways to translate this word are:

terrible troubles (NLT)

hardships

great suffering

to come: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to come means that rich people had not yet experienced this trouble. It would happen to them in the future.

In some languages, it is not natural to say that “misery” is to come. If that is true in your language, you may need to say something like:

because of the miseries that God will send/give you^(plur)

because you are going to be miserable

Terrible things are going to happen to you. (CEV)

upon you: Some other ways to translate upon you are:

on you

to you

James 5:2

Section 5:1–6: James warned rich people who mistreat others

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God’s judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God’s judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly (“you rich people”). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were

poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:2a

Your riches have rotted

- Your^(plur) riches are rotted/decayed,
- Your^(plur) valuable goods will be destroyed.

Your riches have rotted: The clause Your riches have rotted is a general statement that all the possessions of the rich people will “spoil.” Some commentators suggest that the Greek word that the BSB translates as riches refers specifically to grain (wheat). See Mayor, pages 148–149; Hiebert, page 285; Mitton, page 176; Tasker, page 110; Manton, page 403. They point out that there is evidence that the word translated

riches originally referred in the ancient world to having plenty of grain stored in the granaries. Also, the word translated rotted usually means actual rotting, although it can mean decay in general. Thirdly, since 5:2a is connected by “and” to a clause that mentions a specific kind of possessions (5:2b), it seems likely that 5:2a also refers to a specific kind of possessions. Note also that Palestine was primarily an agricultural society, and see Luke 12:16–21. However, none of the major English versions translate this word as “grain.” or “be ruined.” In 5:2b and 5:3a James went on to mention which possessions in particular had spoiled. Use a word for rotted that goes well with riches. For example:

Your riches have decayed (GW)

Your richest goods are ruined (JBP)

This future event is so certain that James spoke of it as something that had already happened. This is typical prophetic style. In some languages, it is more natural to use the future tense here. For example:

Your^(plur) wealth will surely become worthless.

All the things that you have accumulated for yourselves will be destroyed.

5:2b

and moths have eaten your clothes.

- and moths have eaten/spoiled your^(plur) fine/expensive clothes.
- Insects/Termites/Ants will ruin your^(plur) clothes.

moths have eaten your clothes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as clothes refers to outer garments such as robes. In the biblical world, beautiful garments were very expensive, and people considered them as part of their wealth. (See Judges 14:12; 2 Kings 5:5; Acts 20:33). The larvae of moths could eat the cloth and make holes in it while the garment was stored.

As in 5:2a, this future event is so certain that James spoke of it as something that had already happened. In some languages, it is more natural to use the future tense here. For example:

moths will eat your clothes

If moths that eat clothes are not known in your area, you can use:

- a more generic name. For example:

insects

- an explanatory phrase

bugs that eat clothes

- another insect that destroys clothes. For example:

termites

ants

cockroaches

James 5:3

Section 5:1–6: James warned rich people who mistreat others

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God’s judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God’s judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly (“you rich people”). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the

last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:3a

Your gold and silver are corroded.

- Your^(plur) gold and silver are rusted,
- Your^(plur) fine/precious metal will rust,

gold and silver: The words gold and silver may refer here to coins made of gold and silver. But the phrase may also include jewelry and drinking cups or bowls made of gold and silver.

If your language does not have words for both gold and silver, it may be possible to say:

gold and other fine metal

money (CEV)

precious/expensive metals

corroded: The Greek word that the BSB translates as corroded literally means “rusted.” It is the process that forms a reddish coating on metals such as iron when they get damp. The word implies that the metal is being spoiled or destroyed.

Pure gold and silver do not rust. But the gold and silver that most people have is not 100% pure, so it can rust. In addition, silver can tarnish (become blackened).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

rusted (CEV)

tarnished/blackened

5:3b

Their corrosion will testify against you

- and that rust will be like a witness against you^(plur) on the day that God will judge you.
- and the rust will be evidence against you^(plur) that you have been greedy/selfish with your wealth.

Their corrosion will testify against you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Their corrosion will testify against you is literally “Their corrosion will be a witness to/for you.” For example:

their rust will be a witness against you (NET)

This sentence is a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, James speaks of corrosion as if it were a person who will testify in court. James meant that on the day when God will judge all people, the corrosion of the gold and silver will be evidence that rich people had misused their possessions. They misused their possessions by hoarding them. An alternate understanding of the sense in which the rust “will testify against them” is that the rust is evidence of the temporary and perishable (and therefore worthless) nature of riches. However, if this is the meaning, then the rust is less a condemning testimony in court and more a “teaching witness” that reveals the true nature and value of riches. But this is less in keeping with the context of judgment coming upon them in the last days. Rich people had more possessions than they needed, but they did not give them to help others.

There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Keep the personification. For example:

their rust will be a witness against you (NASB)

their rust will speak against you^(plur) in court

- Translate the meaning. For example:

the rust will be evidence against you (CEV)

the rust will be evidence to accuse you^(plur) on the day of judgment.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

that rust will be a proof that you were wrong
(NCV)

their very tarnish will be the evidence of your
wicked hoarding (JBP)

the rust will be the sign of your^(plur) sin of being
greedy

that rust will make it clear that you^(plur) have been
selfish with your wealth

Their corrosion: The phrase Their corrosion refers to the corrosion or rust of the gold and silver in 5:3a. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the same corrosion (NJB)

their rust (RSV)

that rust (NCV)

this will be evidence

5:3c

and consume your flesh like fire.

- It will burn your^(plur) bodies like fire burns.
- and the same rust that destroyed your^(plur) wealth will destroy you too. It will attack your body like a fire.
- Because of that, God will destroy you^(plur) like fire destroys.

and consume your flesh: The subject of this clause is “their corrosion” from 5:3b. The corrosion will consume your flesh. James connected the idea that their wealth is being destroyed by rust with the idea that they too will be destroyed. That is, they will be judged guilty by God and punished.

This whole expression is figurative language. Here “corrosion” (rust) refers to God’s judging and punishing rich people based on the evidence of their greed. The verb consume is used in an extended sense to mean “destroy.” The noun flesh refers to the entire “body.” (It does not refer to just the skin.) So this clause refers to God punishing (the bodies of) these rich people.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the figurative language. For example:

It will eat your bodies (NCV)

- Keep some of the figurative language. For example:

it burns your body (CEV)

it will destroy your body (GW)

and that same rust that destroys your^(plur) wealth
will destroy you^(plur) too

- Translate the meaning without the figurative language. For example:

and because of this your^(plur) bodies will be consumed

and it will cause you^(plur) to be destroyed in hell

That rust will so certainly condemn you that it will
be as if the rust itself destroys you

and God will punish you

like fire: The phrase like fire is a comparison called a simile. In this simile, rust is compared to fire. One way that they are similar is that both destroy or consume things. Fire is a common image of God’s judgment in both the Old Testament scriptures (see, for example, Isaiah 30:27, 33) and in Jesus’ teaching (see, for example, Matthew 25:41).

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Keep the simile. For example:

like fire consumes/burns things

like the fire of God’s judgment

like the fire of hell

- Translate the meaning without the simile. One way to do this is to translate the word fire with an adverb that strengthens your translation of the expression “will eat your flesh.” For example:

you^(plur) will be severely punished

God will harshly punish you

5:3d**You have hoarded treasure in the last days.**

- You^(plur) have foolishly stored up many possessions in the time of the last days of this world.
- The world is about to end, and yet you^(plur) are gathering riches in case you may need them some day!
- You^(plur) are storing up wealth for the future. But do you not realize that the world is about to end and God will begin to judge people right after that?

You have hoarded treasure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as You have hoarded treasure means “you have stored, gathered, or saved treasure.” This refers to all the possessions the rich people had gathered (in 5:2–3a).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

You have piled up riches (GNT)

You have stored up riches (GW)

you keep on storing up wealth (CEV)

You^(plur) have accumulated many things for yourselves

in the last days: There are two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as in the last days:

1. It means in the time of the last days. James believed that he was already living in the final days before the end of the world. He was implying that it was foolish for rich people to continue gathering more and more possessions. They ought to realize that God would soon judge everyone in the world. For example, the REB says:

in an age that is near its close (BSB, NIV, GNT, REB, NASB, ESV, NET, GW)

1. It means in preparation for the last days. According to this interpretation, the rich were hoarding wealth to prepare for the difficult times in the last days. For example, the RSV says:

for the last days (RSV, NJB, NCV, KJV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek preposition normally means “in” rather than “for.” Also, the expression “the last days” normally refers to all of the present age since the Day of Pente-

cost. James was implying that the days we live in will soon end with God’s Day of Judgment.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

during these last days

in this last period of time before God judges people

General Comment on 5:3d

James rebuked these rich people for hoarding wealth in the last days. This was a foolish thing to do. People hoard wealth in order to have it for the future. But if it is the last days, the world as they knew it would soon come to an end and judgment would follow. In your translation, you may want to show that hoarding wealth is not the wise or logical thing to do in the last days. For example:

You have foolishly hoarded wealth in the last days.

The world is about to end, but/yet you are storing up wealth.

James 5:4**Section 5:1–6: James warned rich people who mistreat others**

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God’s judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God’s judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly (“you rich people”). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this

section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:4a

Look, the wages you withheld from the workmen who mowed your fields

- Listen! Men harvested your^(plur) fields, but you refused to give them their money. This money
- Listen! You^(plur) have also refused to pay the men who cut the grain on/in your fields/farms.

5:4b

are crying out against you.

- is complaining about you.^(plur)
- They are shouting/calling to God against/about you.^(plur)

5:4a–b

In this verse, James condemned another sin of rich men. They cheated their workers by refusing to pay them what they had agreed to pay.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as Look calls attention to something surprising or shocking. It does not necessarily refer to something

that can be seen with the eyes. Since the main event in this verse is “crying out,” it may be better to start with “Listen!” rather than with “look!” For example:

Listen! (NRSV)

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Pay attention to

Notice

Listen to me

Many English versions do not translate this word. Use a natural way in your language to call attention to what James said immediately following this word.

the wages you withheld from the workmen: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withheld also means “cheated,” “defrauded,” or “refused to pay.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You refused to pay the people who worked (CEV)

the field workers whom you have cheated of their pay (NLT)

the pay you have held back from the workers (NET)

who mowed your fields: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mowed here refers to cutting the stalks of grain. This is the first process in harvesting grain.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

who harvested your fields (GW)

who worked in your fields (CEV)

who cut your grain

are crying out against you: This is a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, James speaks of the unpaid wages as if they were people who cry out. The wages were crying out that they should be paid to the workmen.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as crying out implies that the wages were:

1. complaining to the rich men who cheated. For example:

Listen to their complaints! (GNT)

1. asking God for help. For example:

shout to God against you (GW)

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

General Comment on 5:4a–b

- Keep the personification. For example:

The pay you did not give the workers...cries out against you. (NCV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

Hear the cries of the field workers whom you have cheated of their pay. (NLT)

There is a lot of new information in these verse parts. In many languages, it may be helpful to divide the long sentence into two or more separate clauses or sentences. For example:

^{4a-b}You refused to pay the people who worked in your fields, and now their unpaid wages are shouting out against you. (CEV)

^{4a-b}You failed to pay the workmen who mowed your fields. Look! Their wages are crying out against you!

5:4c

The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord of Hosts.

- The cries of those who reap have reached the ears of God, the Lord of heaven's armies.
- The Lord All-powerful has heard the cries/complaints of the harvest workers.

The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord of Hosts: The harvesters are the same men as the "workmen" in 5:4a. James said that their cries had reached God's ears. This means that God had heard the workers' complaints. James implied that God would soon punish the rich men for their sin.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

the cries of the workers have been heard by the Lord All-Powerful. (NCV)

The Lord of Armies has heard the cries of those who gather the crops. (GW)

the harvesters: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the harvesters refers to workers who cut the grain and gather it together to remove it from the field. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the reapers (NET)

workers who harvested your crops (CEV)

the workers (NCV)

the Lord of Hosts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord of Hosts is taken from the Old Testament. It is a title for God that is literally "Lord of armies." Even in the Old Testament, this title had come to mean "the supreme God" or "the Almighty God." This means that God is the ruler of every power in the spiritual world.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the Lord of Heaven's Armies (NLT)

God, the Lord Almighty (GNT)

the Supreme Chief/Ruler of all heavenly beings

the Lord All-Powerful (CEV)

This title also occurs in Romans 9:29; Psalm 89:8; and Isaiah 6:3. See also Lord in the Glossary.

James 5:5

Section 5:1–6: James warned rich people who mistreat others

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God's judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God's judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly (“you rich people”). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:5

In this verse, James condemned rich people for the way they lived. The past tense verbs “have lived” and “have fattened” describe how the rich people had lived their lives until that time.

5:5a

You have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence.

- You^(plur) have lived your life on earth in comfort and have indulged yourselves in every pleasure.
- While in this world, you^(plur) have enjoyed life because of your riches, and you have done whatever you wanted.

You have lived...in luxury: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as You have lived...in luxury means that the rich men lived an easy life. They had everything they liked that gave them comfort or great joy without doing any hard work.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

Your life...was full of rich living (NCV)

you have had a life of comfort (NJB)

You^(plur) have had an easy life with lots of money to buy nice things

on earth: The phrase on earth implies a contrast with how these men would live after God’s Day of Judgment.

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this phrase first in 5:5. For example:

While here on earth (CEV)

Your life on earth (NCV)

In this world

and self-indulgence: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as self-indulgence is similar in meaning to the verb “lived in luxury.” It means that the rich people did anything they wanted so that they could have as much pleasure as they liked.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

and pleasure (GNT)

satisfying your every desire (NLT)

and pleasing yourselves with everything you wanted (NCV)

5:5b**You have fattened your hearts in the day of slaughter.**

- You made yourselves fat, like an animal ready to be killed. (NCV)
- You^(plur) have made yourselves ready to be judged. You are like fattened animals that men prepare for the day that they will slaughter them.
- In doing this, you^(plur) are like animals that are made fat just before they are killed and eaten. Like them, you are not aware that you are about to be judged/destroyed.

You have fattened your hearts in the day of slaughter: This is a metaphor. Parts of it are implicit. In this metaphor, James compared rich people to animals. Some ways that they are similar are:

1. Both fatten themselves. The rich people were indulging themselves, not doing any physical work and getting fat. They are just like animals that farmers allow not to work, but to enjoy eating and becoming fat before the farmer slaughters them for food.
2. By fattening themselves, both are unaware that they are preparing their own doom. For animals, their doom is to be slaughtered. For the rich, their doom is to be punished as part of God's judgment.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the image explicit. For example:

You made yourselves fat, like an animal ready to be killed. (NCV)

you are like fat cattle on their way to be butchered. (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

You^(plur) have made yourselves fat and will be judged/punished like fattened animals that men prepare for the day of slaughter.

Like animals that are fed well just before they are slaughtered to be eaten, you^(plur) live for pleasure and are not aware that you are about to face judgment.

- Translate the meaning without using a metaphor. In this metaphor, "getting fat" is a sign of self-indul-

gence and not following God's law to help others. For example:

You^(plur) have not followed God's laws and will be judged.

You have lived only for your own pleasures, and in that way, you have prepared yourselves for God to judge you. And you are not even aware of it!

your hearts: The phrase "your hearts" is figurative language that refers to the entire person. So many modern English versions translate it as "yourselves."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

You^(plur) have made yourselves like animals that have been fattened

But now you are like fat cattle (CEV)

in the day of slaughter: The phrase in the day of slaughter means "prepared for the day to be killed." This phrase refers to the day that the farmer will kill the fattened animals for food. In this metaphor, this phrase is parallel to the day that God will judge the rich.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the day when men slaughter the animals

prepared for a day to be killed

and in this way you^(plur) have prepared yourselves for God's judgment

James 5:6**Section 5:1–6: James warned rich people who mistreat others**

This section consists of a series of warnings that God is about to condemn rich people who have lived in luxury and exploited poor people. James wrote in the style of the Old Testament prophets using very harsh language and vivid, even frightening, images of God's judgment. In your translation, you should use strong language that communicates the certainty of God's judgment.

James wrote as though he were addressing rich people directly ("you rich people"). But he was not really expecting these rich people to read or to hear his

letter. He was writing about rich people who were certainly unbelievers. They were not members of the Christian community. So this section is actually an encouragement to Christians. Many Christians were poor and were being exploited by wealthy landowners. James encouraged these Christians by telling them that, though they were suffering, God would judge the rich. He also wanted to warn them not to envy the rich and not to think or live like them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to use third person forms (“they,” “their,” “them”) throughout this section instead of second person forms (“you”). For example:

^{1a}Rich people ^{1b}should weep and wail ^{1c}because of the misery that is coming upon them. ^{2a}Their wealth has rotted ^{2b}and moths have eaten their clothes. ^{3a}Their gold and silver are corroded. ^{3b}This corrosion will testify against them ^{3c}and eat their flesh like fire. ^{3d}They have hoarded wealth in the last days. ^{4a}Look! The wages they failed to pay the workmen who mowed their fields ^{4b}are crying out against them. ^{4c}The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord Almighty. ^{5a}They have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. ^{5b}They have fattened themselves in the day of slaughter. ^{6a}They have condemned and murdered innocent men, ^{6b}who were not opposing them.

James does not condemn the rich simply because they are rich. He accuses them of specific things they have done wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Warning to the Rich (GNT)

A warning to rich people who mistreat others

James encouraged the poor, mistreated believers by speaking about the judgment that will come to their rich oppressors

5:6a

You have condemned and murdered the righteous,

- You^(plur) have caused righteous people to be judged guilty and then to be killed.
- You^(plur) have influenced judges to declare guilty and have killed those who are not guilty.

You have condemned and murdered the righteous:

James accused the rich men of misusing their power

in the law courts. Rich men were leaders among the people. They had friends who were judges. They used their power to oppress ordinary people even as far as having them condemned to death.

You have condemned: The word condemned means “declare/judge to be guilty (because he has done something wrong).” It can also imply “decide the punishment.” The rich men asked judges to do these things.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You have judged guilty (NCV)

You^(plur) have caused innocent men to be declared guilty

You have made judges declare that innocent men have broken the law

murdered: The word murdered means “caused them to be killed.” This word refers to influencing a judge to condemn a person to die and then have him executed.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

punished by death

executed/killed

the righteous: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the righteous literally says “the righteous person.” Most commentators agree that this does not refer here to one individual person, but to righteous people in general who obey the laws.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

those who are not guilty

those who keep/follow God’s laws

people who do what is right/just

people who have done nothing wrong

See righteous, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

5:6b

who did not resist you.

- They did not oppose/resist you.^(plur)

- These people did not fight back.

who did not resist you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who did not resist you is literally “and he does not resist you.” James meant that the righteous people did not oppose the rich men while the rich men persecuted them. At no point did they attempt to resist or fight back.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

who do not resist you (NLT)

They did not fight back.

resist: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as resist occurs also in 4:6 (“opposes”). It means actively resisting, not just a feeling of hatred.

James 5:7

Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

Commentators disagree over which section the paragraph 5:12 belongs to. ManyHuther, page 215, 217; Mitton, page 191; Davids (1982); Moo (1985), page 173. of them say that it does not belong to this section (5:7–12) more than the next one (5:13–18), and prefer to set it off as separate from both. A fewLaws, page 219; Martin, page 199; see also Ropes, page 300, for a similar view. of them put it with 5:13–18 because it shares the same topic of referring to God when speaking. A few othersAlford, page 325; Adamson (1976), page 194; Hiebert, page 308. (see also the NIV) put it with 5:7–11, because it is similar to 5:9. On the whole it seems best to put 5:12 with this section, but to make it a separate paragraph.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:7–9

In this paragraph, James recommended that Christians be patient even though they were suffering. He supported this by illustrating patience from ordinary life and then applying the illustration to spiritual life.

5:7a

Be patient, then, brothers,

- ¶ So, my brothers, be^(plur) patient
- ¶ Therefore, fellow-believers, be^(plur) long-suffering

Be patient: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Be patient means “be long-suffering.” James was encouraging believers to remain quiet, calm, and hopeful when they were persecuted. They could be certain that God would treat them correctly and fairly in the end.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Endure suffering without complaint

Wait for God to make things right

Many languages have an idiom for this word.

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then introduces some strong advice to be patient. God is going to judge the rich for their unloving actions (5:1–6), and therefore, you should be patient until he does it (5:7–12).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

therefore (RSV)

So (NET)

For this reason

brothers: Notice that the BSB places the word brothers at the end of 5:7a. This follows the Greek word order. In some languages, it is more natural to place this word at a different place in the verse. For example:

Brothers, be patient

Therefore, brothers, be patient

Therefore be patient until the coming of the Lord, brothers.

5:7b

until the Lord’s coming.

- until the Lord returns. (CEV)
- while you^(plur) wait for our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ to come back to earth again.

until the Lord's coming: The phrase the Lord's coming refers to the time when the Lord Jesus Christ will come again to the world in power and glory to judge human beings. (See, for example, Matthew 24:3, 1 Thessalonians 2:19, 4:15, 2 Peter 1:16.)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word coming with a verb. For example:

until the Lord comes (REB)

until the Lord returns (CEV)

until the Lord comes again (NCV)

for the Lord Jesus to come back to earth

Lord's: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord's means someone who has authority over someone or something. Here it refers to Jesus, who is God and has supreme authority.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Master

Owner

our supreme Chief/Leader

Lord Jesus

For further suggestions on translating Lord's in James, see Lord in the Glossary.

5:7c

See how the farmer

- Think^(plur) about farmers. They
- Consider^(plur) farmers as an example. They

See: The Greek word that the BSB translates as See here means "Consider" or "Think about." It introduces an illustration that supports his appeal for them to be patient. It does not mean to do something with one's eyes.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Think of how (NET)

Consider

This same word occurs in 3:4a.

the farmer: The phrase the farmer refers to any ordinary farmer. It is someone who used land to grow food. In some languages it may be natural to translate this in the plural. For example:

farmers (GNT)

5:7d

awaits the precious fruit of the soil—

- wait for their land/fields to produce precious crops.
- must wait until their fields ripen with good grain.

awaits the precious fruit of the soil: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as precious fruit refers to all the fruits, vegetables, or grain that grow in the land/field.

The harvest is precious to the farmer because at that time of year he has little or no food left from the previous year. He needs a good/bountiful harvest to have enough food to last during the coming year. It is also valuable when there is an extra portion of the harvest that the farmer can sell or trade for other things that his family needs.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

wait for their land to produce precious crops (GNT)

They eagerly look for the valuable harvest to ripen. (NLT)

waits for a good/bountiful harvest

soil: The word soil refers to the field or plot of land in which the farmer has planted his crops. Some other ways to translate this are:

field

plot of ground

farm

In some languages, it is not necessary to translate this word. It is understood that the harvest comes from the land.

5:7e**how patient he is**

- They wait patiently
- They calmly wait

how patient he is: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patient is the same word as in 5:7a. In this context, the farmer waits quietly and does not get angry, even though he may be suffering from hunger and does not know if the rain will come at the right time.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

He patiently waits

He endures without complaint

5:7f**for the fall and spring rains.**

- for the first/early rains and the last/late rains to fall.
- for the necessary rains to fall so that the crops grow and ripen well.

for the fall and spring rains: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for the fall and spring rains is literally “until it receives the early and the late rain” (as in the RSV). Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

until the early and late rains have fallen (REB)

for the first and last rains to fall

for the rains to fall to make his crops grow

In Israel, there are two periods when rain is very important for getting a good harvest. The rains during these times are called the “early rain” and the “late rain.” The “early rain” is expected in October, but it is sometimes very delayed. This period of rain is necessary so that the ground may become soft enough for planting seed, and so that the seeds then sprout. The “late rain” refers to showers in April and early May that help to ripen the crops. If these rains do not come, the harvest will be small.

General Comment on 5:7c–f

In some languages, it may be more natural to first talk about rains before mentioning the crop. For example:

“Think of farmers who wait ^epatiently ^ffor the spring and summer rains ^dto make their valuable crops grow. (CEV)

James 5:8**Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith**

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

Commentators disagree over which section the paragraph 5:12 belongs to. ManyHuther, page 215, 217; Mitton, page 191; Davids (1982); Moo (1985), page 173. of them say that it does not belong to this section (5:7–12) more than the next one (5:13–18), and prefer to set it off as separate from both. A fewLaws, page 219; Martin, page 199; see also Ropes, page 300, for a similar view. of them put it with 5:13–18 because it shares the same topic of referring to God when speaking. A few othersAlford, page 325; Adamson (1976), page 194; Hiebert, page 308. (see also the NIV) put it with 5:7–11, because it is similar to 5:9. On the whole it seems best to put 5:12 with this section, but to make it a separate paragraph.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:7–9

In this paragraph, James recommended that Christians be patient even though they were suffering. He supported this by illustrating patience from ordinary life and then applying the illustration to spiritual life.

5:8a**You, too, be patient**

- You^(plur) also, be patient
- You^(plur) believers also should wait calmly/quietly like that.

You, too: The phrase You, too indicates that Christians should behave like the farmer. James was applying the illustration to spiritual life.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

You^(plur) should act in the same way

You should do the same

be patient: The verb be patient is the same word as in 5:7a and 5:7e.

5:8b and strengthen your hearts,

- and courageous,
- Do^(plur) not lose hope.

strengthen your hearts: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as strengthen your hearts can also be translated as “Establish your hearts” (as in the RSV). This is a Greek idiom. James was saying that Christians should remain confident in the midst of their difficult circumstances.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Do not give up hope (NCV)

continue^(plur) confident

be courageous

Many languages have another idiom to translate this phrase. Use whatever has this meaning and is natural in your language.

5:8c because the Lord’s coming is near.

- because the Lord is coming soon. (NCV)
- Our^(incl) Lord Jesus will soon return to earth.

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the basis for James’ appeal to stand firm. They should stand firm because the Lord’s coming is near.

the Lord’s coming is near: The clause the Lord’s coming is near indicates that Jesus Christ will soon return. This fact should motivate James’ readers to be patient and courageous and not lose hope.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Lord is coming soon (NCV)

The Lord will soon be here! (CEV)

The phrase the Lord’s coming also occurs in 5:7b.

James 5:9

Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:7–9

In this paragraph, James recommended that Christians be patient even though they were suffering. He supported this by illustrating patience from ordinary life and then applying the illustration to spiritual life.

5:9a

Do not complain about one another, brothers,

- My brothers, do^(plur) not grumble about one another,
- Fellow-believers, do^(plur) not complain about one another.

Do not complain about one another: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as complain refers to being discontented with others and blaming them for problems. Blaming others is a way of judging them. It is accusing them of doing something wrong. So

this “grumbling” leads to the consequent action mentioned in 5:9b. (See 4:11 and Matthew 7:1.)

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Don’t grumble against each other (NIV)

Do^(plur) not talk against your fellow believers or accuse them

one another: The phrase one another refers to other Christians. Christians should not grumble against one another. See examples above for ways to translate this.

brothers: Notice that the BSB places the word brothers at the end of 5:9a. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning of the verse. For example:

Brothers and sisters, do not complain against each other (NCV)

The word brothers last occurred in 5:7a.

5:9b

so that you will not be judged.

- Otherwise, the Lord will condemn you.^(plur)
- If you^(plur) do complain, the Lord will declare you to be guilty of sin.

so that you will not be judged: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as so that you will not be judged indicates the basis for what James wrote in 5:9a. It indicates that James’ readers will be judged if they continue grumbling about one another.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

or you will be judged guilty (NCV)

if you^(plur) do, you will be condemned

will not be judged: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will not be judged here describes part of the process of judging. It is the part when a judge decides and declares that a person is guilty/wrong. Connected with this decision and pronouncement is the idea that the person will be punished. Here James was saying that the Lord will declare guilty the person who grumbles about another Christian brother.

Some other ways to translate this are:

will not be condemned

will not be declared/pronounced to be wrong

will not be guilty of sin

God’s judgment here does not refer to eternal condemnation and punishment in hell. The word judged also occurs with a similar meaning in 2:12a and 2:13a. See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

James did not say who would do the judging. There are two possibilities:

1. It is the Lord Jesus Christ.
2. It is God the Father. For example:

so that God will not judge you (GNT)

It is preferable that you do not distinguish between God the Father and Jesus here. So if you must say who will judge, it is recommended that you say “the Lord.” In 5:8, James said that the Lord would soon come, and in 5:9c he said that the Judge is standing at the door. It is likely that he was thinking about the same event. In 4:12 James said that there was only one Judge, God, the Lawgiver. But most commentators think that here James is thinking of Christ, who is soon to come back (see Martin, page 192; Hiebert, page 301; SSA, page 146; cf. Ropes, page 297; Laws, page 213).

5:9c

Look, the Judge is standing at the door!

- The judge is arriving soon!
- The one who will judge everybody is ready to come to/into our^(incl) world again!
- The Lord will soon be here, and he will be the judge!

Look: In Greek, this sentence begins with a word that the BSB translates as Look and the RSV translates as “behold”. This word calls attention to something surprising. The NIV uses an exclamation mark at the end of the sentence to show this surprise.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Do not be surprised!

Listen to this!

You should use whatever expression is natural in your language for showing surprise. This same word occurs in 5:4a–b.

the Judge: Commentators disagree as to whether the Judge refers to the Lord Jesus Christ or to God the Father. If you have made explicit who will judge in 5:9b, you will need to make sure that this refers to the same person.

If you need to make it clear that James is not referring to a human judge it is recommended that you say “the Lord.” For example:

the Lord, the one who will judge all people

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

standing at the door: This is a Greek idiom. It means “nearly here” (as in Matthew 24:33). There are at least two ways to translate this idiom:

- Keep the idiom. For example:

stands before the gates! (NET)

right outside the door (CEV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

ready to appear. (GNT)

ready to come! (NCV)

James 5:10

Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

Commentators disagree over which section the paragraph 5:12 belongs to. Many Huther, page 215, 217; Mitton, page 191; Davids (1982); Moo (1985), page 173. of them say that it does not belong to this section (5:7–12) more than the next one (5:13–18), and prefer to set it off as separate from both. A few Laws, page 219; Martin, page 199; see also Ropes, page 300, for a similar view. of them put it with 5:13–18 because it shares the same topic of referring to God when speaking. A

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:10–11

James knew that some of his readers were suffering badly. He encouraged them to be patient like the prophets were. This is the second example of patience.

5:10a

Brothers,

- ¶ My brothers and sisters,
- ¶ Fellow believers,

Brothers: The word Brothers also occurs in 5:7a and 5:9a.

5:10b

as an example of patience in affliction, take the prophets

- for another example of people who were patient when they were suffering, think^(plur) about the prophets
- consider^(plur) also the example of the prophets of God. They suffered, but they were patient.

as an example of patience in affliction, take the prophets:

James told his readers to remember the prophets of Old Testament days who endured suffering and were patient. His readers should follow the examples of these men. In other words, they should imitate their behavior.

Some other ways to translate this are:

let us imitate the prophets. They were patient when they suffered.

follow the example of the prophets.... They suffered many hard things, but they were patient. (NCV)

The prophets who patiently endured suffering long ago are a good example for you^(plur) to follow.

patience in affliction: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as patience in affliction is literally “suffering and patience” (as in the RSV). Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

They were patient, even when they had to suffer.
(CEV)

They suffered many hard things, but they were patient.
(NCV)

patience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patience is related to the verb “be patient” in 5:7a,e and 5:8a. Use a word or expression that corresponds to what you used in those verses.

affliction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as affliction here refers to suffering physical pain caused by others treating them badly. Some other ways to translate this word are:

hardship

persecution

take the prophets: The phrase take the prophets here means “think about the prophets” or “remember the prophets.” For example:

remember the prophets.... Take them as examples
(GNT)

follow the example of the prophets (NCV)

prophets: The word prophets refers to men who spoke on behalf of God. They told people what God revealed to them. God gave some prophets power to work miracles. These miracles helped people realize that God had sent the prophet.

Many prophets were persecuted and even killed, but they remained faithful to God despite their suffering.

Some ways to translate prophets are:

spokesmen for God

men who speak God’s words

God’s message-speakers

It is good to use a general term that does not focus only on foretelling the future. Although prophets did foretell the future, they also gave people other messages from God. They especially told them to stop sinning and to obey God.

When choosing a term for prophet, consider how you will distinguish prophet from other words which are similar in meaning such as “angel,” “apostle,” and “preacher.”

5:10c

who spoke in the name of the Lord.

- who spoke on behalf of the Lord.
- They suffered because they spoke to people the messages that the Lord God told them to speak.

who spoke in the name of the Lord: The phrase who spoke in the name of the Lord indicates that the prophets spoke with the Lord’s authority. They represented God. James was probably implying that this was the reason for the prophets’ suffering.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

who spoke in the name of the Lord (GW)

who spoke what God made known to them

who spoke on behalf of the Lord

who spoke by the authority of the Lord

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to God, the one with supreme authority. Another way to translate this word is:

the Lord God

This word also occurs in 3:9a. See also Lord in the Glossary.

General Comment on 5:10a–c

In some languages, it may be helpful to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{10a}Brothers, ^{10b}think about the prophets. ^{10c}They spoke in the name of the Lord, ^{10b}and they were patient when they suffered because of it.

^{10a}My fellow believers! ^{10b}Remember the prophets ^{10c}who brought the Word of the Lord. ^{10b}They were

patient and withstood suffering. We should follow their example.

James 5:11

Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

Commentators disagree over which section the paragraph 5:12 belongs to. ManyHuther, page 215, 217; Mitton, page 191; Davids (1982); Moo (1985), page 173. of them say that it does not belong to this section (5:7–12) more than the next one (5:13–18), and prefer to set it off as separate from both. A fewLaws, page 219; Martin, page 199; see also Ropes, page 300, for a similar view. of them put it with 5:13–18 because it shares the same topic of referring to God when speaking. A few othersAlford, page 325; Adamson (1976), page 194; Hiebert, page 308. (see also the NIV) put it with 5:7–11, because it is similar to 5:9. On the whole it seems best to put 5:12 with this section, but to make it a separate paragraph.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:10–11

James knew that some of his readers were suffering badly. He encouraged them to be patient like the prophets were. This is the second example of patience.

5:11a

See

- Think^(plur) about this:
- (omit)

See: The Greek word that the BSB translates as See is literally “behold.” This word calls for the readers to pay attention, and it encourages them to think carefully about something.

In some languages, it is more natural to leave this idea implicit. Many English versions do not translate this word.

5:11b

how blessed we consider those who have persevered.

- the people whom we^(incl) think are blessed are those who endured to the end.
- Some people did not give up their faith. We^(incl) consider them favored/fortunate.

how blessed we consider those who have persevered: Scholars differ as to whom James was talking about:

1. He was referring to all people who have been steadfast in their faith.Huther, page 213; Ropes, page 298; Davids (1982), page 186; Hiebert, page 303; Martin, page 193. For example, the NLT says:

We give great honor to those who endure under suffering. (NIV, RSV, ESV, CEV, NLT, GW, NET, KJV)

1. He was referring only to the prophets in 5:10b. The GNT seems to follow this interpretation, saying:

We call them happy because they endured. (GNT, NCV)

James was probably repeating a well-known thought that applied to other people as well as prophets. (A similar thought occurs in 1:12.) For this reason, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

how blessed we consider: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we consider blessed is related to the word in 1:12a that the BSB there translates as blessed. It means that the person is in a good position or is in an enviable/desirable situation.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Favored/fortunate are

How good it is for

See also the note on 1:12a, and see bless, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

those who have persevered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have persevered also means “have endured.” This refers to people who continued to obey God throughout their lives, despite the fact that their faith was greatly tested.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

those who have endured (NET)

did not give up (NCV)

This word comes from the same Greek verb as “perseveres” in 1:12a.

5:11c

You have heard of Job’s perseverance

- You^(plur) have heard of/about Job’s endurance
- We^(incl) have heard how Job persevered/endured suffering for a long time.

James turned to a specific example of someone who persevered: Job. This example was well-known to James’ readers from the Old Testament and from Jewish tradition. Job continued to trust God even when he had lost his wealth, his family and his health.

You have heard of Job’s perseverance: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as perseverance also means “endurance.” It refers to remaining loyal and steadfast.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You have heard about Job’s endurance. (GW)

Job is an example of a man who endured patiently. (NLT96)

You^(plur) know about Job. He did not give up when he suffered

This noun also occurs in 1:3c, and it is related to the verb “have persevered” in 5:11a.

You: In some languages, it may be more natural to continue using the pronoun “We” as in 5:11b.

5:11d

and have seen the outcome from the Lord.

- and how the Lord finally helped him. (CEV)
- We^(incl) also know of the good that the Lord God did for him in the end.

and have seen: The clause have seen means “(you) have understood” by hearing or reading the story. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and you know (GNT)

and you^(plur) have heard

the outcome from the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the outcome from the Lord is literally “the end of the Lord.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that is literally “end”:

1. It means the conclusion, the final outcome, what happened in the end. According to this interpretation, the whole phrase means “the outcome that the Lord gave.” For example, the GNT says:

how the Lord provided for him in the end (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)

1. It means the purpose, the goal that was in view. For example, the ESV says:

the purpose of the Lord (RSV, NET, NCV, NJB, ESV)

In 5:7 James not only urged Christians to be patient in the midst of suffering, but he also promised a happy ending (“the coming of the Lord”). Similarly, the farmer’s crop receives the rain in the end. So also here it is probable that James was referring not only to the fact that Job was steadfast in his faith, but to the way the Lord blessed him in the end. God finally restored Job’s family, wealth, and health (see Job 42:10–17). So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and how the Lord finally helped him. (CEV)

the Lord’s plan finally ended in good (NLT96)

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to God, the one with supreme authority. This word also occurs in 5:10c. See also Lord in the Glossary for more information.

5:11e

The Lord is full of compassion and mercy.

- You^(plur) also know that the Lord is very loving and kind.
- The Lord greatly pities and helps his people who are suffering.

A Greek conjunction connects 5:11d to 5:11e. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It means that or how and introduces something else that James’ readers had understood. For example, the NJB says:

realising that the Lord is kind... (KJV, NASB, RSV, NJB, NET, NCV)

1. It means because or for and introduces a reason for how God treated Job. For example, the GNT says:

For the Lord is full of mercy... (GNT, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). What happened to Job showed James' readers that the Lord was gracious. The BSB does not explicitly translate this word, but it is probably following the first interpretation.

The Lord is full of compassion and mercy: The clause The Lord is full of compassion and mercy means that the Lord is very compassionate and merciful. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Lord is compassionate and merciful (GW)

The Lord has much compassion and mercy

compassion and mercy: The words compassion and mercy are a doublet. This means that they have almost the same meaning.

The word compassion means "kind-hearted," or "having much pity on people." The word mercy means "compassionate" or "showing kindness towards people who suffer or who are in need." (The word mercy also occurs in 2:13 and 3:17.)

Some other ways to translate these words are:

loving and kind

tenderness and pity

In some languages, it may be more natural to use a single expression that is intensified or emphasized. For example:

The Lord greatly pities his suffering people and helps them

James 5:12

Section 5:7–12: Suffering believers should be patient and persevere in their faith

In this section, James explained how Christian people should respond when ungodly rich people oppress

them. Christians should not resist but should be patient, waiting for the Lord to come and bring justice (5:7–8). The theme of patience in the midst of suffering is related to the opening theme of the letter (1:2–4). As well as being patient in suffering, Christians should be patient with one another (5:9). They should follow the example of the prophets of God (5:10–11). They should avoid swearing with oaths (5:12).

Commentators disagree over which section the paragraph 5:12 belongs to. ManyHuther, page 215, 217; Mitton, page 191; Davids (1982); Moo (1985), page 173. of them say that it does not belong to this section (5:7–12) more than the next one (5:13–18), and prefer to set it off as separate from both. A fewLaws, page 219; Martin, page 199; see also Ropes, page 300, for a similar view. of them put it with 5:13–18 because it shares the same topic of referring to God when speaking. A few othersAlford, page 325; Adamson (1976), page 194; Hiebert, page 308. (see also the NIV) put it with 5:7–11, because it is similar to 5:9. On the whole it seems best to put 5:12 with this section, but to make it a separate paragraph.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers should be patient when they suffer

Be patient; the Lord is coming (UBS)

Paragraph 5:12

The Jews used oaths frequently, especially when they had strong feelings. They swore oaths when they made promises or threats, or when they wanted to strengthen the statement they were making. Some examples from the Bible are: 1 Samuel 1:26, 20:3, 20:12; 1 Kings 17:1; Matthew 14:7, 26:72. James here taught that Christian people should avoid oaths.

5:12a

Above all, my brothers,

- ¶ Above all this that I have just said, my brothers,
- ¶ My fellow believers, more important than everything else is this:

Above all: The phrase Above all here means "most of all," or "most important of all." James was probably ranking the avoidance of swearing oaths as even more important than avoiding other sins of the tongue such as grumbling. See Mayor, page 161; Ropes, page 300; Adamson (1976), page 194. Huther, page 215, thinks the comparison is with all the other warnings of the epistle. Other commentators think that James meant, "What I am going to say now is extremely important," and that he was not comparing the importance of this

topic with the importance of what he had said before. See Davids (1982), page 189; Mitton, page 191; Hiebert, page 308; Laws, pages 219–220; Martin, page 203.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

But most of all (NLT)

It is of the highest importance (JBP)

Most importantly

my brothers: Notice that the BSB places the phrase my brothers at the end of 5:12a. This follows the word order of the Greek text. In some languages, it is more natural to place it at the beginning. For example:

My friends, if any of you wander away from the truth... (GNT)

In some languages, it is not natural to repeat my brothers so often. Read 5:7–12 to see if it would be more natural to omit one or more of the phrases my brothers.

5:12b do not swear,

- do^(plur) not swear with/by oaths.
- do not use oaths to convince others that you^(plur) are telling the truth.

do not swear: The Greek word that the BSB translates as swear refers to calling upon God or some other being or object to be a witness that what you are saying is true. It is implied that God will punish you if what you are saying is not true. James said that his readers should stop swearing or using oaths.

Another way to translate this word is:

do not use an oath (GNT)

Be sure to distinguish the word “swear” from the words “curse” and “bad words/language.”

If there is no expression that refers to this word in your language, you may need to explain what James means. For example:

do not call on God to punish you if you are lying

5:12c not by heaven or earth

- You^(plur) should not swear by the name of heaven or by the name of this world,
- For instance: Do^(plur) not use an oath saying that something/someone in heaven or earth

not by heaven or earth: The phrase by heaven or earth means “calling on heaven or earth as a witness that you are telling the truth.” These are examples of the common oaths that the Jews used in the days when James wrote. In this context, heaven means the place where God lives, and earth means this world where human beings live.

In some languages, it will be natural to translate this phrase as a separate sentence. For example:

Don’t use the name of heaven, earth...to prove what you say (NCV)

Do not swear by using anything in heaven or on earth to support your words

See heaven, meaning 2, in the Glossary for more information.

5:12d or by any other oath.

- or by the name of anything else.
- or anything else is your witness that you are telling the truth.

or by any other oath: The phrase or by any other oath means “do not swear by using anything else as a witness that you are telling the truth.”

5:12e Simply let your “Yes” be yes, and your “No,” no,

- When you mean yes, say only yes, and when you mean no, say only no. (NCV)
- Just say a simple yes or no. (NLT)

Simply let your “Yes” be yes, and your “No,” no: This clause implies that when you talk:

1. You should not add any oaths to your words. A simple “yes” or “no” is sufficient.
2. You should always be honest and tell the truth. You should not lie.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

“Yes” or “No” is all you need to say. (CEV)

If you mean yes, say yes. If you mean no, say no. (GW)

Speak the truth without an oath. Say only “yes” when you mean “yes” and say only “no” when you mean “no.”

5:12f

so that you will not fall under judgment.

- Otherwise, you^(plur) will be judged to be guilty.
- If you^(plur) say more, God will judge you and punish you.

so that you will not fall under judgment: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as so that you will not fall under judgment indicates the basis for what James wrote in 5:12a–d.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

otherwise, you^(plur) will be condemned

If you say anything more, you will be condemned.
(CEV)

and then you will not come under God’s judgment
(GNT)

In other words, if you follow James’ advice, God will not condemn you on the Day of Judgment. This is because a person who is in the habit of swearing oaths will sooner or later break his promise or tell a lie. So he will be guilty of using God’s name in an unacceptable way.

fall under judgment: The Greek words that the BSB translates literally as fall under judgment mean “be declared/judged guilty” of having done something wrong. This also includes the idea that the person will be punished for doing wrong. But “judgment” here does not refer to eternal condemnation and punishment in hell.

Some other ways to translate this are:

be judged guilty (NCV)

be pronounced/declared guilty of sin

See judge, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

James 5:13

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations.

When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:13–16

In 5:13 James advised people to praise God or to pray to him, according to what kind of situation they are in. Then he gave them detailed instructions and encouraged them to pray for the sick (5:14–16).

5:13a

Is any one of you suffering?

- ¶ If you are having trouble, (CEV)
- ¶ Any of you^(plur) believers who are having difficulties
- ¶ When you^(sing) have problems,

Is any one of you suffering?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to begin talking about a particular situation. It also introduces a new topic. The topic is about what to do when you are in trouble.

Some ways to introduce this new topic are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Are any among you in trouble? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Anyone who is having troubles (NCV)

- As a conditional clause. For example:

If any of you are having trouble (GW)

- As a temporal clause. For example:

When you^(sing) are in trouble

Use a natural way in your language to introduce this new topic.

A rhetorical question with a similar function occurs in 3:13a.

Is...suffering: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Is...suffering means “faces difficulties (of any kind).” It could refer to physical suffering, but you should translate it in a way that includes other kinds of trouble as well.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

Is...in trouble (NIV)

Are...suffering hardships (NLT)

Is having difficulties

any one of you: The phrase any one of you refers to any believer. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Anyone who (NCV)

you (CEV)

any person among you^(plur)

5:13b

He should pray.

- then you^(sing) should pray to God.
- should pray to God for help.
- ask^(sing) God to help you.

He should pray: In some languages, it will be necessary to make explicit the person to whom people should pray, that is, God. Some other ways to translate this are:

It is important that he pray to God

He should ask God to help him

He: Depending on how you have translated “anyone of you” in 5:13a, you may need to say “you” or “they” rather than “he” here.

5:13c

Is anyone cheerful?

- If you are happy, (GW)
- Anyone who is happy (NCV)
- When you^(sing) are encouraged,

Is anyone cheerful?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to begin talking about a particular situation. The situation is what to do when you are happy.

Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Are any among you happy? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Anyone who is happy (NCV)

Concerning people who are happy

- As a conditional clause. For example:

If you are happy (GW)

- As a temporal clause. For example:

When you^(sing) are happy

cheerful: Some other ways to translate this word are:

encouraged

hopeful

happy (NIV)

feeling good (CEV)

glad

5:13d

He should sing praises.

- then you^(sing) should sing songs of praise.
- should^(sing) sing songs of praise to God.
- you^(sing) should sing about how much you love/respect and honor God.

sing praises: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sing praises refers to praising God by singing any kind of psalm or hymn or spiritual song. It refers to expressing in words and song how much you love, respect, admire and honor God for who he is.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

sing songs of praise (NIV)

sing praises to the Lord (NLT96)

sing words that honor the Lord

James 5:14

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations. When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:13–16

In 5:13 James advised people to praise God or to pray to him, according to what kind of situation they are in. Then he gave them detailed instructions and encouraged them to pray for the sick (5:14–16).

5:14a

Is any one of you sick?

- If you are sick, (GW)
- Anyone who is sick (NCV)
- When you^(sing) are very ill,

Is any one of you sick?: This is a rhetorical question. James used this rhetorical question to begin talking about a particular situation. The situation is what to do when you are sick.

Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Are any among you sick? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Anyone who is sick (NCV)

Suppose one of you^(plur) is sick

Concerning people who are sick

- As a conditional clause. For example:

If you are sick (GW)

- As a temporal clause. For example:

When you are sick

Is...sick: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Is... sick here refers to someone who is very ill. He is so ill that he is unable to go to the elders of the church to ask them to pray for him. He has to call them to come to him. See Mitton, page 197; Martin, page 209; and Davids (1982), page 192.

5:14b

He should call the elders of the church

- you^(sing) should ask the church elders to come
- should tell the church leaders to come to his house.
- you^(sing) should invite the elders of your church to come.

He should call: The verb should call means “summon,” or “ask someone to come.” Some other ways to translate this verb are:

ask (CEV)

tell

invite

request to come

the elders of the church: The phrase the elders of the church means “the leaders of the church.” These men are not necessarily the oldest men.

The word elders also occurs in Acts 14:23, 20:17; 1 Timothy 5:17; and Titus 1:5.

the church: The word the church means the particular assembly of Christians of which the sick person is a member. Some other ways to translate the church are:

the community/family of God’s people

those who gather to worship God

5:14c to pray over him

- to pray for you.^(sing)
- They should pray to God for him/them
- They should pray for God to heal you^(sing)

to pray over him: This is the first command to the elders of the church. When a sick person calls them to come, they should go and pray for him.

Some other ways to translate pray over him are:

pray to God for him

They should pray for...the person (NCV)

They should come/go and pray for God to heal you

5:14d and anoint him with oil

- As they pray, they should put oil on you^(sing)
- and put oil on him as they pray
- and put oil on you^(sing) as they pray

and anoint him with oil: This is the second command to the elders of the church regarding a sick person.

In the time of James, it was common to treat a sick person by anointing him with oil. The oil was used as a medicine. It was also used symbolically.

Most commentators think that here the oil was used as a symbol of the healing power of God. It was poured or dripped onto the head of the person. Since the meaning is uncertain, it is recommended that you translate the phrase in a general way.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

put olive oil on you (CEV)

and pour oil on the person (NCV)

The structure of the Greek in 5:14 shows that praying is the important part of the whole process. The action of anointing is less important. For example, the RSV says:

let them pray over him, anointing him with oil

oil: The oil that people used was olive oil. It was the common oil of that country. You should use a term that refers to a common type of oil that people use for cooking or to put on their bodies. It should not be a term that refers to motor oil.

5:14e in the name of the Lord.

- with the authority of the Lord Jesus.
- using the power that the Lord Jesus had given to them.

in the name of the Lord: The phrase in the name of the Lord is connected to both the praying (in 5:14c) and the anointing (in 5:14d). The elders should both pray for and anoint the sick person in the name of the Lord. This means that they should pray and anoint with the authority that the Lord has given them. They should act on behalf of the Lord.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

with the Lord's power

using the Lord's authority

the Lord: The phrase the Lord refers to Jesus Christ. In the New Testament, healing was often done in the name of Jesus Christ. (For example, see Acts 3:6, 9:34.)

If you feel that it would be helpful to make clear that Lord refers to Jesus here, you could say:

the Lord Jesus Christ

Jesus, our Lord

See also Lord in the Glossary.

James 5:15

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations. When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:13–16

In 5:13 James advised people to praise God or to pray to him, according to what kind of situation they are in. Then he gave them detailed instructions and encouraged them to pray for the sick (5:14–16).

5:15a–b

the prayer offered in faith will restore the one who is sick: This sentence is a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, the prayer itself is said to heal the sick person. James meant that when the elders pray to the Lord, the Lord would heal the sick man.

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the personification. For example:

This prayer made in faith will heal the sick; (GNT)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

When they pray in faith, the Lord will heal the sick person.

5:15a**And the prayer offered in faith**

- The prayer that they ask/pray while trusting the Lord
- If they pray to God while trusting him to answer,
- And so when they pray to the Lord and trust that he will make you^(sing) well

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces the result of the elders' praying. Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

So then

As a result

And so

In some languages, no conjunction is necessary here.

the prayer offered in faith: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the prayer offered in faith is literally “the prayer of faith” (as in the RSV). This means that the elders who were praying needed to have faith or trust in God. James did not say what they should be trusting God for, but it is implied that they should trust him to heal the sick person. There are at least three ways to interpret the word faith here. (1) Some commentators say that faith here is faith that God will

heal the sick person. (2) Other commentators say that faith here is a more general faith. It is a belief that God is good, that he can be trusted, that he delights in answering prayer, and that he can answer prayer. (3) Other commentators say that faith here is an unwavering commitment to God and Jesus as the Messiah. For example:

when they pray to God and they trust that he will make the sick one well

See believe, meaning 3, in the Glossary.

the prayer: The phrase the prayer refers back to the prayer mentioned in 5:14. In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun prayer with a verb. For instance:

When they pray to God

offered: The word offered has been supplied by the BSB. It is formal language and simply means that the prayer is prayed or spoken to God. Another way to translate this is:

that is said (NCV)

If you translate the phrase “the prayer” with a verb, you do not need to translate the word offered.

in faith: The phrase in faith means “while believing.” Here it refers to the faith of those who are praying. In some languages, it is more natural to translate faith with a verb or clause. For example:

pray believing that the Lord will heal

trusting the Lord to heal the sick person

5:15b**will restore the one who is sick.**

- will cause you^(sing) to be healed.
- the sick person, he will be healed.
- you^(sing) will get well,

will restore: The Greek word that the BSB translates as will restore is literally “will save” (as in the RSV). In the context of a very sick person, it means “will heal,” or “will make well.” For example:

will heal (GNT)

will cure (GW)

will cause...to become well

See save, meaning 2, in the Glossary.

5:15c

The Lord will raise him up.

- The Lord will make you^(sing) well.
- The Lord will heal him.
- because the Lord Jesus will do it.

The Lord will raise him up: This clause explains the clause “will...make well” (in 5:15b). The elders’ prayer heals the sick person in the sense that the Lord Jesus responds to the prayer by healing the sick person.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and the Lord will make you well (NLT)

the Lord will heal that person (NCV)

The Lord: The phrase the Lord probably refers to Jesus Christ, as in 5:14e. Another way to translate this phrase is:

the Lord Jesus

5:15d

If he has sinned,

- If you^(sing) have sinned,
- And if he has disobeyed God,
- And if you^(sing) are sick because you have sinned

If he has sinned: The clause If he has sinned indicates that there was a possibility that the person had sinned and had not yet asked God to forgive him. It is implied that this sin may have something to do with his sickness. But do not translate this in such a way as to suggest that everyone who is sick has sinned.

sinned: The word sinned refers to doing something that is against God’s will and God’s law. This includes acts, thoughts, and attitudes. In other words, sin means to do anything that violates God’s standard of what is right or good.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

disobeyed God

done wrong

done something against God’s will

The noun sin occurs in 1:15b.

5:15e

he will be forgiven.

- you^(sing) will receive forgiveness from the Lord.
- God will forgive him.
- God will forgive your^(sing) sin.

he will be forgiven: This is a passive clause. James implied that the person would be forgiven by the Lord. So there are at least two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be forgiven (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the Lord will forgive him/you^(sing)

James 5:16

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations. When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:13–16

In 5:13 James advised people to praise God or to pray to him, according to what kind of situation they are in. Then he gave them detailed instructions and encouraged them to pray for the sick (5:14–16).

5:16a

Therefore confess your sins to each other

- Therefore, you^(plur) should confess/tell your sins to one another
- So you^(plur) believers should admit to other believers that you have disobeyed God.

Therefore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore here introduces a command to do something based on what James had just written. God heals sick people in answer to prayer, even if they have sinned (5:15). So people who are sick should seek to be healed by confessing their sins. For example:

So (GW)

For this reason

Because of that

On the basis of what I have just said

confess: The Greek word that the BSB translates as confess means “openly admit” to another person that one has disobeyed God. In this context, it does not mean praying silently to God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

admit (GW)

you should tell each other what you have done (CEV)

your sins: The word sins here refers to anything that a person has done that is contrary to God’s will and desire for his people. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the things that you have done wrong

your evil thoughts and deeds

your wrongs

to each other: The phrase to each other refers to other members of the church. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to one another

to your fellow believers

5:16b

and pray for each other

- and pray^(plur) for one another,

- Pray^(plur) to God for each other

and pray for each other: The word pray means “ask God.” In this context of a person confessing that he has sinned, the topic of the prayer is clear. Here pray for implies that they will ask God to forgive and heal this member of the church. Some other ways to translate this are:

and pray to God for one another

and ask God to heal and forgive you and your fellow believers

5:16c

so that you may be healed.

- so that you^(plur) will be cured.
- so that the Lord will make you^(plur) well.

so that you may be healed: The purpose of the prayer is so that you may be healed. It is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that you will be healed (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so God can heal you (NCV)

so that the Lord may heal you

5:16d

The prayer of a righteous man

- The prayer prayed/said by a righteous person
- When a person who is right with God prays,

The prayer: In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun prayer as a verb. For example:

When a believing person prays (NCV)

a righteous man: The phrase a righteous man means “a person who lives in the way that God requires.” Some other ways to translate this word are:

a person who does what is right/just

a person who follows/keeps God’s laws

a straight person

This same word occurs in 5:6a where the NIV translates it as “innocent men.” See righteous, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

5:16e

has great power to prevail.

- is very powerful and causes great things to happen.
- great results happen.

has great power to prevail: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as power to prevail indicates that when a righteous person prays, it causes great things to happen.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

has great power and produces wonderful results (NLT)

is powerful, and it can help a lot (CEV)

In some languages, it will be natural to translate power to prevail as one phrase that is emphasized. For example:

has great effectiveness (NET)

does great things

accomplishes a lot

is very powerful

James 5:17

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations. When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:17–18

James supported his advice to pray by giving the example of Elijah. Elijah received miracles in answer to his prayers.

5:17c

that it would not rain,

- that it should not rain,
- that God would stop rain from falling on the land of Israel.

5:17

As an example of powerful prayer, James used the story of the prophet Elijah. (See 1 Kings chapters 17–18.) This story was well known to James’ readers. Elijah saw how the people of his country had turned to evil, and so he prayed that God would punish them by sending no rain on their land.

5:17a

Elijah was a man just like us.

- ¶ Consider^(plur) Elijah. He was a human being, just as we^(incl) are.
- ¶ For example, the prophet Elijah was a human just like the rest of us.^(incl)

Elijah: Elijah was a prophet who lived 900 years before James. In some languages, it may be more natural to make some of this information explicit. For example:

Elijah the prophet

Elijah the prophet of long ago

was a man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man here means “human being.” For example:

was a human being (NCV)

was a mere human

just like us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as just like us means “has the same kind of desires and feelings as we do.” The Jews thought of Elijah as an extraordinary person, so James reminded them that he was a normal human being.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

as we are (CEV)

with a nature like ours (ESV)

the same kind of person as we are (GNT)

This word also occurs in Acts 14:15.

5:17b

He prayed earnestly

- He prayed sincerely/fervently
- He prayed to God very hard

He prayed earnestly: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He prayed earnestly is literally “He prayed with prayer.” This double use of the word “pray” intensifies what James was saying. He meant that when Elijah prayed, he was sincere, serious, and eager to receive an answer. Use what is natural in your language to indicate this intensity of prayer. Use an idiom if that is appropriate. For example, some English idioms for this are:

He prayed hard

He prayed with his whole heart

5:17d

and it did not rain on the land for three and a half years.

- and no rain fell on the land for three and a half years.
- So then there was no rain in the country of Israel for three and a half years.

it did not rain on the land: The phrase on the land refers to the land of Israel. The drought that God sent did not affect the whole world, but only the land of Israel.

James 5:18

Section 5:13–18: Believers should praise God and pray to him in faith

In this section, James talked about how believers should interact with God in all kinds of situations. When things are going well, they should praise him. When they need help, they should ask him for it.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

The Power of Prayer (NLT)

Prayer for the Sick (NET)

Think of God in all Situations

Pray to God in every Circumstance

Paragraph 5:17–18

James supported his advice to pray by giving the example of Elijah. Elijah received miracles in answer to his prayers.

5:18a

Again he prayed,

- Then he prayed again,
- Then when he asked God to send rain,

5:18b

and the heavens gave rain,

- and the rain came down from the sky,
- God caused it to rain,

the heavens gave rain: The phrase the heavens may refer to:

1. the clouds and the sky. For example:

rain came down from the sky (NCV)

1. God, who sent the rain. It did not just come automatically. (See 1 Samuel 12:17; 1 Kings 18:1; and Acts 14:17 for the idea of God giving rain.) For example:

God caused rain to fall

God again brought the rains to the land

In some languages, it may be natural to combine (a) and (b). For example:

God caused rain to fall from the sky

See heaven, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

5:18c

and the earth yielded its crops.

- and the ground/fields produced crops.
- and caused the crops/plants to grow again.

the earth yielded its crops: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the earth here means “the ground,” “the soil,” or “the land.” After the rains came again, in due course the ground produced the crops that it normally produced.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and the land produced crops again (NCV)

and the fields/farms grew plants

and the crops grew well in the fields

In some languages, it is not necessary to translate the phrase the earth. For example:

and the crops began to grow again (NLT96)

James 5:19

Section 5:19–20: James encouraged believers to help the person who is no longer obeying God to obey him again

In this final section of James' epistle, he encouraged his readers to help any fellow Christians who had stopped obeying God to begin to obey him again.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Help Those Who Have Wandered Away from the Truth (GW)

Restore Wandering Believers (NLT)

Help people return to obeying God

Paragraph 5:19–20

The two verses of this paragraph are all one sentence in the Greek text. In 5:19 James described figuratively something that may happen to a Christian: a person strays away from God, and someone brings him back. In 5:20 James commented that bringing this person back into a relationship with God is a worthwhile thing to do.

5:19a

My brothers, if one of you should wander from the truth

- ¶ My brothers, if anyone among you^(plur) strays from the path of truth,
- ¶ My fellow believers, if one of you^(plur) stops obeying the true teachings of God,

My brothers: Here James used the phrase My brothers to emphasize the following point and to introduce a new topic.

This phrase also occurs in 5:12a.

if one of you should wander from the truth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wander means that a person “strays from,” “leaves” or “abandons” the correct path. This is a figure of speech meaning that a person is no longer following God nor living a life that pleases him.

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

if one of you strays from the truth (REB)

if one of you leaves the path of truth

- Translate the meaning. For example:

If one of you believers no longer obeys the true teachings about/ from God

one of you: The phrase one of you refers to a member of the Christian community.

the truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the truth here refers to the true way of life. This is the way that is taught in God's word. It is the true teaching of God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

true/straight teaching

God's ways

the way that God wants us to live

following what God teaches us to believe and do

This word also occurs in 3:14d.

5:19b

and someone should bring him back,

- and if someone goes and brings him back to the true path,
- and if someone helps/causes him to repent and return to God,

and someone should bring him back: This clause is a second part of the condition. In other words, the word “if” is implied. For example:

and if someone should bring him back

James continued to use figurative language. He spoke of someone helping another person to find the right path again. He meant helping this other person to recognize that he was no longer living as a Christian should. This person helps the other to repent and again live the way a true Christian should live.

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

you should try to lead them back. (CEV)

and if someone helps him follow God's path again

- Translate the meaning. For example:

and if someone helps him to repent

if someone encourages him to obey the truth again

(See the General Comment on 5:19–20 at the end of 5:20d for a way to make this a separate sentence.)

James 5:20

Section 5:19–20: James encouraged believers to help the person who is no longer obeying God to obey him again

In this final section of James' epistle, he encouraged his readers to help any fellow Christians who had stopped obeying God to begin to obey him again.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Help Those Who Have Wandered Away from the Truth (GW)

Restore Wandering Believers (NLT)

Help people return to obeying God

Paragraph 5:19–20

The two verses of this paragraph are all one sentence in the Greek text. In 5:19 James described figuratively something that may happen to a Christian: a person strays away from God, and someone brings him back. In 5:20 James commented that bringing this person back into a relationship with God is a worthwhile thing to do.

5:20a consider this:

- he should know/realize that
- that person may be sure that

consider this: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek texts have "He should know." Huther, page 226; Ropes, page 315; Hiebert, pages 334–335; Mitton, page 212; Adamson (1976), page 203; Laws, pages 239–240; Davids (1982), page 199; Martin, page 217. This is the reading of most editions of the Greek text, including the UBS 3rd ed. and 4th ed. For example, the RSV says:

let him know that (RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV, NET)

1. Other Greek texts have "You^(plur) should know." Alford, page 329; Mayor, page 176. This is the reading of Nestle's 25th ed. and the UBS 1st ed. Greek texts. For example, the GNT says:

remember this (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, REB, GW, NLT, NCV)

The evidence shows that option (1) is more likely to be the original text. It means that the person who brings his Christian brother back to believing and obeying God's truth should know that he has done a good thing. To reflect this meaning, the NET translation is used as the source line in the Display.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

may he realize that

he can be sure that

5:20b

Whoever turns a sinner from the error of his way

- whoever brings a sinner back from his wandering/straying path
- anyone who helps/causes an evildoer to return to God from his sin

In 5:20b, James continued to use the same figures of speech about wandering away and someone bringing the person back.

Whoever turns: The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as turns is the same as the word translated as "bring back" in 5:19b. For example:

whoever brings a sinner back (GW)

a sinner: The word sinner refers to a person who habitually disobeys God. Some other ways to translate this word are:

a sinful person

someone who disobeys God

a person who does evil

See the note at 4:8c for more information.

from the error of his way: The Greek word that the BSB translates as error is the noun form of the verb translated “wander” in 5:19a. The phrase his way refers to the path that he has taken. It means the kind of life he has been living. So the whole phrase refers to returning the sinner back “from the wandering/straying path.” It means to help the sinner repent from his life or behavior that no longer pleases God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

from his wandering path (NET)

from his wandering (ESV)

from the wrong way (NCV)

from his wrong living

from doing bad things

In some languages, it may be possible to leave this phrase implicit. For example:

^{20b}whoever brings the sinner back ^{20c}will save that person (NLT)

5:20c

will save his soul from death

- saves that person from eternal death.
- rescues that person from hell.

will save his soul from death: The phrase that the BSB translates literally as will save his soul from death means that the person whose words and prayers help the sinner stop sinning and return to obeying God “will save the sinner from dying.” In this context of “saving his soul,” death refers to spiritual death. It is being eternally separated from God.

Some ways to make it clear that this refers to spiritual death are:

will save that sinner’s soul from death (NCV)

will save the soul of that sinner so that he does not go to hell

will rescue from eternal death the one who has been doing evil

In some languages, it is more natural to translate the noun death with a verb. For example:

will keep him from dying spiritually

save him from being punished eternally

save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save here means “rescue” or “deliver.” The righteous person will be the means that God uses to save from spiritual death the person who went astray. See save, meaning 1, in the Glossary.

his soul: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as his soul means his real inner self, in contrast to his body. This is the part of the person that is eternal. Here his soul refers to the soul of the sinner who has turned from the error of his ways.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

him

5:20d

and cover over a multitude of sins.

- He causes God not to look at that person’s many evil deeds anymore.
- God will forgive the many sins of the one he brought back.

cover over: This is a figure of speech. The righteous person covers over the sins of the person who has wandered from the path of God’s way to live. This implies that God decides not to look at those sins anymore. It means that God forgives the sins. It does not mean that the righteous person has hidden the other person’s sins from God.

There are at least two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

and will cover a multitude of sins (NRSV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

and will cause many sins to be forgiven. (NCV)

and God will forgive his many sins.

a multitude of sins: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a multitude of sins means “very many sins.” Make sure that in your language this expression does not mean “most but not all.” James did not mean that some sins would not be covered. All will be forgiven.

General Comment on 5:19–20

In some languages, it may be natural to break up this long sentence into two or more smaller sentences. For example:

^{19a}My brothers, perhaps one of you will wander from the truth. ^{19b}If that happens, someone can bring that person back. ^{20a}He should know that ^{20b}whoever brings a sinner back from the error of his ways ^{20c}will save him from death. ^{20d}Also, his many sins will be forgiven.